

SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

India and the Neighbourhood - Solved Practice Workbook

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

India and the Neighbourhood	
REFRESHED TEACHING NAVIGATION — BASIC/CORE FIRST	
01	FOUNDATION — WHAT THE NEIGHBOURHOOD OWNER HOLDS AND HOW ITS SCOPE IS Prelims: Retain the exact actor, document title, doctrine label, dated
02	FOUNDATION — THE EIGHT BORDERING NEIGHBOURS AND AFGHANISTAN AS A Evidence chain: India's eight bordering neighbours and Afghanistan
03	FOUNDATION — NEIGHBOURHOOD FIRST AND THE GUJRAT DOCTRINE'S FIVE PRINCIPLES Neighbourhood First is India's stated policy priority of engaging South
04	CORE — ASYMMETRY AND THE REGIONAL-FRAMEWORK PREFERENCE OF Evidence chain: Asymmetric interdependence as the structural
05	CORE — REGIME ORIENTATION, SOCIETY ORIENTATION AND THE INVOLVEMENT Evidence chain: Regime-oriented against people-to-people
06	CORE — BANGLADESH CONNECTIVITY AND THE BBIN SUBREGIONAL INSTRUMENT The Akhaura-Agartala cross-border rail link was inaugurated on 1
07	CORE — BHUTAN HYDROPOWER AND THE CURRENT COMMITMENT SET Evidence chain: Bhutan hydropower and the current commitment set
08	CORE — FEDERAL CONSTRAINT AND THE SEGMENT-AGAINST-CORRIDOR DISTINCTION Evidence chain: Teesta and the federal constraint on neighbourhood
09	CORE — SRI LANKA'S CURRENT INSTRUMENT SET AND ITS PRE-DELIVERY STATUS During the Prime Minister's visit of 5 April 2025 seven memoranda of
10	CORE — MALDIVES INSTRUMENTS AND THE MARITIME CROSS-LINK Evidence chain: Maldives instruments and the maritime cross-link
11	CORE — SRI LANKA'S 2022 CRISIS AS THE FIRST-RESPONDER EVIDENCE SET Mains: Distinguish emergency assistance from durable partnership
12	CORE — BANGLADESH'S TRANSITION AND THE GANGA WATERS TREATY HORIZON India engaged Bangladesh's interim government from 16 August 2024
13	CORE SYNTHESIS — NEPAL'S TRANSITION AND AFGHANISTAN'S Evidence chain: Nepal's transition and the power-trade understanding
14	CORE SYNTHESIS — PAKISTAN, WATER SECURITY AND THE LIMITS OF Mains: Qualify the Gujral Doctrine by showing when accommodation
15	CORE SYNTHESIS — IMPLEMENTATION CREDIBILITY, THE OUTSIDE-POWER VARIABLE Evidence chain: The implementation-credibility test, the

Original deterministic study visual; labels are explanatory, not textual quotations.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

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BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

Q1. Which statement correctly identifies What this owner holds and how its scope is bounded?

A. This topic owns India's engagement with Bangladesh, Bhutan, Nepal, Sri Lanka, Myanmar, Pakistan and Afghanistan, together with the Neighbourhood First policy, the Gujral Doctrine, and the development, connectivity and people-to-people instruments that carry them, and its distinctive feature is that it is simultaneously doctrinal and heavily evidence-bound: one General Studies Paper II Mains demand from 2022 is routed to it in the audited ledgers alongside four objective demands from 2020, 2023 and 2026; Maldives is deliberately cross-linked to topic 04 because its salience is primarily maritime, the SAARC and BIMSTEC institutional comparison is reserved for topic 10, and the physical border and route geography belongs to the Geography owner. B. Tharoor counts Pakistan, China, Nepal, Bhutan, Bangladesh, Myanmar, Sri Lanka and Maldives as sharing a land or maritime border with India, and adds Afghanistan as a near-neighbour because Pakistan's capture in 1948 of a strip of north-western Kashmir made Afghanistan territorially adjacent, and he separately records that of the eight bordering states there has been a history of problems, of varying degrees of difficulty, with six; the examinable consequence is that neighbourhood in Indian strategic practice is defined by security relevance and not only by strict territorial contiguity, and that friction is a structural feature rather than an aberration. C. Neighbourhood First is India's stated policy priority of engaging South Asian neighbours ahead of more distant partners through connectivity, development assistance and people-to-people ties, delivered by prime-ministerial visits, policy statements, lines of credit, power-grid interlinkage, transit and transport protocols and river-water cooperation, with readiness for humanitarian assistance and disaster relief built in; the qualification the owners insist upon is that the doctrine is not applied identically to every neighbour, because its emphasis is calibrated by the partner's size, history and current politics. D. The Gujral Doctrine, associated with former Prime Minister I. K. Gujral, is a five-principle approach under which India does not seek reciprocity from smaller neighbours, does not interfere in their internal affairs, does not allow its territory to be used against them, respects their territorial integrity, and settles disputes bilaterally and peacefully, and it remains the standard doctrinal reference for South Asia policy; the defining feature that examiners test is non-reciprocal accommodation, so any statement that the doctrine demands reciprocity as a precondition for cooperation inverts its meaning exactly.

Answer: A. Explanation: This topic owns India's engagement with Bangladesh, Bhutan, Nepal, Sri Lanka, Myanmar, Pakistan and Afghanistan, together with the Neighbourhood First policy, the Gujral Doctrine, and the development, connectivity and people-to-people instruments that carry them, and its distinctive feature is that it is simultaneously doctrinal and heavily evidence-bound: one General Studies Paper II Mains demand from 2022 is routed to it in the audited ledgers alongside four objective demands from 2020, 2023 and 2026; Maldives is deliberately cross-linked to topic 04 because its salience is primarily maritime, the SAARC and BIMSTEC institutional comparison is reserved for topic 10, and the physical border and route geography belongs to the Geography owner. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q2. Which card should be filed under What this owner holds and how its scope is bounded in an International Relations answer?

A. India is larger in economy, population and military capacity than its entire immediate neighbourhood combined, and the owners treat this asymmetry as the structural condition that shapes how smaller states balance cooperation with India against anxiety about dependence, so the Gujral Doctrine is best read as a response to that anxiety rather than as generosity for its own sake; the analytical move that raises an answer is to treat asymmetry as a design problem to be converted into reliable public goods, instead of treating size disparity as inherently adversarial. B. This topic owns India's engagement with Bangladesh, Bhutan, Nepal, Sri Lanka, Myanmar, Pakistan and Afghanistan, together with the Neighbourhood First policy, the Gujral Doctrine, and the development, connectivity and people-to-people instruments that carry them, and its distinctive feature is that it is simultaneously doctrinal and heavily evidence-bound: one General Studies Paper II Mains demand from 2022 is routed to it in the audited ledgers alongside four objective demands from 2020, 2023 and 2026; Maldives is deliberately cross-linked to topic 04 because its salience is primarily maritime, the SAARC and BIMSTEC institutional comparison is reserved for topic 10, and the physical border and route geography belongs to the Geography owner. C. The Gujral Doctrine, associated

with former Prime Minister I. K. Gujral, is a five-principle approach under which India does not seek reciprocity from smaller neighbours, does not interfere in their internal affairs, does not allow its territory to be used against them, respects their territorial integrity, and settles disputes bilaterally and peacefully, and it remains the standard doctrinal reference for South Asia policy; the defining feature that examiners test is non-reciprocal accommodation, so any statement that the doctrine demands reciprocity as a precondition for cooperation inverts its meaning exactly. D. Neighbourhood First is India's stated policy priority of engaging South Asian neighbours ahead of more distant partners through connectivity, development assistance and people-to-people ties, delivered by prime-ministerial visits, policy statements, lines of credit, power-grid interlinkage, transit and transport protocols and river-water cooperation, with readiness for humanitarian assistance and disaster relief built in; the qualification the owners insist upon is that the doctrine is not applied identically to every neighbour, because its emphasis is calibrated by the partner's size, history and current politics.

Answer: B. Explanation: This topic owns India's engagement with Bangladesh, Bhutan, Nepal, Sri Lanka, Myanmar, Pakistan and Afghanistan, together with the Neighbourhood First policy, the Gujral Doctrine, and the development, connectivity and people-to-people instruments that carry them, and its distinctive feature is that it is simultaneously doctrinal and heavily evidence-bound: one General Studies Paper II Mains demand from 2022 is routed to it in the audited ledgers alongside four objective demands from 2020, 2023 and 2026; Maldives is deliberately cross-linked to topic 04 because its salience is primarily maritime, the SAARC and BIMSTEC institutional comparison is reserved for topic 10, and the physical border and route geography belongs to the Geography owner. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q3. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of What this owner holds and how its scope is bounded?

A. India is larger in economy, population and military capacity than its entire immediate neighbourhood combined, and the owners treat this asymmetry as the structural condition that shapes how smaller states balance cooperation with India against anxiety about dependence, so the Gujral Doctrine is best read as a response to that anxiety rather than as generosity for its own sake; the analytical move that raises an answer is to treat asymmetry as a design problem to be converted into reliable public goods, instead of treating size disparity as inherently adversarial. B. The Gujral Doctrine, associated with former Prime Minister I. K. Gujral, is a five-principle approach under which India does not seek reciprocity from smaller neighbours, does not interfere in their internal affairs, does not allow its territory to be used against them, respects their territorial integrity, and settles disputes bilaterally and peacefully, and it remains the standard doctrinal reference for South Asia policy; the defining feature that examiners test is non-reciprocal accommodation, so any statement that the doctrine demands reciprocity as a precondition for cooperation inverts its meaning exactly. C. This topic owns India's engagement with Bangladesh, Bhutan, Nepal, Sri Lanka, Myanmar, Pakistan and Afghanistan, together with the Neighbourhood First policy, the Gujral Doctrine, and the development, connectivity and people-to-people instruments that carry them, and its distinctive feature is that it is simultaneously doctrinal and heavily evidence-bound: one General Studies Paper II Mains demand from 2022 is routed to it in the audited ledgers alongside four objective demands from 2020, 2023 and 2026; Maldives is deliberately cross-linked to topic 04 because its salience is primarily maritime, the SAARC and BIMSTEC institutional comparison is reserved for topic 10, and the physical border and route geography belongs to the Geography owner. D. Sikri records that smaller neighbours like Bhutan, Nepal, Maldives and Sri Lanka have shown greater interest in economic integration with India than the larger ones like Pakistan and Bangladesh, and that they are more receptive to cooperation within a regional framework than on a bilateral basis because numbers give them a sense of greater security, which the owners treat as a structural rather than merely tactical preference; the necessary qualification is that this preference does not amount to rejecting bilateral engagement, because the substantive connectivity work still proceeds bilaterally while the regional overlay supplies political reassurance.

Answer: C. Explanation: This topic owns India's engagement with Bangladesh, Bhutan, Nepal, Sri Lanka, Myanmar, Pakistan and Afghanistan, together with the Neighbourhood First policy, the Gujral Doctrine, and the development, connectivity and people-to-people instruments that carry them, and its distinctive feature is that it is simultaneously doctrinal and heavily evidence-bound: one General Studies Paper II Mains demand from 2022 is routed to it in the audited ledgers alongside four objective demands from 2020, 2023 and 2026; Maldives is deliberately cross-linked to topic 04 because its salience is primarily maritime, the SAARC and BIMSTEC institutional comparison is reserved for topic 10, and the physical border and route geography

belongs to the Geography owner. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q4. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about What this owner holds and how its scope is bounded?

A. Sikri argues that India must move away from its excessive regime-oriented policies towards people-to-people relations on the reasoning that only neighbouring regimes which reflect their own people's interests are likely to sustain friendly relations with India, and the owners convert this into the operative test of Neighbourhood First, namely whether engagement survives a change of government in the partner state; the regime-orientation trap emerges when engagement depends too heavily on one incumbent, producing discontinuity whenever that incumbent changes, and the people-to-people reorientation is presented as a partial mitigation rather than a guarantee. B. Sikri records that smaller neighbours like Bhutan, Nepal, Maldives and Sri Lanka have shown greater interest in economic integration with India than the larger ones like Pakistan and Bangladesh, and that they are more receptive to cooperation within a regional framework than on a bilateral basis because numbers give them a sense of greater security, which the owners treat as a structural rather than merely tactical preference; the necessary qualification is that this preference does not amount to rejecting bilateral engagement, because the substantive connectivity work still proceeds bilaterally while the regional overlay supplies political reassurance. C. India is larger in economy, population and military capacity than its entire immediate neighbourhood combined, and the owners treat this asymmetry as the structural condition that shapes how smaller states balance cooperation with India against anxiety about dependence, so the Gujral Doctrine is best read as a response to that anxiety rather than as generosity for its own sake; the analytical move that raises an answer is to treat asymmetry as a design problem to be converted into reliable public goods, instead of treating size disparity as inherently adversarial. D. This topic owns India's engagement with Bangladesh, Bhutan, Nepal, Sri Lanka, Myanmar, Pakistan and Afghanistan, together with the Neighbourhood First policy, the Gujral Doctrine, and the development, connectivity and people-to-people instruments that carry them, and its distinctive feature is that it is simultaneously doctrinal and heavily evidence-bound: one General Studies Paper II Mains demand from 2022 is routed to it in the audited ledgers alongside four objective demands from 2020, 2023 and 2026; Maldives is deliberately cross-linked to topic 04 because its salience is primarily maritime, the SAARC and BIMSTEC institutional comparison is reserved for topic 10, and the physical border and route geography belongs to the Geography owner.

Answer: D. Explanation: This topic owns India's engagement with Bangladesh, Bhutan, Nepal, Sri Lanka, Myanmar, Pakistan and Afghanistan, together with the Neighbourhood First policy, the Gujral Doctrine, and the development, connectivity and people-to-people instruments that carry them, and its distinctive feature is that it is simultaneously doctrinal and heavily evidence-bound: one General Studies Paper II Mains demand from 2022 is routed to it in the audited ledgers alongside four objective demands from 2020, 2023 and 2026; Maldives is deliberately cross-linked to topic 04 because its salience is primarily maritime, the SAARC and BIMSTEC institutional comparison is reserved for topic 10, and the physical border and route geography belongs to the Geography owner. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q5. Which statement correctly identifies India's eight bordering neighbours and Afghanistan as a near-neighbour?

A. Tharoor counts Pakistan, China, Nepal, Bhutan, Bangladesh, Myanmar, Sri Lanka and Maldives as sharing a land or maritime border with India, and adds Afghanistan as a near-neighbour because Pakistan's capture in 1948 of a strip of north-western Kashmir made Afghanistan territorially adjacent, and he separately records that of the eight bordering states there has been a history of problems, of varying degrees of difficulty, with six; the examinable consequence is that neighbourhood in Indian strategic practice is defined by security relevance and not only by strict territorial contiguity, and that friction is a structural feature rather than an aberration. B. The Gujral Doctrine, associated with former Prime Minister I. K. Gujral, is a five-principle approach under which India does not seek reciprocity from smaller neighbours, does not interfere in their internal affairs, does not allow its territory to be used against them, respects their territorial integrity, and settles disputes bilaterally and peacefully, and it remains the standard doctrinal reference for South Asia policy; the defining feature that examiners test is non-reciprocal accommodation, so any statement that the doctrine demands reciprocity as a precondition for cooperation inverts its meaning exactly. C. Neighbourhood First is India's stated policy priority of engaging South Asian neighbours ahead of more distant partners through

connectivity, development assistance and people-to-people ties, delivered by prime-ministerial visits, policy statements, lines of credit, power-grid interlinkage, transit and transport protocols and river-water cooperation, with readiness for humanitarian assistance and disaster relief built in; the qualification the owners insist upon is that the doctrine is not applied identically to every neighbour, because its emphasis is calibrated by the partner's size, history and current politics. D. India is larger in economy, population and military capacity than its entire immediate neighbourhood combined, and the owners treat this asymmetry as the structural condition that shapes how smaller states balance cooperation with India against anxiety about dependence, so the Gujral Doctrine is best read as a response to that anxiety rather than as generosity for its own sake; the analytical move that raises an answer is to treat asymmetry as a design problem to be converted into reliable public goods, instead of treating size disparity as inherently adversarial.

Answer: A. Explanation: Tharoor counts Pakistan, China, Nepal, Bhutan, Bangladesh, Myanmar, Sri Lanka and Maldives as sharing a land or maritime border with India, and adds Afghanistan as a near-neighbour because Pakistan's capture in 1948 of a strip of north-western Kashmir made Afghanistan territorially adjacent, and he separately records that of the eight bordering states there has been a history of problems, of varying degrees of difficulty, with six; the examinable consequence is that neighbourhood in Indian strategic practice is defined by security relevance and not only by strict territorial contiguity, and that friction is a structural feature rather than an aberration. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q6. Which card should be filed under India's eight bordering neighbours and Afghanistan as a near-neighbour in an International Relations answer?

A. Sikri records that smaller neighbours like Bhutan, Nepal, Maldives and Sri Lanka have shown greater interest in economic integration with India than the larger ones like Pakistan and Bangladesh, and that they are more receptive to cooperation within a regional framework than on a bilateral basis because numbers give them a sense of greater security, which the owners treat as a structural rather than merely tactical preference; the necessary qualification is that this preference does not amount to rejecting bilateral engagement, because the substantive connectivity work still proceeds bilaterally while the regional overlay supplies political reassurance. B. Tharoor counts Pakistan, China, Nepal, Bhutan, Bangladesh, Myanmar, Sri Lanka and Maldives as sharing a land or maritime border with India, and adds Afghanistan as a near-neighbour because Pakistan's capture in 1948 of a strip of north-western Kashmir made Afghanistan territorially adjacent, and he separately records that of the eight bordering states there has been a history of problems, of varying degrees of difficulty, with six; the examinable consequence is that neighbourhood in Indian strategic practice is defined by security relevance and not only by strict territorial contiguity, and that friction is a structural feature rather than an aberration. C. India is larger in economy, population and military capacity than its entire immediate neighbourhood combined, and the owners treat this asymmetry as the structural condition that shapes how smaller states balance cooperation with India against anxiety about dependence, so the Gujral Doctrine is best read as a response to that anxiety rather than as generosity for its own sake; the analytical move that raises an answer is to treat asymmetry as a design problem to be converted into reliable public goods, instead of treating size disparity as inherently adversarial. D. The Gujral Doctrine, associated with former Prime Minister I. K. Gujral, is a five-principle approach under which India does not seek reciprocity from smaller neighbours, does not interfere in their internal affairs, does not allow its territory to be used against them, respects their territorial integrity, and settles disputes bilaterally and peacefully, and it remains the standard doctrinal reference for South Asia policy; the defining feature that examiners test is non-reciprocal accommodation, so any statement that the doctrine demands reciprocity as a precondition for cooperation inverts its meaning exactly.

Answer: B. Explanation: Tharoor counts Pakistan, China, Nepal, Bhutan, Bangladesh, Myanmar, Sri Lanka and Maldives as sharing a land or maritime border with India, and adds Afghanistan as a near-neighbour because Pakistan's capture in 1948 of a strip of north-western Kashmir made Afghanistan territorially adjacent, and he separately records that of the eight bordering states there has been a history of problems, of varying degrees of difficulty, with six; the examinable consequence is that neighbourhood in Indian strategic practice is defined by security relevance and not only by strict territorial contiguity, and that friction is a structural feature rather than an aberration. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q7. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of India's eight bordering neighbours and Afghanistan as a near-neighbour?

A. Sikri records that smaller neighbours like Bhutan, Nepal, Maldives and Sri Lanka have shown greater interest in economic integration with India than the larger ones like Pakistan and Bangladesh, and that they are more receptive to cooperation within a regional framework than on a bilateral basis because numbers give them a sense of greater security, which the owners treat as a structural rather than merely tactical preference; the necessary qualification is that this preference does not amount to rejecting bilateral engagement, because the substantive connectivity work still proceeds bilaterally while the regional overlay supplies political reassurance. B. India is larger in economy, population and military capacity than its entire immediate neighbourhood combined, and the owners treat this asymmetry as the structural condition that shapes how smaller states balance cooperation with India against anxiety about dependence, so the Gujral Doctrine is best read as a response to that anxiety rather than as generosity for its own sake; the analytical move that raises an answer is to treat asymmetry as a design problem to be converted into reliable public goods, instead of treating size disparity as inherently adversarial. C. Tharoor counts Pakistan, China, Nepal, Bhutan, Bangladesh, Myanmar, Sri Lanka and Maldives as sharing a land or maritime border with India, and adds Afghanistan as a near-neighbour because Pakistan's capture in 1948 of a strip of north-western Kashmir made Afghanistan territorially adjacent, and he separately records that of the eight bordering states there has been a history of problems, of varying degrees of difficulty, with six; the examinable consequence is that neighbourhood in Indian strategic practice is defined by security relevance and not only by strict territorial contiguity, and that friction is a structural feature rather than an aberration. D. Sikri argues that India must move away from its excessive regime-oriented policies towards people-to-people relations on the reasoning that only neighbouring regimes which reflect their own people's interests are likely to sustain friendly relations with India, and the owners convert this into the operative test of Neighbourhood First, namely whether engagement survives a change of government in the partner state; the regime-orientation trap emerges when engagement depends too heavily on one incumbent, producing discontinuity whenever that incumbent changes, and the people-to-people reorientation is presented as a partial mitigation rather than a guarantee.

Answer: C. Explanation: Tharoor counts Pakistan, China, Nepal, Bhutan, Bangladesh, Myanmar, Sri Lanka and Maldives as sharing a land or maritime border with India, and adds Afghanistan as a near-neighbour because Pakistan's capture in 1948 of a strip of north-western Kashmir made Afghanistan territorially adjacent, and he separately records that of the eight bordering states there has been a history of problems, of varying degrees of difficulty, with six; the examinable consequence is that neighbourhood in Indian strategic practice is defined by security relevance and not only by strict territorial contiguity, and that friction is a structural feature rather than an aberration. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q8. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about India's eight bordering neighbours and Afghanistan as a near-neighbour?

A. Sikri records that smaller neighbours like Bhutan, Nepal, Maldives and Sri Lanka have shown greater interest in economic integration with India than the larger ones like Pakistan and Bangladesh, and that they are more receptive to cooperation within a regional framework than on a bilateral basis because numbers give them a sense of greater security, which the owners treat as a structural rather than merely tactical preference; the necessary qualification is that this preference does not amount to rejecting bilateral engagement, because the substantive connectivity work still proceeds bilaterally while the regional overlay supplies political reassurance. B. Sikri states that India has no alternative but to closely follow and deeply analyze political trends in neighbouring countries because their domestic developments have an effect on India itself, and he cites India as the decisive factor in seeking a resolution of domestic political crises in Bangladesh in 1971, Sri Lanka in 1987 and Nepal in 1950-51 and subsequent crises; the owners require that these be treated as historical references rather than a standing doctrine of intervention, and that the resulting tension with the Gujral Doctrine's non-interference principle be acknowledged explicitly instead of being smoothed into one consistent posture. C. Sikri argues that India must move away from its excessive regime-oriented policies towards people-to-people relations on the reasoning that only neighbouring regimes which reflect their own people's interests are likely to sustain friendly relations with India, and the owners convert this into the operative test of Neighbourhood First, namely whether engagement survives a change of government in the partner state; the regime-orientation trap emerges when engagement depends too heavily on one incumbent, producing discontinuity whenever that incumbent changes, and the people-to-people reorientation is presented as a partial mitigation rather

than a guarantee. D. Tharoor counts Pakistan, China, Nepal, Bhutan, Bangladesh, Myanmar, Sri Lanka and Maldives as sharing a land or maritime border with India, and adds Afghanistan as a near-neighbour because Pakistan's capture in 1948 of a strip of north-western Kashmir made Afghanistan territorially adjacent, and he separately records that of the eight bordering states there has been a history of problems, of varying degrees of difficulty, with six; the examinable consequence is that neighbourhood in Indian strategic practice is defined by security relevance and not only by strict territorial contiguity, and that friction is a structural feature rather than an aberration.

Answer: D. Explanation: Tharoor counts Pakistan, China, Nepal, Bhutan, Bangladesh, Myanmar, Sri Lanka and Maldives as sharing a land or maritime border with India, and adds Afghanistan as a near-neighbour because Pakistan's capture in 1948 of a strip of north-western Kashmir made Afghanistan territorially adjacent, and he separately records that of the eight bordering states there has been a history of problems, of varying degrees of difficulty, with six; the examinable consequence is that neighbourhood in Indian strategic practice is defined by security relevance and not only by strict territorial contiguity, and that friction is a structural feature rather than an aberration. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q9. Which statement correctly identifies Neighbourhood First as a stated priority policy?

A. Neighbourhood First is India's stated policy priority of engaging South Asian neighbours ahead of more distant partners through connectivity, development assistance and people-to-people ties, delivered by prime-ministerial visits, policy statements, lines of credit, power-grid interlinkage, transit and transport protocols and river-water cooperation, with readiness for humanitarian assistance and disaster relief built in; the qualification the owners insist upon is that the doctrine is not applied identically to every neighbour, because its emphasis is calibrated by the partner's size, history and current politics. B. India is larger in economy, population and military capacity than its entire immediate neighbourhood combined, and the owners treat this asymmetry as the structural condition that shapes how smaller states balance cooperation with India against anxiety about dependence, so the Gujral Doctrine is best read as a response to that anxiety rather than as generosity for its own sake; the analytical move that raises an answer is to treat asymmetry as a design problem to be converted into reliable public goods, instead of treating size disparity as inherently adversarial. C. The Gujral Doctrine, associated with former Prime Minister I. K. Gujral, is a five-principle approach under which India does not seek reciprocity from smaller neighbours, does not interfere in their internal affairs, does not allow its territory to be used against them, respects their territorial integrity, and settles disputes bilaterally and peacefully, and it remains the standard doctrinal reference for South Asia policy; the defining feature that examiners test is non-reciprocal accommodation, so any statement that the doctrine demands reciprocity as a precondition for cooperation inverts its meaning exactly. D. Sikri records that smaller neighbours like Bhutan, Nepal, Maldives and Sri Lanka have shown greater interest in economic integration with India than the larger ones like Pakistan and Bangladesh, and that they are more receptive to cooperation within a regional framework than on a bilateral basis because numbers give them a sense of greater security, which the owners treat as a structural rather than merely tactical preference; the necessary qualification is that this preference does not amount to rejecting bilateral engagement, because the substantive connectivity work still proceeds bilaterally while the regional overlay supplies political reassurance.

Answer: A. Explanation: Neighbourhood First is India's stated policy priority of engaging South Asian neighbours ahead of more distant partners through connectivity, development assistance and people-to-people ties, delivered by prime-ministerial visits, policy statements, lines of credit, power-grid interlinkage, transit and transport protocols and river-water cooperation, with readiness for humanitarian assistance and disaster relief built in; the qualification the owners insist upon is that the doctrine is not applied identically to every neighbour, because its emphasis is calibrated by the partner's size, history and current politics. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q10. Which card should be filed under Neighbourhood First as a stated priority policy in an International Relations answer?

A. India is larger in economy, population and military capacity than its entire immediate neighbourhood combined, and the owners treat this asymmetry as the structural condition that shapes how smaller states balance cooperation with India against anxiety about dependence, so the Gujral Doctrine is best read as a response to that anxiety rather than as generosity for its own sake; the analytical move that raises an answer is to treat asymmetry as a design problem to be converted into reliable public goods, instead of treating size disparity as inherently adversarial. B. Neighbourhood First is India's stated policy priority of engaging South Asian neighbours ahead of more distant partners through connectivity, development assistance and people-to-people ties, delivered by prime-ministerial visits, policy statements, lines of credit, power-grid interlinkage, transit and transport protocols and river-water cooperation, with readiness for humanitarian assistance and disaster relief built in; the qualification the owners insist upon is that the doctrine is not applied identically to every neighbour, because its emphasis is calibrated by the partner's size, history and current politics. C. Sikri records that smaller neighbours like Bhutan, Nepal, Maldives and Sri Lanka have shown greater interest in economic integration with India than the larger ones like Pakistan and Bangladesh, and that they are more receptive to cooperation within a regional framework than on a bilateral basis because numbers give them a sense of greater security, which the owners treat as a structural rather than merely tactical preference; the necessary qualification is that this preference does not amount to rejecting bilateral engagement, because the substantive connectivity work still proceeds bilaterally while the regional overlay supplies political reassurance. D. Sikri argues that India must move away from its excessive regime-oriented policies towards people-to-people relations on the reasoning that only neighbouring regimes which reflect their own people's interests are likely to sustain friendly relations with India, and the owners convert this into the operative test of Neighbourhood First, namely whether engagement survives a change of government in the partner state; the regime-orientation trap emerges when engagement depends too heavily on one incumbent, producing discontinuity whenever that incumbent changes, and the people-to-people reorientation is presented as a partial mitigation rather than a guarantee.

Answer: B. Explanation: Neighbourhood First is India's stated policy priority of engaging South Asian neighbours ahead of more distant partners through connectivity, development assistance and people-to-people ties, delivered by prime-ministerial visits, policy statements, lines of credit, power-grid interlinkage, transit and transport protocols and river-water cooperation, with readiness for humanitarian assistance and disaster relief built in; the qualification the owners insist upon is that the doctrine is not applied identically to every neighbour, because its emphasis is calibrated by the partner's size, history and current politics. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q11. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Neighbourhood First as a stated priority policy?

A. Sikri argues that India must move away from its excessive regime-oriented policies towards people-to-people relations on the reasoning that only neighbouring regimes which reflect their own people's interests are likely to sustain friendly relations with India, and the owners convert this into the operative test of Neighbourhood First, namely whether engagement survives a change of government in the partner state; the regime-orientation trap emerges when engagement depends too heavily on one incumbent, producing discontinuity whenever that incumbent changes, and the people-to-people reorientation is presented as a partial mitigation rather than a guarantee. B. Sikri states that India has no alternative but to closely follow and deeply analyze political trends in neighbouring countries because their domestic developments have an effect on India itself, and he cites India as the decisive factor in seeking a resolution of domestic political crises in Bangladesh in 1971, Sri Lanka in 1987 and Nepal in 1950-51 and subsequent crises; the owners require that these be treated as historical references rather than a standing doctrine of intervention, and that the resulting tension with the Gujral Doctrine's non-interference principle be acknowledged explicitly instead of being smoothed into one consistent posture. C. Neighbourhood First is India's stated policy priority of engaging South Asian neighbours ahead of more distant partners through connectivity, development assistance and people-to-people ties, delivered by prime-ministerial visits, policy statements, lines of credit, power-grid interlinkage, transit and transport protocols and river-water cooperation, with readiness for humanitarian assistance and disaster relief built in; the qualification the owners insist upon is that the doctrine is not applied identically to every neighbour, because its emphasis is calibrated by the partner's size, history and current politics. D. Sikri records that smaller neighbours like Bhutan, Nepal, Maldives and Sri Lanka have shown greater interest in economic integration with India than the larger

ones like Pakistan and Bangladesh, and that they are more receptive to cooperation within a regional framework than on a bilateral basis because numbers give them a sense of greater security, which the owners treat as a structural rather than merely tactical preference; the necessary qualification is that this preference does not amount to rejecting bilateral engagement, because the substantive connectivity work still proceeds bilaterally while the regional overlay supplies political reassurance.

Answer: C. Explanation: Neighbourhood First is India's stated policy priority of engaging South Asian neighbours ahead of more distant partners through connectivity, development assistance and people-to-people ties, delivered by prime-ministerial visits, policy statements, lines of credit, power-grid interlinkage, transit and transport protocols and river-water cooperation, with readiness for humanitarian assistance and disaster relief built in; the qualification the owners insist upon is that the doctrine is not applied identically to every neighbour, because its emphasis is calibrated by the partner's size, history and current politics. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q12. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Neighbourhood First as a stated priority policy?

A. The Akhaura-Agartala cross-border rail link was inaugurated on 1 November 2023, complementing restored rail, inland-waterway, road and power links, and the Bangladesh, Bhutan, India and Nepal Motor Vehicles Agreement was signed in 2015 to facilitate cross-border passenger and cargo movement; the owners attach a limitation to each, namely that customs, trans-shipment, domestic politics and last-mile infrastructure determine actual use of a rail link, and that Bhutan's non-ratification has constrained four-country implementation of the Motor Vehicles Agreement, so subregionalism progresses where SAARC-wide consensus is unavailable but does not by itself deliver seamless movement. B. Sikri states that India has no alternative but to closely follow and deeply analyze political trends in neighbouring countries because their domestic developments have an effect on India itself, and he cites India as the decisive factor in seeking a resolution of domestic political crises in Bangladesh in 1971, Sri Lanka in 1987 and Nepal in 1950-51 and subsequent crises; the owners require that these be treated as historical references rather than a standing doctrine of intervention, and that the resulting tension with the Gujral Doctrine's non-interference principle be acknowledged explicitly instead of being smoothed into one consistent posture. C. Sikri argues that India must move away from its excessive regime-oriented policies towards people-to-people relations on the reasoning that only neighbouring regimes which reflect their own people's interests are likely to sustain friendly relations with India, and the owners convert this into the operative test of Neighbourhood First, namely whether engagement survives a change of government in the partner state; the regime-orientation trap emerges when engagement depends too heavily on one incumbent, producing discontinuity whenever that incumbent changes, and the people-to-people reorientation is presented as a partial mitigation rather than a guarantee. D. Neighbourhood First is India's stated policy priority of engaging South Asian neighbours ahead of more distant partners through connectivity, development assistance and people-to-people ties, delivered by prime-ministerial visits, policy statements, lines of credit, power-grid interlinkage, transit and transport protocols and river-water cooperation, with readiness for humanitarian assistance and disaster relief built in; the qualification the owners insist upon is that the doctrine is not applied identically to every neighbour, because its emphasis is calibrated by the partner's size, history and current politics.

Answer: D. Explanation: Neighbourhood First is India's stated policy priority of engaging South Asian neighbours ahead of more distant partners through connectivity, development assistance and people-to-people ties, delivered by prime-ministerial visits, policy statements, lines of credit, power-grid interlinkage, transit and transport protocols and river-water cooperation, with readiness for humanitarian assistance and disaster relief built in; the qualification the owners insist upon is that the doctrine is not applied identically to every neighbour, because its emphasis is calibrated by the partner's size, history and current politics. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q13. Which statement correctly identifies The Gujral Doctrine and its five principles?

A. The Gujral Doctrine, associated with former Prime Minister I. K. Gujral, is a five-principle approach under which India does not seek reciprocity from smaller neighbours, does not interfere in their internal affairs, does not allow its territory to be used against them, respects their territorial integrity, and settles disputes bilaterally and peacefully, and it remains the standard doctrinal reference for South Asia policy; the defining feature that examiners test is non-reciprocal accommodation, so any statement that the doctrine demands reciprocity as a precondition for cooperation inverts its meaning exactly. B. Sikri argues that India must move away from its excessive regime-oriented policies towards people-to-people relations on the reasoning that only neighbouring regimes which reflect their own people's interests are likely to sustain friendly relations with India, and the owners convert this into the operative test of Neighbourhood First, namely whether engagement survives a change of government in the partner state; the regime-orientation trap emerges when engagement depends too heavily on one incumbent, producing discontinuity whenever that incumbent changes, and the people-to-people reorientation is presented as a partial mitigation rather than a guarantee. C. Sikri records that smaller neighbours like Bhutan, Nepal, Maldives and Sri Lanka have shown greater interest in economic integration with India than the larger ones like Pakistan and Bangladesh, and that they are more receptive to cooperation within a regional framework than on a bilateral basis because numbers give them a sense of greater security, which the owners treat as a structural rather than merely tactical preference; the necessary qualification is that this preference does not amount to rejecting bilateral engagement, because the substantive connectivity work still proceeds bilaterally while the regional overlay supplies political reassurance. D. India is larger in economy, population and military capacity than its entire immediate neighbourhood combined, and the owners treat this asymmetry as the structural condition that shapes how smaller states balance cooperation with India against anxiety about dependence, so the Gujral Doctrine is best read as a response to that anxiety rather than as generosity for its own sake; the analytical move that raises an answer is to treat asymmetry as a design problem to be converted into reliable public goods, instead of treating size disparity as inherently adversarial.

Answer: A. Explanation: The Gujral Doctrine, associated with former Prime Minister I. K. Gujral, is a five-principle approach under which India does not seek reciprocity from smaller neighbours, does not interfere in their internal affairs, does not allow its territory to be used against them, respects their territorial integrity, and settles disputes bilaterally and peacefully, and it remains the standard doctrinal reference for South Asia policy; the defining feature that examiners test is non-reciprocal accommodation, so any statement that the doctrine demands reciprocity as a precondition for cooperation inverts its meaning exactly. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q14. Which card should be filed under The Gujral Doctrine and its five principles in an International Relations answer?

A. Sikri records that smaller neighbours like Bhutan, Nepal, Maldives and Sri Lanka have shown greater interest in economic integration with India than the larger ones like Pakistan and Bangladesh, and that they are more receptive to cooperation within a regional framework than on a bilateral basis because numbers give them a sense of greater security, which the owners treat as a structural rather than merely tactical preference; the necessary qualification is that this preference does not amount to rejecting bilateral engagement, because the substantive connectivity work still proceeds bilaterally while the regional overlay supplies political reassurance. B. The Gujral Doctrine, associated with former Prime Minister I. K. Gujral, is a five-principle approach under which India does not seek reciprocity from smaller neighbours, does not interfere in their internal affairs, does not allow its territory to be used against them, respects their territorial integrity, and settles disputes bilaterally and peacefully, and it remains the standard doctrinal reference for South Asia policy; the defining feature that examiners test is non-reciprocal accommodation, so any statement that the doctrine demands reciprocity as a precondition for cooperation inverts its meaning exactly. C. Sikri states that India has no alternative but to closely follow and deeply analyze political trends in neighbouring countries because their domestic developments have an effect on India itself, and he cites India as the decisive factor in seeking a resolution of domestic political crises in Bangladesh in 1971, Sri Lanka in 1987 and Nepal in 1950-51 and subsequent crises; the owners require that these be treated as historical references rather than a standing doctrine of intervention, and that the resulting tension with the Gujral Doctrine's non-interference principle be acknowledged explicitly instead of being smoothed into one consistent posture. D. Sikri argues that India must move away from its excessive regime-oriented policies towards people-to-people relations on the reasoning that only neighbouring regimes which reflect their own people's interests are likely to sustain friendly relations with India, and the owners convert this into the

operative test of Neighbourhood First, namely whether engagement survives a change of government in the partner state; the regime-orientation trap emerges when engagement depends too heavily on one incumbent, producing discontinuity whenever that incumbent changes, and the people-to-people reorientation is presented as a partial mitigation rather than a guarantee.

Answer: B. Explanation: The Gujral Doctrine, associated with former Prime Minister I. K. Gujral, is a five-principle approach under which India does not seek reciprocity from smaller neighbours, does not interfere in their internal affairs, does not allow its territory to be used against them, respects their territorial integrity, and settles disputes bilaterally and peacefully, and it remains the standard doctrinal reference for South Asia policy; the defining feature that examiners test is non-reciprocal accommodation, so any statement that the doctrine demands reciprocity as a precondition for cooperation inverts its meaning exactly. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q15. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of The Gujral Doctrine and its five principles?

A. The Akhaura-Agartala cross-border rail link was inaugurated on 1 November 2023, complementing restored rail, inland-waterway, road and power links, and the Bangladesh, Bhutan, India and Nepal Motor Vehicles Agreement was signed in 2015 to facilitate cross-border passenger and cargo movement; the owners attach a limitation to each, namely that customs, trans-shipment, domestic politics and last-mile infrastructure determine actual use of a rail link, and that Bhutan's non-ratification has constrained four-country implementation of the Motor Vehicles Agreement, so subregionalism progresses where SAARC-wide consensus is unavailable but does not by itself deliver seamless movement. B. Sikri argues that India must move away from its excessive regime-oriented policies towards people-to-people relations on the reasoning that only neighbouring regimes which reflect their own people's interests are likely to sustain friendly relations with India, and the owners convert this into the operative test of Neighbourhood First, namely whether engagement survives a change of government in the partner state; the regime-orientation trap emerges when engagement depends too heavily on one incumbent, producing discontinuity whenever that incumbent changes, and the people-to-people reorientation is presented as a partial mitigation rather than a guarantee. C. The Gujral Doctrine, associated with former Prime Minister I. K. Gujral, is a five-principle approach under which India does not seek reciprocity from smaller neighbours, does not interfere in their internal affairs, does not allow its territory to be used against them, respects their territorial integrity, and settles disputes bilaterally and peacefully, and it remains the standard doctrinal reference for South Asia policy; the defining feature that examiners test is non-reciprocal accommodation, so any statement that the doctrine demands reciprocity as a precondition for cooperation inverts its meaning exactly. D. Sikri states that India has no alternative but to closely follow and deeply analyze political trends in neighbouring countries because their domestic developments have an effect on India itself, and he cites India as the decisive factor in seeking a resolution of domestic political crises in Bangladesh in 1971, Sri Lanka in 1987 and Nepal in 1950-51 and subsequent crises; the owners require that these be treated as historical references rather than a standing doctrine of intervention, and that the resulting tension with the Gujral Doctrine's non-interference principle be acknowledged explicitly instead of being smoothed into one consistent posture.

Answer: C. Explanation: The Gujral Doctrine, associated with former Prime Minister I. K. Gujral, is a five-principle approach under which India does not seek reciprocity from smaller neighbours, does not interfere in their internal affairs, does not allow its territory to be used against them, respects their territorial integrity, and settles disputes bilaterally and peacefully, and it remains the standard doctrinal reference for South Asia policy; the defining feature that examiners test is non-reciprocal accommodation, so any statement that the doctrine demands reciprocity as a precondition for cooperation inverts its meaning exactly. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q16. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about The Gujral Doctrine and its five principles?

A. Sikri states that India has no alternative but to closely follow and deeply analyze political trends in neighbouring countries because their domestic developments have an effect on India itself, and he cites India as the decisive factor in seeking a resolution of domestic political crises in Bangladesh in 1971, Sri Lanka in 1987 and Nepal in 1950-51 and subsequent crises; the owners require that these be treated as historical references rather than a standing doctrine of intervention, and that the resulting tension with the Gujral Doctrine's non-interference principle be acknowledged explicitly instead of being smoothed into one consistent posture. B. The 720 megawatt Mangdechhu project was commissioned in 2019 and handed over to Bhutan in 2022, illustrating joint project delivery and electricity trade that links Bhutanese revenue to Indian clean-power access, and the owners record India's commitment of one hundred billion Indian rupees, equivalently ten thousand crore rupees, for Bhutan's thirteenth Five Year Plan covering 2024 to 2029, a rail-link memorandum of understanding of 29 September 2025 for the Kokrajhar-Gelephu and Banarhat-Samtse links, and support for Gelephu Mindfulness City expressed on 12 November 2025; the evidentiary boundary is that these are a commitment, a memorandum and political support rather than commissioned rail links or an operating city, and that project delay, cost escalation, ecological effects and Bhutan's diversification concerns require balance. C. The Akhaura-Agartala cross-border rail link was inaugurated on 1 November 2023, complementing restored rail, inland-waterway, road and power links, and the Bangladesh, Bhutan, India and Nepal Motor Vehicles Agreement was signed in 2015 to facilitate cross-border passenger and cargo movement; the owners attach a limitation to each, namely that customs, trans-shipment, domestic politics and last-mile infrastructure determine actual use of a rail link, and that Bhutan's non-ratification has constrained four-country implementation of the Motor Vehicles Agreement, so subregionalism progresses where SAARC-wide consensus is unavailable but does not by itself deliver seamless movement. D. The Gujral Doctrine, associated with former Prime Minister I. K. Gujral, is a five-principle approach under which India does not seek reciprocity from smaller neighbours, does not interfere in their internal affairs, does not allow its territory to be used against them, respects their territorial integrity, and settles disputes bilaterally and peacefully, and it remains the standard doctrinal reference for South Asia policy; the defining feature that examiners test is non-reciprocal accommodation, so any statement that the doctrine demands reciprocity as a precondition for cooperation inverts its meaning exactly.

Answer: D. Explanation: The Gujral Doctrine, associated with former Prime Minister I. K. Gujral, is a five-principle approach under which India does not seek reciprocity from smaller neighbours, does not interfere in their internal affairs, does not allow its territory to be used against them, respects their territorial integrity, and settles disputes bilaterally and peacefully, and it remains the standard doctrinal reference for South Asia policy; the defining feature that examiners test is non-reciprocal accommodation, so any statement that the doctrine demands reciprocity as a precondition for cooperation inverts its meaning exactly. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q17. Which statement correctly identifies Asymmetric interdependence as the structural starting point?

A. India is larger in economy, population and military capacity than its entire immediate neighbourhood combined, and the owners treat this asymmetry as the structural condition that shapes how smaller states balance cooperation with India against anxiety about dependence, so the Gujral Doctrine is best read as a response to that anxiety rather than as generosity for its own sake; the analytical move that raises an answer is to treat asymmetry as a design problem to be converted into reliable public goods, instead of treating size disparity as inherently adversarial. B. Sikri states that India has no alternative but to closely follow and deeply analyze political trends in neighbouring countries because their domestic developments have an effect on India itself, and he cites India as the decisive factor in seeking a resolution of domestic political crises in Bangladesh in 1971, Sri Lanka in 1987 and Nepal in 1950-51 and subsequent crises; the owners require that these be treated as historical references rather than a standing doctrine of intervention, and that the resulting tension with the Gujral Doctrine's non-interference principle be acknowledged explicitly instead of being smoothed into one consistent posture. C. Sikri argues that India must move away from its excessive regime-oriented policies towards people-to-people relations on the reasoning that only neighbouring regimes which reflect their own people's interests are likely to sustain friendly relations with India, and the owners convert this into the operative test of Neighbourhood First, namely whether engagement survives a change of government in the partner state; the regime-orientation trap emerges when engagement depends too heavily on one incumbent, producing

discontinuity whenever that incumbent changes, and the people-to-people reorientation is presented as a partial mitigation rather than a guarantee. D. Sikri records that smaller neighbours like Bhutan, Nepal, Maldives and Sri Lanka have shown greater interest in economic integration with India than the larger ones like Pakistan and Bangladesh, and that they are more receptive to cooperation within a regional framework than on a bilateral basis because numbers give them a sense of greater security, which the owners treat as a structural rather than merely tactical preference; the necessary qualification is that this preference does not amount to rejecting bilateral engagement, because the substantive connectivity work still proceeds bilaterally while the regional overlay supplies political reassurance.

Answer: A. Explanation: India is larger in economy, population and military capacity than its entire immediate neighbourhood combined, and the owners treat this asymmetry as the structural condition that shapes how smaller states balance cooperation with India against anxiety about dependence, so the Gujral Doctrine is best read as a response to that anxiety rather than as generosity for its own sake; the analytical move that raises an answer is to treat asymmetry as a design problem to be converted into reliable public goods, instead of treating size disparity as inherently adversarial. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q18. Which card should be filed under Asymmetric interdependence as the structural starting point in an International Relations answer?

A. Sikri argues that India must move away from its excessive regime-oriented policies towards people-to-people relations on the reasoning that only neighbouring regimes which reflect their own people's interests are likely to sustain friendly relations with India, and the owners convert this into the operative test of Neighbourhood First, namely whether engagement survives a change of government in the partner state; the regime-orientation trap emerges when engagement depends too heavily on one incumbent, producing discontinuity whenever that incumbent changes, and the people-to-people reorientation is presented as a partial mitigation rather than a guarantee. B. India is larger in economy, population and military capacity than its entire immediate neighbourhood combined, and the owners treat this asymmetry as the structural condition that shapes how smaller states balance cooperation with India against anxiety about dependence, so the Gujral Doctrine is best read as a response to that anxiety rather than as generosity for its own sake; the analytical move that raises an answer is to treat asymmetry as a design problem to be converted into reliable public goods, instead of treating size disparity as inherently adversarial. C. The Akhaura-Agartala cross-border rail link was inaugurated on 1 November 2023, complementing restored rail, inland-waterway, road and power links, and the Bangladesh, Bhutan, India and Nepal Motor Vehicles Agreement was signed in 2015 to facilitate cross-border passenger and cargo movement; the owners attach a limitation to each, namely that customs, trans-shipment, domestic politics and last-mile infrastructure determine actual use of a rail link, and that Bhutan's non-ratification has constrained four-country implementation of the Motor Vehicles Agreement, so subregionalism progresses where SAARC-wide consensus is unavailable but does not by itself deliver seamless movement. D. Sikri states that India has no alternative but to closely follow and deeply analyze political trends in neighbouring countries because their domestic developments have an effect on India itself, and he cites India as the decisive factor in seeking a resolution of domestic political crises in Bangladesh in 1971, Sri Lanka in 1987 and Nepal in 1950-51 and subsequent crises; the owners require that these be treated as historical references rather than a standing doctrine of intervention, and that the resulting tension with the Gujral Doctrine's non-interference principle be acknowledged explicitly instead of being smoothed into one consistent posture.

Answer: B. Explanation: India is larger in economy, population and military capacity than its entire immediate neighbourhood combined, and the owners treat this asymmetry as the structural condition that shapes how smaller states balance cooperation with India against anxiety about dependence, so the Gujral Doctrine is best read as a response to that anxiety rather than as generosity for its own sake; the analytical move that raises an answer is to treat asymmetry as a design problem to be converted into reliable public goods, instead of treating size disparity as inherently adversarial. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q19. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Asymmetric interdependence as the structural starting point?

A. The Akhaura-Agartala cross-border rail link was inaugurated on 1 November 2023, complementing restored rail, inland-waterway, road and power links, and the Bangladesh, Bhutan, India and Nepal Motor Vehicles Agreement was signed in 2015 to facilitate cross-border passenger and cargo movement; the owners attach a limitation to each, namely that customs, trans-shipment, domestic politics and last-mile infrastructure determine actual use of a rail link, and that Bhutan's non-ratification has constrained four-country implementation of the Motor Vehicles Agreement, so subregionalism progresses where SAARC-wide consensus is unavailable but does not by itself deliver seamless movement. B. The 720 megawatt Mangdechhu project was commissioned in 2019 and handed over to Bhutan in 2022, illustrating joint project delivery and electricity trade that links Bhutanese revenue to Indian clean-power access, and the owners record India's commitment of one hundred billion Indian rupees, equivalently ten thousand crore rupees, for Bhutan's thirteenth Five Year Plan covering 2024 to 2029, a rail-link memorandum of understanding of 29 September 2025 for the Kokrajhar-Gelephu and Banarhat-Samtse links, and support for Gelephu Mindfulness City expressed on 12 November 2025; the evidentiary boundary is that these are a commitment, a memorandum and political support rather than commissioned rail links or an operating city, and that project delay, cost escalation, ecological effects and Bhutan's diversification concerns require balance. C. India is larger in economy, population and military capacity than its entire immediate neighbourhood combined, and the owners treat this asymmetry as the structural condition that shapes how smaller states balance cooperation with India against anxiety about dependence, so the Gujral Doctrine is best read as a response to that anxiety rather than as generosity for its own sake; the analytical move that raises an answer is to treat asymmetry as a design problem to be converted into reliable public goods, instead of treating size disparity as inherently adversarial. D. Sikri states that India has no alternative but to closely follow and deeply analyze political trends in neighbouring countries because their domestic developments have an effect on India itself, and he cites India as the decisive factor in seeking a resolution of domestic political crises in Bangladesh in 1971, Sri Lanka in 1987 and Nepal in 1950-51 and subsequent crises; the owners require that these be treated as historical references rather than a standing doctrine of intervention, and that the resulting tension with the Gujral Doctrine's non-interference principle be acknowledged explicitly instead of being smoothed into one consistent posture.

Answer: C. Explanation: India is larger in economy, population and military capacity than its entire immediate neighbourhood combined, and the owners treat this asymmetry as the structural condition that shapes how smaller states balance cooperation with India against anxiety about dependence, so the Gujral Doctrine is best read as a response to that anxiety rather than as generosity for its own sake; the analytical move that raises an answer is to treat asymmetry as a design problem to be converted into reliable public goods, instead of treating size disparity as inherently adversarial. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q20. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Asymmetric interdependence as the structural starting point?

A. The 720 megawatt Mangdechhu project was commissioned in 2019 and handed over to Bhutan in 2022, illustrating joint project delivery and electricity trade that links Bhutanese revenue to Indian clean-power access, and the owners record India's commitment of one hundred billion Indian rupees, equivalently ten thousand crore rupees, for Bhutan's thirteenth Five Year Plan covering 2024 to 2029, a rail-link memorandum of understanding of 29 September 2025 for the Kokrajhar-Gelephu and Banarhat-Samtse links, and support for Gelephu Mindfulness City expressed on 12 November 2025; the evidentiary boundary is that these are a commitment, a memorandum and political support rather than commissioned rail links or an operating city, and that project delay, cost escalation, ecological effects and Bhutan's diversification concerns require balance. B. The unresolved Teesta water-sharing issue demonstrates how Indian state-level interests can constrain a bilateral agreement with Bangladesh, and the owners draw the general lesson that neighbourhood diplomacy is shaped by domestic federal and border stakeholders rather than by the external ministry alone; the qualification carried with it is equally examinable, namely that one dispute should not be allowed to erase the wider record of connectivity and security cooperation, so the correct treatment is to name the federal constraint as a specific limiting mechanism instead of generalising it into a verdict on the whole relationship. C. The Akhaura-Agartala cross-border rail link was inaugurated on 1 November 2023, complementing restored rail, inland-waterway, road and power links, and the Bangladesh, Bhutan, India and Nepal Motor Vehicles Agreement was signed in 2015 to facilitate cross-border passenger and cargo movement; the owners attach a limitation to each,

namely that customs, trans-shipment, domestic politics and last-mile infrastructure determine actual use of a rail link, and that Bhutan's non-ratification has constrained four-country implementation of the Motor Vehicles Agreement, so subregionalism progresses where SAARC-wide consensus is unavailable but does not by itself deliver seamless movement. D. India is larger in economy, population and military capacity than its entire immediate neighbourhood combined, and the owners treat this asymmetry as the structural condition that shapes how smaller states balance cooperation with India against anxiety about dependence, so the Gujral Doctrine is best read as a response to that anxiety rather than as generosity for its own sake; the analytical move that raises an answer is to treat asymmetry as a design problem to be converted into reliable public goods, instead of treating size disparity as inherently adversarial.

Answer: D. Explanation: India is larger in economy, population and military capacity than its entire immediate neighbourhood combined, and the owners treat this asymmetry as the structural condition that shapes how smaller states balance cooperation with India against anxiety about dependence, so the Gujral Doctrine is best read as a response to that anxiety rather than as generosity for its own sake; the analytical move that raises an answer is to treat asymmetry as a design problem to be converted into reliable public goods, instead of treating size disparity as inherently adversarial. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q21. Which statement correctly identifies Sikri's regional-framework preference among smaller neighbours?

A. Sikri records that smaller neighbours like Bhutan, Nepal, Maldives and Sri Lanka have shown greater interest in economic integration with India than the larger ones like Pakistan and Bangladesh, and that they are more receptive to cooperation within a regional framework than on a bilateral basis because numbers give them a sense of greater security, which the owners treat as a structural rather than merely tactical preference; the necessary qualification is that this preference does not amount to rejecting bilateral engagement, because the substantive connectivity work still proceeds bilaterally while the regional overlay supplies political reassurance. B. The Akhaura-Agartala cross-border rail link was inaugurated on 1 November 2023, complementing restored rail, inland-waterway, road and power links, and the Bangladesh, Bhutan, India and Nepal Motor Vehicles Agreement was signed in 2015 to facilitate cross-border passenger and cargo movement; the owners attach a limitation to each, namely that customs, trans-shipment, domestic politics and last-mile infrastructure determine actual use of a rail link, and that Bhutan's non-ratification has constrained four-country implementation of the Motor Vehicles Agreement, so subregionalism progresses where SAARC-wide consensus is unavailable but does not by itself deliver seamless movement. C. Sikri argues that India must move away from its excessive regime-oriented policies towards people-to-people relations on the reasoning that only neighbouring regimes which reflect their own people's interests are likely to sustain friendly relations with India, and the owners convert this into the operative test of Neighbourhood First, namely whether engagement survives a change of government in the partner state; the regime-orientation trap emerges when engagement depends too heavily on one incumbent, producing discontinuity whenever that incumbent changes, and the people-to-people reorientation is presented as a partial mitigation rather than a guarantee. D. Sikri states that India has no alternative but to closely follow and deeply analyze political trends in neighbouring countries because their domestic developments have an effect on India itself, and he cites India as the decisive factor in seeking a resolution of domestic political crises in Bangladesh in 1971, Sri Lanka in 1987 and Nepal in 1950-51 and subsequent crises; the owners require that these be treated as historical references rather than a standing doctrine of intervention, and that the resulting tension with the Gujral Doctrine's non-interference principle be acknowledged explicitly instead of being smoothed into one consistent posture.

Answer: A. Explanation: Sikri records that smaller neighbours like Bhutan, Nepal, Maldives and Sri Lanka have shown greater interest in economic integration with India than the larger ones like Pakistan and Bangladesh, and that they are more receptive to cooperation within a regional framework than on a bilateral basis because numbers give them a sense of greater security, which the owners treat as a structural rather than merely tactical preference; the necessary qualification is that this preference does not amount to rejecting bilateral engagement, because the substantive connectivity work still proceeds bilaterally while the regional overlay supplies political reassurance. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q22. Which card should be filed under Sikri's regional-framework preference among smaller neighbours in an International Relations answer?

A. The 720 megawatt Mangdechhu project was commissioned in 2019 and handed over to Bhutan in 2022, illustrating joint project delivery and electricity trade that links Bhutanese revenue to Indian clean-power access, and the owners record India's commitment of one hundred billion Indian rupees, equivalently ten thousand crore rupees, for Bhutan's thirteenth Five Year Plan covering 2024 to 2029, a rail-link memorandum of understanding of 29 September 2025 for the Kokrajhar-Gelephu and Banarhat-Samtse links, and support for Gelephu Mindfulness City expressed on 12 November 2025; the evidentiary boundary is that these are a commitment, a memorandum and political support rather than commissioned rail links or an operating city, and that project delay, cost escalation, ecological effects and Bhutan's diversification concerns require balance. B. Sikri records that smaller neighbours like Bhutan, Nepal, Maldives and Sri Lanka have shown greater interest in economic integration with India than the larger ones like Pakistan and Bangladesh, and that they are more receptive to cooperation within a regional framework than on a bilateral basis because numbers give them a sense of greater security, which the owners treat as a structural rather than merely tactical preference; the necessary qualification is that this preference does not amount to rejecting bilateral engagement, because the substantive connectivity work still proceeds bilaterally while the regional overlay supplies political reassurance. C. The Akhaura-Agartala cross-border rail link was inaugurated on 1 November 2023, complementing restored rail, inland-waterway, road and power links, and the Bangladesh, Bhutan, India and Nepal Motor Vehicles Agreement was signed in 2015 to facilitate cross-border passenger and cargo movement; the owners attach a limitation to each, namely that customs, trans-shipment, domestic politics and last-mile infrastructure determine actual use of a rail link, and that Bhutan's non-ratification has constrained four-country implementation of the Motor Vehicles Agreement, so subregionalism progresses where SAARC-wide consensus is unavailable but does not by itself deliver seamless movement. D. Sikri states that India has no alternative but to closely follow and deeply analyze political trends in neighbouring countries because their domestic developments have an effect on India itself, and he cites India as the decisive factor in seeking a resolution of domestic political crises in Bangladesh in 1971, Sri Lanka in 1987 and Nepal in 1950-51 and subsequent crises; the owners require that these be treated as historical references rather than a standing doctrine of intervention, and that the resulting tension with the Gujral Doctrine's non-interference principle be acknowledged explicitly instead of being smoothed into one consistent posture.

Answer: B. Explanation: Sikri records that smaller neighbours like Bhutan, Nepal, Maldives and Sri Lanka have shown greater interest in economic integration with India than the larger ones like Pakistan and Bangladesh, and that they are more receptive to cooperation within a regional framework than on a bilateral basis because numbers give them a sense of greater security, which the owners treat as a structural rather than merely tactical preference; the necessary qualification is that this preference does not amount to rejecting bilateral engagement, because the substantive connectivity work still proceeds bilaterally while the regional overlay supplies political reassurance. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q23. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Sikri's regional-framework preference among smaller neighbours?

A. The unresolved Teesta water-sharing issue demonstrates how Indian state-level interests can constrain a bilateral agreement with Bangladesh, and the owners draw the general lesson that neighbourhood diplomacy is shaped by domestic federal and border stakeholders rather than by the external ministry alone; the qualification carried with it is equally examinable, namely that one dispute should not be allowed to erase the wider record of connectivity and security cooperation, so the correct treatment is to name the federal constraint as a specific limiting mechanism instead of generalising it into a verdict on the whole relationship. B. The Akhaura-Agartala cross-border rail link was inaugurated on 1 November 2023, complementing restored rail, inland-waterway, road and power links, and the Bangladesh, Bhutan, India and Nepal Motor Vehicles Agreement was signed in 2015 to facilitate cross-border passenger and cargo movement; the owners attach a limitation to each, namely that customs, trans-shipment, domestic politics and last-mile infrastructure determine actual use of a rail link, and that Bhutan's non-ratification has constrained four-country implementation of the Motor Vehicles Agreement, so subregionalism progresses where SAARC-wide consensus is unavailable but does not by itself deliver seamless movement. C. Sikri records that smaller neighbours like Bhutan, Nepal, Maldives and Sri Lanka have shown greater interest in economic integration with India than the larger ones like Pakistan and Bangladesh, and that they are more receptive to cooperation within a regional framework than on a bilateral basis because numbers give them a sense of greater security, which the owners treat as

a structural rather than merely tactical preference; the necessary qualification is that this preference does not amount to rejecting bilateral engagement, because the substantive connectivity work still proceeds bilaterally while the regional overlay supplies political reassurance. D. The 720 megawatt Mangdechhu project was commissioned in 2019 and handed over to Bhutan in 2022, illustrating joint project delivery and electricity trade that links Bhutanese revenue to Indian clean-power access, and the owners record India's commitment of one hundred billion Indian rupees, equivalently ten thousand crore rupees, for Bhutan's thirteenth Five Year Plan covering 2024 to 2029, a rail-link memorandum of understanding of 29 September 2025 for the Kokrajhar-Gelephu and Banarhat-Samtse links, and support for Gelephu Mindfulness City expressed on 12 November 2025; the evidentiary boundary is that these are a commitment, a memorandum and political support rather than commissioned rail links or an operating city, and that project delay, cost escalation, ecological effects and Bhutan's diversification concerns require balance.

Answer: C. Explanation: Sikri records that smaller neighbours like Bhutan, Nepal, Maldives and Sri Lanka have shown greater interest in economic integration with India than the larger ones like Pakistan and Bangladesh, and that they are more receptive to cooperation within a regional framework than on a bilateral basis because numbers give them a sense of greater security, which the owners treat as a structural rather than merely tactical preference; the necessary qualification is that this preference does not amount to rejecting bilateral engagement, because the substantive connectivity work still proceeds bilaterally while the regional overlay supplies political reassurance. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q24. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Sikri's regional-framework preference among smaller neighbours?

A. The Kaladan Multi-Modal Transit Transport Project and the India-Myanmar-Thailand Trilateral Highway aim to connect India's Northeast with Myanmar and Southeast Asia, and the owners record that on Kaladan the waterway and Sittwe Port were operationalised in May 2023 while the road component lagged, with both sides still calling for completion on 1 June 2026; the recorded reading is that the real gap in neighbourhood infrastructure is typically between a segment delivered and a corridor completed rather than between announcement and total inaction, and that conflict, incomplete road segments and border procedures mean an announced corridor is not seamless connectivity. B. The 720 megawatt Mangdechhu project was commissioned in 2019 and handed over to Bhutan in 2022, illustrating joint project delivery and electricity trade that links Bhutanese revenue to Indian clean-power access, and the owners record India's commitment of one hundred billion Indian rupees, equivalently ten thousand crore rupees, for Bhutan's thirteenth Five Year Plan covering 2024 to 2029, a rail-link memorandum of understanding of 29 September 2025 for the Kokrajhar-Gelephu and Banarhat-Samtse links, and support for Gelephu Mindfulness City expressed on 12 November 2025; the evidentiary boundary is that these are a commitment, a memorandum and political support rather than commissioned rail links or an operating city, and that project delay, cost escalation, ecological effects and Bhutan's diversification concerns require balance. C. The unresolved Teesta water-sharing issue demonstrates how Indian state-level interests can constrain a bilateral agreement with Bangladesh, and the owners draw the general lesson that neighbourhood diplomacy is shaped by domestic federal and border stakeholders rather than by the external ministry alone; the qualification carried with it is equally examinable, namely that one dispute should not be allowed to erase the wider record of connectivity and security cooperation, so the correct treatment is to name the federal constraint as a specific limiting mechanism instead of generalising it into a verdict on the whole relationship. D. Sikri records that smaller neighbours like Bhutan, Nepal, Maldives and Sri Lanka have shown greater interest in economic integration with India than the larger ones like Pakistan and Bangladesh, and that they are more receptive to cooperation within a regional framework than on a bilateral basis because numbers give them a sense of greater security, which the owners treat as a structural rather than merely tactical preference; the necessary qualification is that this preference does not amount to rejecting bilateral engagement, because the substantive connectivity work still proceeds bilaterally while the regional overlay supplies political reassurance.

Answer: D. Explanation: Sikri records that smaller neighbours like Bhutan, Nepal, Maldives and Sri Lanka have shown greater interest in economic integration with India than the larger ones like Pakistan and Bangladesh, and that they are more receptive to cooperation within a regional framework than on a bilateral basis because numbers give them a sense of greater security, which the owners treat as a structural rather than merely tactical preference; the necessary qualification is that this preference does not amount to rejecting bilateral engagement, because the substantive connectivity work still proceeds bilaterally while the regional overlay supplies political reassurance. The remaining options belong to different actors,

Q25. Which statement correctly identifies Regime-oriented against people-to-people engagement?

A. Sikri argues that India must move away from its excessive regime-oriented policies towards people-to-people relations on the reasoning that only neighbouring regimes which reflect their own people's interests are likely to sustain friendly relations with India, and the owners convert this into the operative test of Neighbourhood First, namely whether engagement survives a change of government in the partner state; the regime-orientation trap emerges when engagement depends too heavily on one incumbent, producing discontinuity whenever that incumbent changes, and the people-to-people reorientation is presented as a partial mitigation rather than a guarantee. B. The Akhaura-Agartala cross-border rail link was inaugurated on 1 November 2023, complementing restored rail, inland-waterway, road and power links, and the Bangladesh, Bhutan, India and Nepal Motor Vehicles Agreement was signed in 2015 to facilitate cross-border passenger and cargo movement; the owners attach a limitation to each, namely that customs, trans-shipment, domestic politics and last-mile infrastructure determine actual use of a rail link, and that Bhutan's non-ratification has constrained four-country implementation of the Motor Vehicles Agreement, so subregionalism progresses where SAARC-wide consensus is unavailable but does not by itself deliver seamless movement. C. Sikri states that India has no alternative but to closely follow and deeply analyze political trends in neighbouring countries because their domestic developments have an effect on India itself, and he cites India as the decisive factor in seeking a resolution of domestic political crises in Bangladesh in 1971, Sri Lanka in 1987 and Nepal in 1950-51 and subsequent crises; the owners require that these be treated as historical references rather than a standing doctrine of intervention, and that the resulting tension with the Gujral Doctrine's non-interference principle be acknowledged explicitly instead of being smoothed into one consistent posture. D. The 720 megawatt Mangdechhu project was commissioned in 2019 and handed over to Bhutan in 2022, illustrating joint project delivery and electricity trade that links Bhutanese revenue to Indian clean-power access, and the owners record India's commitment of one hundred billion Indian rupees, equivalently ten thousand crore rupees, for Bhutan's thirteenth Five Year Plan covering 2024 to 2029, a rail-link memorandum of understanding of 29 September 2025 for the Kokrajhar-Gelephu and Banarhat-Samtse links, and support for Gelephu Mindfulness City expressed on 12 November 2025; the evidentiary boundary is that these are a commitment, a memorandum and political support rather than commissioned rail links or an operating city, and that project delay, cost escalation, ecological effects and Bhutan's diversification concerns require balance.

Answer: A. Explanation: Sikri argues that India must move away from its excessive regime-oriented policies towards people-to-people relations on the reasoning that only neighbouring regimes which reflect their own people's interests are likely to sustain friendly relations with India, and the owners convert this into the operative test of Neighbourhood First, namely whether engagement survives a change of government in the partner state; the regime-orientation trap emerges when engagement depends too heavily on one incumbent, producing discontinuity whenever that incumbent changes, and the people-to-people reorientation is presented as a partial mitigation rather than a guarantee. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q26. Which card should be filed under Regime-oriented against people-to-people engagement in an International Relations answer?

A. The unresolved Teesta water-sharing issue demonstrates how Indian state-level interests can constrain a bilateral agreement with Bangladesh, and the owners draw the general lesson that neighbourhood diplomacy is shaped by domestic federal and border stakeholders rather than by the external ministry alone; the qualification carried with it is equally examinable, namely that one dispute should not be allowed to erase the wider record of connectivity and security cooperation, so the correct treatment is to name the federal constraint as a specific limiting mechanism instead of generalising it into a verdict on the whole relationship. B. Sikri argues that India must move away from its excessive regime-oriented policies towards people-to-people relations on the reasoning that only neighbouring regimes which reflect their own people's interests are likely to sustain friendly relations with India, and the owners convert this into the operative test of Neighbourhood First, namely whether engagement survives a change of government in the partner state; the regime-orientation trap emerges when engagement depends too heavily on one incumbent, producing discontinuity whenever that incumbent changes, and the people-to-people reorientation is presented as a partial mitigation rather than a guarantee. C. The Akhaura-Agartala cross-border rail link was

inaugurated on 1 November 2023, complementing restored rail, inland-waterway, road and power links, and the Bangladesh, Bhutan, India and Nepal Motor Vehicles Agreement was signed in 2015 to facilitate cross-border passenger and cargo movement; the owners attach a limitation to each, namely that customs, trans-shipment, domestic politics and last-mile infrastructure determine actual use of a rail link, and that Bhutan's non-ratification has constrained four-country implementation of the Motor Vehicles Agreement, so subregionalism progresses where SAARC-wide consensus is unavailable but does not by itself deliver seamless movement. D. The 720 megawatt Mangdechhu project was commissioned in 2019 and handed over to Bhutan in 2022, illustrating joint project delivery and electricity trade that links Bhutanese revenue to Indian clean-power access, and the owners record India's commitment of one hundred billion Indian rupees, equivalently ten thousand crore rupees, for Bhutan's thirteenth Five Year Plan covering 2024 to 2029, a rail-link memorandum of understanding of 29 September 2025 for the Kokrajhar-Gelephu and Banarhat-Samtse links, and support for Gelephu Mindfulness City expressed on 12 November 2025; the evidentiary boundary is that these are a commitment, a memorandum and political support rather than commissioned rail links or an operating city, and that project delay, cost escalation, ecological effects and Bhutan's diversification concerns require balance.

Answer: B. Explanation: Sikri argues that India must move away from its excessive regime-oriented policies towards people-to-people relations on the reasoning that only neighbouring regimes which reflect their own people's interests are likely to sustain friendly relations with India, and the owners convert this into the operative test of Neighbourhood First, namely whether engagement survives a change of government in the partner state; the regime-orientation trap emerges when engagement depends too heavily on one incumbent, producing discontinuity whenever that incumbent changes, and the people-to-people reorientation is presented as a partial mitigation rather than a guarantee. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q27. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Regime-oriented against people-to-people engagement?

A. The Kaladan Multi-Modal Transit Transport Project and the India-Myanmar-Thailand Trilateral Highway aim to connect India's Northeast with Myanmar and Southeast Asia, and the owners record that on Kaladan the waterway and Sittwe Port were operationalised in May 2023 while the road component lagged, with both sides still calling for completion on 1 June 2026; the recorded reading is that the real gap in neighbourhood infrastructure is typically between a segment delivered and a corridor completed rather than between announcement and total inaction, and that conflict, incomplete road segments and border procedures mean an announced corridor is not seamless connectivity. B. The 720 megawatt Mangdechhu project was commissioned in 2019 and handed over to Bhutan in 2022, illustrating joint project delivery and electricity trade that links Bhutanese revenue to Indian clean-power access, and the owners record India's commitment of one hundred billion Indian rupees, equivalently ten thousand crore rupees, for Bhutan's thirteenth Five Year Plan covering 2024 to 2029, a rail-link memorandum of understanding of 29 September 2025 for the Kokrajhar-Gelephu and Banarhat-Samtse links, and support for Gelephu Mindfulness City expressed on 12 November 2025; the evidentiary boundary is that these are a commitment, a memorandum and political support rather than commissioned rail links or an operating city, and that project delay, cost escalation, ecological effects and Bhutan's diversification concerns require balance. C. Sikri argues that India must move away from its excessive regime-oriented policies towards people-to-people relations on the reasoning that only neighbouring regimes which reflect their own people's interests are likely to sustain friendly relations with India, and the owners convert this into the operative test of Neighbourhood First, namely whether engagement survives a change of government in the partner state; the regime-orientation trap emerges when engagement depends too heavily on one incumbent, producing discontinuity whenever that incumbent changes, and the people-to-people reorientation is presented as a partial mitigation rather than a guarantee. D. The unresolved Teesta water-sharing issue demonstrates how Indian state-level interests can constrain a bilateral agreement with Bangladesh, and the owners draw the general lesson that neighbourhood diplomacy is shaped by domestic federal and border stakeholders rather than by the external ministry alone; the qualification carried with it is equally examinable, namely that one dispute should not be allowed to erase the wider record of connectivity and security cooperation, so the correct treatment is to name the federal constraint as a specific limiting mechanism instead of generalising it into a verdict on the whole relationship.

Answer: C. Explanation: Sikri argues that India must move away from its excessive regime-oriented policies towards people-to-people relations on the reasoning that only neighbouring regimes which reflect their own

people's interests are likely to sustain friendly relations with India, and the owners convert this into the operative test of Neighbourhood First, namely whether engagement survives a change of government in the partner state; the regime-orientation trap emerges when engagement depends too heavily on one incumbent, producing discontinuity whenever that incumbent changes, and the people-to-people reorientation is presented as a partial mitigation rather than a guarantee. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q28. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Regime-oriented against people-to-people engagement?

A. The unresolved Teesta water-sharing issue demonstrates how Indian state-level interests can constrain a bilateral agreement with Bangladesh, and the owners draw the general lesson that neighbourhood diplomacy is shaped by domestic federal and border stakeholders rather than by the external ministry alone; the qualification carried with it is equally examinable, namely that one dispute should not be allowed to erase the wider record of connectivity and security cooperation, so the correct treatment is to name the federal constraint as a specific limiting mechanism instead of generalising it into a verdict on the whole relationship. B. The Kaladan Multi-Modal Transit Transport Project and the India-Myanmar-Thailand Trilateral Highway aim to connect India's Northeast with Myanmar and Southeast Asia, and the owners record that on Kaladan the waterway and Sittwe Port were operationalised in May 2023 while the road component lagged, with both sides still calling for completion on 1 June 2026; the recorded reading is that the real gap in neighbourhood infrastructure is typically between a segment delivered and a corridor completed rather than between announcement and total inaction, and that conflict, incomplete road segments and border procedures mean an announced corridor is not seamless connectivity. C. During the Prime Minister's visit of 5 April 2025 seven memoranda of understanding were exchanged with Sri Lanka, covering high-voltage direct-current power interconnection, digital transformation, the India-Sri Lanka-United Arab Emirates Trincomalee energy hub, defence cooperation, Eastern Province grant assistance, health and medicine, and pharmacopoeial cooperation, and the Ministry of External Affairs bilateral brief on India-Sri Lanka was current to July 2026; the owners fix the evidentiary level precisely, recording that signed memoranda are not proof that each project is operational and that the 120 megawatt Sampur solar project had its ground-breaking rather than its commissioning, while the same visit inaugurated five thousand rooftop solar units and a warehouse. D. Sikri argues that India must move away from its excessive regime-oriented policies towards people-to-people relations on the reasoning that only neighbouring regimes which reflect their own people's interests are likely to sustain friendly relations with India, and the owners convert this into the operative test of Neighbourhood First, namely whether engagement survives a change of government in the partner state; the regime-orientation trap emerges when engagement depends too heavily on one incumbent, producing discontinuity whenever that incumbent changes, and the people-to-people reorientation is presented as a partial mitigation rather than a guarantee.

Answer: D. Explanation: Sikri argues that India must move away from its excessive regime-oriented policies towards people-to-people relations on the reasoning that only neighbouring regimes which reflect their own people's interests are likely to sustain friendly relations with India, and the owners convert this into the operative test of Neighbourhood First, namely whether engagement survives a change of government in the partner state; the regime-orientation trap emerges when engagement depends too heavily on one incumbent, producing discontinuity whenever that incumbent changes, and the people-to-people reorientation is presented as a partial mitigation rather than a guarantee. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q29. Which statement correctly identifies Domestic-political sensitivity and the historical-involvement tension?

A. Sikri states that India has no alternative but to closely follow and deeply analyze political trends in neighbouring countries because their domestic developments have an effect on India itself, and he cites India as the decisive factor in seeking a resolution of domestic political crises in Bangladesh in 1971, Sri Lanka in 1987 and Nepal in 1950-51 and subsequent crises; the owners require that these be treated as historical references rather than a standing doctrine of intervention, and that the resulting tension with the Gujral Doctrine's non-interference principle be acknowledged explicitly instead of being smoothed into one consistent posture. B. The Akhaura-Agartala cross-border rail link was inaugurated on 1 November 2023, complementing restored rail, inland-waterway, road and power links, and the Bangladesh, Bhutan, India and Nepal Motor Vehicles Agreement was signed in 2015 to facilitate cross-border

passenger and cargo movement; the owners attach a limitation to each, namely that customs, trans-shipment, domestic politics and last-mile infrastructure determine actual use of a rail link, and that Bhutan's non-ratification has constrained four-country implementation of the Motor Vehicles Agreement, so subregionalism progresses where SAARC-wide consensus is unavailable but does not by itself deliver seamless movement. C. The unresolved Teesta water-sharing issue demonstrates how Indian state-level interests can constrain a bilateral agreement with Bangladesh, and the owners draw the general lesson that neighbourhood diplomacy is shaped by domestic federal and border stakeholders rather than by the external ministry alone; the qualification carried with it is equally examinable, namely that one dispute should not be allowed to erase the wider record of connectivity and security cooperation, so the correct treatment is to name the federal constraint as a specific limiting mechanism instead of generalising it into a verdict on the whole relationship. D. The 720 megawatt Mangdechhu project was commissioned in 2019 and handed over to Bhutan in 2022, illustrating joint project delivery and electricity trade that links Bhutanese revenue to Indian clean-power access, and the owners record India's commitment of one hundred billion Indian rupees, equivalently ten thousand crore rupees, for Bhutan's thirteenth Five Year Plan covering 2024 to 2029, a rail-link memorandum of understanding of 29 September 2025 for the Kokrajhar-Gelephu and Banarhat-Samtse links, and support for Gelephu Mindfulness City expressed on 12 November 2025; the evidentiary boundary is that these are a commitment, a memorandum and political support rather than commissioned rail links or an operating city, and that project delay, cost escalation, ecological effects and Bhutan's diversification concerns require balance.

Answer: A. Explanation: Sikri states that India has no alternative but to closely follow and deeply analyze political trends in neighbouring countries because their domestic developments have an effect on India itself, and he cites India as the decisive factor in seeking a resolution of domestic political crises in Bangladesh in 1971, Sri Lanka in 1987 and Nepal in 1950-51 and subsequent crises; the owners require that these be treated as historical references rather than a standing doctrine of intervention, and that the resulting tension with the Gujral Doctrine's non-interference principle be acknowledged explicitly instead of being smoothed into one consistent posture. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q30. Which card should be filed under Domestic-political sensitivity and the historical-involvement tension in an International Relations answer?

A. The 720 megawatt Mangdechhu project was commissioned in 2019 and handed over to Bhutan in 2022, illustrating joint project delivery and electricity trade that links Bhutanese revenue to Indian clean-power access, and the owners record India's commitment of one hundred billion Indian rupees, equivalently ten thousand crore rupees, for Bhutan's thirteenth Five Year Plan covering 2024 to 2029, a rail-link memorandum of understanding of 29 September 2025 for the Kokrajhar-Gelephu and Banarhat-Samtse links, and support for Gelephu Mindfulness City expressed on 12 November 2025; the evidentiary boundary is that these are a commitment, a memorandum and political support rather than commissioned rail links or an operating city, and that project delay, cost escalation, ecological effects and Bhutan's diversification concerns require balance. B. Sikri states that India has no alternative but to closely follow and deeply analyze political trends in neighbouring countries because their domestic developments have an effect on India itself, and he cites India as the decisive factor in seeking a resolution of domestic political crises in Bangladesh in 1971, Sri Lanka in 1987 and Nepal in 1950-51 and subsequent crises; the owners require that these be treated as historical references rather than a standing doctrine of intervention, and that the resulting tension with the Gujral Doctrine's non-interference principle be acknowledged explicitly instead of being smoothed into one consistent posture. C. The unresolved Teesta water-sharing issue demonstrates how Indian state-level interests can constrain a bilateral agreement with Bangladesh, and the owners draw the general lesson that neighbourhood diplomacy is shaped by domestic federal and border stakeholders rather than by the external ministry alone; the qualification carried with it is equally examinable, namely that one dispute should not be allowed to erase the wider record of connectivity and security cooperation, so the correct treatment is to name the federal constraint as a specific limiting mechanism instead of generalising it into a verdict on the whole relationship. D. The Kaladan Multi-Modal Transit Transport Project and the India-Myanmar-Thailand Trilateral Highway aim to connect India's Northeast with Myanmar and Southeast Asia, and the owners record that on Kaladan the waterway and Sittwe Port were operationalised in May 2023 while the road component lagged, with both sides still calling for completion on 1 June 2026; the recorded reading is that the real gap in neighbourhood infrastructure is typically between a segment delivered and a corridor completed rather than between announcement and total inaction, and that conflict, incomplete road segments and border procedures mean an announced corridor is not seamless connectivity.

Answer: B. Explanation: Sikri states that India has no alternative but to closely follow and deeply analyze political trends in neighbouring countries because their domestic developments have an effect on India itself, and he cites India as the decisive factor in seeking a resolution of domestic political crises in Bangladesh in 1971, Sri Lanka in 1987 and Nepal in 1950-51 and subsequent crises; the owners require that these be treated as historical references rather than a standing doctrine of intervention, and that the resulting tension with the Gujral Doctrine's non-interference principle be acknowledged explicitly instead of being smoothed into one consistent posture. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q31. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Domestic-political sensitivity and the historical-involvement tension?

A. During the Prime Minister's visit of 5 April 2025 seven memoranda of understanding were exchanged with Sri Lanka, covering high-voltage direct-current power interconnection, digital transformation, the India-Sri Lanka-United Arab Emirates Trincomalee energy hub, defence cooperation, Eastern Province grant assistance, health and medicine, and pharmacopoeial cooperation, and the Ministry of External Affairs bilateral brief on India-Sri Lanka was current to July 2026; the owners fix the evidentiary level precisely, recording that signed memoranda are not proof that each project is operational and that the 120 megawatt Sampur solar project had its ground-breaking rather than its commissioning, while the same visit inaugurated five thousand rooftop solar units and a warehouse. B. The Kaladan Multi-Modal Transit Transport Project and the India-Myanmar-Thailand Trilateral Highway aim to connect India's Northeast with Myanmar and Southeast Asia, and the owners record that on Kaladan the waterway and Sittwe Port were operationalised in May 2023 while the road component lagged, with both sides still calling for completion on 1 June 2026; the recorded reading is that the real gap in neighbourhood infrastructure is typically between a segment delivered and a corridor completed rather than between announcement and total inaction, and that conflict, incomplete road segments and border procedures mean an announced corridor is not seamless connectivity. C. Sikri states that India has no alternative but to closely follow and deeply analyze political trends in neighbouring countries because their domestic developments have an effect on India itself, and he cites India as the decisive factor in seeking a resolution of domestic political crises in Bangladesh in 1971, Sri Lanka in 1987 and Nepal in 1950-51 and subsequent crises; the owners require that these be treated as historical references rather than a standing doctrine of intervention, and that the resulting tension with the Gujral Doctrine's non-interference principle be acknowledged explicitly instead of being smoothed into one consistent posture. D. The unresolved Teesta water-sharing issue demonstrates how Indian state-level interests can constrain a bilateral agreement with Bangladesh, and the owners draw the general lesson that neighbourhood diplomacy is shaped by domestic federal and border stakeholders rather than by the external ministry alone; the qualification carried with it is equally examinable, namely that one dispute should not be allowed to erase the wider record of connectivity and security cooperation, so the correct treatment is to name the federal constraint as a specific limiting mechanism instead of generalising it into a verdict on the whole relationship.

Answer: C. Explanation: Sikri states that India has no alternative but to closely follow and deeply analyze political trends in neighbouring countries because their domestic developments have an effect on India itself, and he cites India as the decisive factor in seeking a resolution of domestic political crises in Bangladesh in 1971, Sri Lanka in 1987 and Nepal in 1950-51 and subsequent crises; the owners require that these be treated as historical references rather than a standing doctrine of intervention, and that the resulting tension with the Gujral Doctrine's non-interference principle be acknowledged explicitly instead of being smoothed into one consistent posture. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q32. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Domestic-political sensitivity and the historical-involvement tension?

A. The India-Maldives Joint Vision of 7 October 2024 records support of four hundred million United States dollars and thirty billion Indian rupees as a currency-swap arrangement, the Terms of Reference for a free trade agreement were signed and negotiations launched on 25 July 2025, a line of credit of 4,850 crore Indian rupees is recorded, and the Ministry of External Affairs bilateral brief on India-Maldives was current to June 2026; the owners state expressly that a vision document, terms of reference and a line of credit are pre-delivery instruments and that no free trade agreement has been concluded, and they route the deeper Maldives treatment to topic 04 because its geostrategic salience is primarily maritime and is addressed by the 2024 objective demand recorded there. B. During the Prime

Minister's visit of 5 April 2025 seven memoranda of understanding were exchanged with Sri Lanka, covering high-voltage direct-current power interconnection, digital transformation, the India-Sri Lanka-United Arab Emirates Trincomalee energy hub, defence cooperation, Eastern Province grant assistance, health and medicine, and pharmacopoeial cooperation, and the Ministry of External Affairs bilateral brief on India-Sri Lanka was current to July 2026; the owners fix the evidentiary level precisely, recording that signed memoranda are not proof that each project is operational and that the 120 megawatt Sampur solar project had its ground-breaking rather than its commissioning, while the same visit inaugurated five thousand rooftop solar units and a warehouse. C. The Kaladan Multi-Modal Transit Transport Project and the India-Myanmar-Thailand Trilateral Highway aim to connect India's Northeast with Myanmar and Southeast Asia, and the owners record that on Kaladan the waterway and Sittwe Port were operationalised in May 2023 while the road component lagged, with both sides still calling for completion on 1 June 2026; the recorded reading is that the real gap in neighbourhood infrastructure is typically between a segment delivered and a corridor completed rather than between announcement and total inaction, and that conflict, incomplete road segments and border procedures mean an announced corridor is not seamless connectivity. D. Sikri states that India has no alternative but to closely follow and deeply analyze political trends in neighbouring countries because their domestic developments have an effect on India itself, and he cites India as the decisive factor in seeking a resolution of domestic political crises in Bangladesh in 1971, Sri Lanka in 1987 and Nepal in 1950-51 and subsequent crises; the owners require that these be treated as historical references rather than a standing doctrine of intervention, and that the resulting tension with the Gujral Doctrine's non-interference principle be acknowledged explicitly instead of being smoothed into one consistent posture.

Answer: D. Explanation: Sikri states that India has no alternative but to closely follow and deeply analyze political trends in neighbouring countries because their domestic developments have an effect on India itself, and he cites India as the decisive factor in seeking a resolution of domestic political crises in Bangladesh in 1971, Sri Lanka in 1987 and Nepal in 1950-51 and subsequent crises; the owners require that these be treated as historical references rather than a standing doctrine of intervention, and that the resulting tension with the Gujral Doctrine's non-interference principle be acknowledged explicitly instead of being smoothed into one consistent posture. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q33. Which statement correctly identifies Bangladesh connectivity and the BBIN subregional instrument?

A. The Akhaura-Agartala cross-border rail link was inaugurated on 1 November 2023, complementing restored rail, inland-waterway, road and power links, and the Bangladesh, Bhutan, India and Nepal Motor Vehicles Agreement was signed in 2015 to facilitate cross-border passenger and cargo movement; the owners attach a limitation to each, namely that customs, trans-shipment, domestic politics and last-mile infrastructure determine actual use of a rail link, and that Bhutan's non-ratification has constrained four-country implementation of the Motor Vehicles Agreement, so subregionalism progresses where SAARC-wide consensus is unavailable but does not by itself deliver seamless movement. B. The unresolved Teesta water-sharing issue demonstrates how Indian state-level interests can constrain a bilateral agreement with Bangladesh, and the owners draw the general lesson that neighbourhood diplomacy is shaped by domestic federal and border stakeholders rather than by the external ministry alone; the qualification carried with it is equally examinable, namely that one dispute should not be allowed to erase the wider record of connectivity and security cooperation, so the correct treatment is to name the federal constraint as a specific limiting mechanism instead of generalising it into a verdict on the whole relationship. C. The 720 megawatt Mangdechhu project was commissioned in 2019 and handed over to Bhutan in 2022, illustrating joint project delivery and electricity trade that links Bhutanese revenue to Indian clean-power access, and the owners record India's commitment of one hundred billion Indian rupees, equivalently ten thousand crore rupees, for Bhutan's thirteenth Five Year Plan covering 2024 to 2029, a rail-link memorandum of understanding of 29 September 2025 for the Kokrajhar-Gelephu and Banarhat-Samtse links, and support for Gelephu Mindfulness City expressed on 12 November 2025; the evidentiary boundary is that these are a commitment, a memorandum and political support rather than commissioned rail links or an operating city, and that project delay, cost escalation, ecological effects and Bhutan's diversification concerns require balance. D. The Kaladan Multi-Modal Transit Transport Project and the India-Myanmar-Thailand Trilateral Highway aim to connect India's Northeast with Myanmar and Southeast Asia, and the owners record that on Kaladan the waterway and Sittwe Port were operationalised in May 2023 while the road component lagged, with both sides still calling for completion on 1 June 2026; the recorded reading is that the real gap in neighbourhood infrastructure is

typically between a segment delivered and a corridor completed rather than between announcement and total inaction, and that conflict, incomplete road segments and border procedures mean an announced corridor is not seamless connectivity.

Answer: A. Explanation: The Akhaura-Agartala cross-border rail link was inaugurated on 1 November 2023, complementing restored rail, inland-waterway, road and power links, and the Bangladesh, Bhutan, India and Nepal Motor Vehicles Agreement was signed in 2015 to facilitate cross-border passenger and cargo movement; the owners attach a limitation to each, namely that customs, trans-shipment, domestic politics and last-mile infrastructure determine actual use of a rail link, and that Bhutan's non-ratification has constrained four-country implementation of the Motor Vehicles Agreement, so subregionalism progresses where SAARC-wide consensus is unavailable but does not by itself deliver seamless movement. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q34. Which card should be filed under Bangladesh connectivity and the BBIN subregional instrument in an International Relations answer?

A. The unresolved Teesta water-sharing issue demonstrates how Indian state-level interests can constrain a bilateral agreement with Bangladesh, and the owners draw the general lesson that neighbourhood diplomacy is shaped by domestic federal and border stakeholders rather than by the external ministry alone; the qualification carried with it is equally examinable, namely that one dispute should not be allowed to erase the wider record of connectivity and security cooperation, so the correct treatment is to name the federal constraint as a specific limiting mechanism instead of generalising it into a verdict on the whole relationship. B. The Akhaura-Agartala cross-border rail link was inaugurated on 1 November 2023, complementing restored rail, inland-waterway, road and power links, and the Bangladesh, Bhutan, India and Nepal Motor Vehicles Agreement was signed in 2015 to facilitate cross-border passenger and cargo movement; the owners attach a limitation to each, namely that customs, trans-shipment, domestic politics and last-mile infrastructure determine actual use of a rail link, and that Bhutan's non-ratification has constrained four-country implementation of the Motor Vehicles Agreement, so subregionalism progresses where SAARC-wide consensus is unavailable but does not by itself deliver seamless movement. C. The Kaladan Multi-Modal Transit Transport Project and the India-Myanmar-Thailand Trilateral Highway aim to connect India's Northeast with Myanmar and Southeast Asia, and the owners record that on Kaladan the waterway and Sittwe Port were operationalised in May 2023 while the road component lagged, with both sides still calling for completion on 1 June 2026; the recorded reading is that the real gap in neighbourhood infrastructure is typically between a segment delivered and a corridor completed rather than between announcement and total inaction, and that conflict, incomplete road segments and border procedures mean an announced corridor is not seamless connectivity. D. During the Prime Minister's visit of 5 April 2025 seven memoranda of understanding were exchanged with Sri Lanka, covering high-voltage direct-current power interconnection, digital transformation, the India-Sri Lanka-United Arab Emirates Trincomalee energy hub, defence cooperation, Eastern Province grant assistance, health and medicine, and pharmacopoeial cooperation, and the Ministry of External Affairs bilateral brief on India-Sri Lanka was current to July 2026; the owners fix the evidentiary level precisely, recording that signed memoranda are not proof that each project is operational and that the 120 megawatt Sampur solar project had its ground-breaking rather than its commissioning, while the same visit inaugurated five thousand rooftop solar units and a warehouse.

Answer: B. Explanation: The Akhaura-Agartala cross-border rail link was inaugurated on 1 November 2023, complementing restored rail, inland-waterway, road and power links, and the Bangladesh, Bhutan, India and Nepal Motor Vehicles Agreement was signed in 2015 to facilitate cross-border passenger and cargo movement; the owners attach a limitation to each, namely that customs, trans-shipment, domestic politics and last-mile infrastructure determine actual use of a rail link, and that Bhutan's non-ratification has constrained four-country implementation of the Motor Vehicles Agreement, so subregionalism progresses where SAARC-wide consensus is unavailable but does not by itself deliver seamless movement. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q35. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Bangladesh connectivity and the BBIN subregional instrument?

A. The India-Maldives Joint Vision of 7 October 2024 records support of four hundred million United States dollars and thirty billion Indian rupees as a currency-swap arrangement, the Terms of Reference for a free trade agreement were signed and negotiations launched on 25 July 2025, a line of credit of 4,850 crore Indian rupees is recorded, and the Ministry of External Affairs bilateral brief on India-Maldives was current to June 2026; the owners state expressly that a vision document, terms of reference and a line of credit are pre-delivery instruments and that no free trade agreement has been concluded, and they route the deeper Maldives treatment to topic 04 because its geostrategic salience is primarily maritime and is addressed by the 2024 objective demand recorded there. B. During the Prime Minister's visit of 5 April 2025 seven memoranda of understanding were exchanged with Sri Lanka, covering high-voltage direct-current power interconnection, digital transformation, the India-Sri Lanka-United Arab Emirates Trincomalee energy hub, defence cooperation, Eastern Province grant assistance, health and medicine, and pharmacopoeial cooperation, and the Ministry of External Affairs bilateral brief on India-Sri Lanka was current to July 2026; the owners fix the evidentiary level precisely, recording that signed memoranda are not proof that each project is operational and that the 120 megawatt Sampur solar project had its ground-breaking rather than its commissioning, while the same visit inaugurated five thousand rooftop solar units and a warehouse. C. The Akhaura-Agartala cross-border rail link was inaugurated on 1 November 2023, complementing restored rail, inland-waterway, road and power links, and the Bangladesh, Bhutan, India and Nepal Motor Vehicles Agreement was signed in 2015 to facilitate cross-border passenger and cargo movement; the owners attach a limitation to each, namely that customs, trans-shipment, domestic politics and last-mile infrastructure determine actual use of a rail link, and that Bhutan's non-ratification has constrained four-country implementation of the Motor Vehicles Agreement, so subregionalism progresses where SAARC-wide consensus is unavailable but does not by itself deliver seamless movement. D. The Kaladan Multi-Modal Transit Transport Project and the India-Myanmar-Thailand Trilateral Highway aim to connect India's Northeast with Myanmar and Southeast Asia, and the owners record that on Kaladan the waterway and Sittwe Port were operationalised in May 2023 while the road component lagged, with both sides still calling for completion on 1 June 2026; the recorded reading is that the real gap in neighbourhood infrastructure is typically between a segment delivered and a corridor completed rather than between announcement and total inaction, and that conflict, incomplete road segments and border procedures mean an announced corridor is not seamless connectivity.

Answer: C. Explanation: The Akhaura-Agartala cross-border rail link was inaugurated on 1 November 2023, complementing restored rail, inland-waterway, road and power links, and the Bangladesh, Bhutan, India and Nepal Motor Vehicles Agreement was signed in 2015 to facilitate cross-border passenger and cargo movement; the owners attach a limitation to each, namely that customs, trans-shipment, domestic politics and last-mile infrastructure determine actual use of a rail link, and that Bhutan's non-ratification has constrained four-country implementation of the Motor Vehicles Agreement, so subregionalism progresses where SAARC-wide consensus is unavailable but does not by itself deliver seamless movement. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q36. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Bangladesh connectivity and the BBIN subregional instrument?

A. By 3 May 2022 India's High Commission recorded more than three billion United States dollars in assistance during 2022, comprising a one billion dollar facility for food, medicines and essentials, a five hundred million dollar petroleum credit line, about one billion dollars in Asian Clearing Union payment deferment and a four hundred million dollar Reserve Bank of India currency swap, while the petroleum line had delivered close to four hundred thousand tonnes of fuel across all twenty-five districts and the essentials facility had supplied rice and other necessities with medical consignments providing a humanitarian component; the owners require the aggregate to be time-bounded, since full-year descriptions commonly place support at around four billion dollars over 2022, and they record the limitation that emergency financing did not remove Sri Lanka's structural debt, revenue, governance and external-financing problems, whose durable resolution required domestic adjustment and an International Monetary Fund-supported programme. B. The India-Maldives Joint Vision of 7 October 2024 records support of four hundred million United States dollars and thirty billion Indian rupees as a currency-swap arrangement, the Terms of Reference for a free trade agreement were signed and negotiations launched on 25 July 2025, a line of credit of 4,850 crore Indian rupees is recorded, and the Ministry of External Affairs bilateral brief on India-Maldives was current to June 2026; the owners state expressly that a vision document, terms of reference and a line of credit are pre-delivery instruments and that no

free trade agreement has been concluded, and they route the deeper Maldives treatment to topic 04 because its geostrategic salience is primarily maritime and is addressed by the 2024 objective demand recorded there. C. During the Prime Minister's visit of 5 April 2025 seven memoranda of understanding were exchanged with Sri Lanka, covering high-voltage direct-current power interconnection, digital transformation, the India-Sri Lanka-United Arab Emirates Trincomalee energy hub, defence cooperation, Eastern Province grant assistance, health and medicine, and pharmacopoeial cooperation, and the Ministry of External Affairs bilateral brief on India-Sri Lanka was current to July 2026; the owners fix the evidentiary level precisely, recording that signed memoranda are not proof that each project is operational and that the 120 megawatt Sampur solar project had its ground-breaking rather than its commissioning, while the same visit inaugurated five thousand rooftop solar units and a warehouse. D. The Akhaura-Agartala cross-border rail link was inaugurated on 1 November 2023, complementing restored rail, inland-waterway, road and power links, and the Bangladesh, Bhutan, India and Nepal Motor Vehicles Agreement was signed in 2015 to facilitate cross-border passenger and cargo movement; the owners attach a limitation to each, namely that customs, trans-shipment, domestic politics and last-mile infrastructure determine actual use of a rail link, and that Bhutan's non-ratification has constrained four-country implementation of the Motor Vehicles Agreement, so subregionalism progresses where SAARC-wide consensus is unavailable but does not by itself deliver seamless movement.

Answer: D. Explanation: The Akhaura-Agartala cross-border rail link was inaugurated on 1 November 2023, complementing restored rail, inland-waterway, road and power links, and the Bangladesh, Bhutan, India and Nepal Motor Vehicles Agreement was signed in 2015 to facilitate cross-border passenger and cargo movement; the owners attach a limitation to each, namely that customs, trans-shipment, domestic politics and last-mile infrastructure determine actual use of a rail link, and that Bhutan's non-ratification has constrained four-country implementation of the Motor Vehicles Agreement, so subregionalism progresses where SAARC-wide consensus is unavailable but does not by itself deliver seamless movement. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q37. Which statement correctly identifies Bhutan hydropower and the current commitment set?

A. The 720 megawatt Mangdechhu project was commissioned in 2019 and handed over to Bhutan in 2022, illustrating joint project delivery and electricity trade that links Bhutanese revenue to Indian clean-power access, and the owners record India's commitment of one hundred billion Indian rupees, equivalently ten thousand crore rupees, for Bhutan's thirteenth Five Year Plan covering 2024 to 2029, a rail-link memorandum of understanding of 29 September 2025 for the Kokrajhar-Gelephu and Banarhat-Samtse links, and support for Gelephu Mindfulness City expressed on 12 November 2025; the evidentiary boundary is that these are a commitment, a memorandum and political support rather than commissioned rail links or an operating city, and that project delay, cost escalation, ecological effects and Bhutan's diversification concerns require balance. B. The unresolved Teesta water-sharing issue demonstrates how Indian state-level interests can constrain a bilateral agreement with Bangladesh, and the owners draw the general lesson that neighbourhood diplomacy is shaped by domestic federal and border stakeholders rather than by the external ministry alone; the qualification carried with it is equally examinable, namely that one dispute should not be allowed to erase the wider record of connectivity and security cooperation, so the correct treatment is to name the federal constraint as a specific limiting mechanism instead of generalising it into a verdict on the whole relationship. C. During the Prime Minister's visit of 5 April 2025 seven memoranda of understanding were exchanged with Sri Lanka, covering high-voltage direct-current power interconnection, digital transformation, the India-Sri Lanka-United Arab Emirates Trincomalee energy hub, defence cooperation, Eastern Province grant assistance, health and medicine, and pharmacopoeial cooperation, and the Ministry of External Affairs bilateral brief on India-Sri Lanka was current to July 2026; the owners fix the evidentiary level precisely, recording that signed memoranda are not proof that each project is operational and that the 120 megawatt Sampur solar project had its ground-breaking rather than its commissioning, while the same visit inaugurated five thousand rooftop solar units and a warehouse. D. The Kaladan Multi-Modal Transit Transport Project and the India-Myanmar-Thailand Trilateral Highway aim to connect India's Northeast with Myanmar and Southeast Asia, and the owners record that on Kaladan the waterway and Sittwe Port were operationalised in May 2023 while the road component lagged, with both sides still calling for completion on 1 June 2026; the recorded reading is that the real gap in neighbourhood infrastructure is typically between a segment delivered and a corridor completed rather than between announcement and total inaction, and that conflict, incomplete road segments and border procedures mean an announced corridor is not seamless connectivity.

Answer: A. Explanation: The 720 megawatt Mangdechhu project was commissioned in 2019 and handed over to Bhutan in 2022, illustrating joint project delivery and electricity trade that links Bhutanese revenue to

Indian clean-power access, and the owners record India's commitment of one hundred billion Indian rupees, equivalently ten thousand crore rupees, for Bhutan's thirteenth Five Year Plan covering 2024 to 2029, a rail-link memorandum of understanding of 29 September 2025 for the Kokrajhar-Gelephu and Banarhat-Samtse links, and support for Gelephu Mindfulness City expressed on 12 November 2025; the evidentiary boundary is that these are a commitment, a memorandum and political support rather than commissioned rail links or an operating city, and that project delay, cost escalation, ecological effects and Bhutan's diversification concerns require balance. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q38. Which card should be filed under Bhutan hydropower and the current commitment set in an International Relations answer?

A. The Kaladan Multi-Modal Transit Transport Project and the India-Myanmar-Thailand Trilateral Highway aim to connect India's Northeast with Myanmar and Southeast Asia, and the owners record that on Kaladan the waterway and Sittwe Port were operationalised in May 2023 while the road component lagged, with both sides still calling for completion on 1 June 2026; the recorded reading is that the real gap in neighbourhood infrastructure is typically between a segment delivered and a corridor completed rather than between announcement and total inaction, and that conflict, incomplete road segments and border procedures mean an announced corridor is not seamless connectivity. B. The 720 megawatt Mangdechhu project was commissioned in 2019 and handed over to Bhutan in 2022, illustrating joint project delivery and electricity trade that links Bhutanese revenue to Indian clean-power access, and the owners record India's commitment of one hundred billion Indian rupees, equivalently ten thousand crore rupees, for Bhutan's thirteenth Five Year Plan covering 2024 to 2029, a rail-link memorandum of understanding of 29 September 2025 for the Kokrajhar-Gelephu and Banarhat-Samtse links, and support for Gelephu Mindfulness City expressed on 12 November 2025; the evidentiary boundary is that these are a commitment, a memorandum and political support rather than commissioned rail links or an operating city, and that project delay, cost escalation, ecological effects and Bhutan's diversification concerns require balance. C. During the Prime Minister's visit of 5 April 2025 seven memoranda of understanding were exchanged with Sri Lanka, covering high-voltage direct-current power interconnection, digital transformation, the India-Sri Lanka-United Arab Emirates Trincomalee energy hub, defence cooperation, Eastern Province grant assistance, health and medicine, and pharmacopoeial cooperation, and the Ministry of External Affairs bilateral brief on India-Sri Lanka was current to July 2026; the owners fix the evidentiary level precisely, recording that signed memoranda are not proof that each project is operational and that the 120 megawatt Sampur solar project had its ground-breaking rather than its commissioning, while the same visit inaugurated five thousand rooftop solar units and a warehouse. D. The India-Maldives Joint Vision of 7 October 2024 records support of four hundred million United States dollars and thirty billion Indian rupees as a currency-swap arrangement, the Terms of Reference for a free trade agreement were signed and negotiations launched on 25 July 2025, a line of credit of 4,850 crore Indian rupees is recorded, and the Ministry of External Affairs bilateral brief on India-Maldives was current to June 2026; the owners state expressly that a vision document, terms of reference and a line of credit are pre-delivery instruments and that no free trade agreement has been concluded, and they route the deeper Maldives treatment to topic 04 because its geostrategic salience is primarily maritime and is addressed by the 2024 objective demand recorded there.

Answer: B. Explanation: The 720 megawatt Mangdechhu project was commissioned in 2019 and handed over to Bhutan in 2022, illustrating joint project delivery and electricity trade that links Bhutanese revenue to Indian clean-power access, and the owners record India's commitment of one hundred billion Indian rupees, equivalently ten thousand crore rupees, for Bhutan's thirteenth Five Year Plan covering 2024 to 2029, a rail-link memorandum of understanding of 29 September 2025 for the Kokrajhar-Gelephu and Banarhat-Samtse links, and support for Gelephu Mindfulness City expressed on 12 November 2025; the evidentiary boundary is that these are a commitment, a memorandum and political support rather than commissioned rail links or an operating city, and that project delay, cost escalation, ecological effects and Bhutan's diversification concerns require balance. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q39. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Bhutan hydropower and the current commitment set?

A. By 3 May 2022 India's High Commission recorded more than three billion United States dollars in assistance during 2022, comprising a one billion dollar facility for food, medicines and essentials, a five hundred million dollar petroleum credit line, about one billion dollars in Asian Clearing Union payment deferment and a four hundred million dollar Reserve Bank of India currency swap, while the petroleum line had delivered close to four hundred thousand tonnes of fuel across all twenty-five districts and the essentials facility had supplied rice and other necessities with medical consignments providing a humanitarian component; the owners require the aggregate to be time-bounded, since full-year descriptions commonly place support at around four billion dollars over 2022, and they record the limitation that emergency financing did not remove Sri Lanka's structural debt, revenue, governance and external-financing problems, whose durable resolution required domestic adjustment and an International Monetary Fund-supported programme. B. The India-Maldives Joint Vision of 7 October 2024 records support of four hundred million United States dollars and thirty billion Indian rupees as a currency-swap arrangement, the Terms of Reference for a free trade agreement were signed and negotiations launched on 25 July 2025, a line of credit of 4,850 crore Indian rupees is recorded, and the Ministry of External Affairs bilateral brief on India-Maldives was current to June 2026; the owners state expressly that a vision document, terms of reference and a line of credit are pre-delivery instruments and that no free trade agreement has been concluded, and they route the deeper Maldives treatment to topic 04 because its geostrategic salience is primarily maritime and is addressed by the 2024 objective demand recorded there. C. The 720 megawatt Mangdechhu project was commissioned in 2019 and handed over to Bhutan in 2022, illustrating joint project delivery and electricity trade that links Bhutanese revenue to Indian clean-power access, and the owners record India's commitment of one hundred billion Indian rupees, equivalently ten thousand crore rupees, for Bhutan's thirteenth Five Year Plan covering 2024 to 2029, a rail-link memorandum of understanding of 29 September 2025 for the Kokrajhar-Gelephu and Banarhat-Samtse links, and support for Gelephu Mindfulness City expressed on 12 November 2025; the evidentiary boundary is that these are a commitment, a memorandum and political support rather than commissioned rail links or an operating city, and that project delay, cost escalation, ecological effects and Bhutan's diversification concerns require balance. D. During the Prime Minister's visit of 5 April 2025 seven memoranda of understanding were exchanged with Sri Lanka, covering high-voltage direct-current power interconnection, digital transformation, the India-Sri Lanka-United Arab Emirates Trincomalee energy hub, defence cooperation, Eastern Province grant assistance, health and medicine, and pharmacopoeial cooperation, and the Ministry of External Affairs bilateral brief on India-Sri Lanka was current to July 2026; the owners fix the evidentiary level precisely, recording that signed memoranda are not proof that each project is operational and that the 120 megawatt Sampur solar project had its ground-breaking rather than its commissioning, while the same visit inaugurated five thousand rooftop solar units and a warehouse.

Answer: C. Explanation: The 720 megawatt Mangdechhu project was commissioned in 2019 and handed over to Bhutan in 2022, illustrating joint project delivery and electricity trade that links Bhutanese revenue to Indian clean-power access, and the owners record India's commitment of one hundred billion Indian rupees, equivalently ten thousand crore rupees, for Bhutan's thirteenth Five Year Plan covering 2024 to 2029, a rail-link memorandum of understanding of 29 September 2025 for the Kokrajhar-Gelephu and Banarhat-Samtse links, and support for Gelephu Mindfulness City expressed on 12 November 2025; the evidentiary boundary is that these are a commitment, a memorandum and political support rather than commissioned rail links or an operating city, and that project delay, cost escalation, ecological effects and Bhutan's diversification concerns require balance. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q40. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Bhutan hydropower and the current commitment set?

A. By 3 May 2022 India's High Commission recorded more than three billion United States dollars in assistance during 2022, comprising a one billion dollar facility for food, medicines and essentials, a five hundred million dollar petroleum credit line, about one billion dollars in Asian Clearing Union payment deferment and a four hundred million dollar Reserve Bank of India currency swap, while the petroleum line had delivered close to four hundred thousand tonnes of fuel across all twenty-five districts and the essentials facility had supplied rice and other necessities with medical consignments providing a humanitarian component; the owners require the aggregate to be time-bounded, since full-year descriptions commonly place support at around four billion dollars over 2022, and they record the limitation

that emergency financing did not remove Sri Lanka's structural debt, revenue, governance and external-financing problems, whose durable resolution required domestic adjustment and an International Monetary Fund-supported programme. B. India engaged Bangladesh's interim government from 16 August 2024 and pressed for early inclusive elections on 20 August 2025, parliamentary elections were held on 12 February 2026, and the 1996 Ganga Waters Treaty expires in December 2026 with India stating on 13 February 2026 that renewal talks had not begun; the owners classify this evidence exactly as engagement plus an election fact plus a treaty-expiry fact and no renewed treaty, which makes it the cleanest available test of whether Neighbourhood First engagement attaches to a state rather than to an incumbent government. C. The India-Maldives Joint Vision of 7 October 2024 records support of four hundred million United States dollars and thirty billion Indian rupees as a currency-swap arrangement, the Terms of Reference for a free trade agreement were signed and negotiations launched on 25 July 2025, a line of credit of 4,850 crore Indian rupees is recorded, and the Ministry of External Affairs bilateral brief on India-Maldives was current to June 2026; the owners state expressly that a vision document, terms of reference and a line of credit are pre-delivery instruments and that no free trade agreement has been concluded, and they route the deeper Maldives treatment to topic 04 because its geostrategic salience is primarily maritime and is addressed by the 2024 objective demand recorded there. D. The 720 megawatt Mangdechhu project was commissioned in 2019 and handed over to Bhutan in 2022, illustrating joint project delivery and electricity trade that links Bhutanese revenue to Indian clean-power access, and the owners record India's commitment of one hundred billion Indian rupees, equivalently ten thousand crore rupees, for Bhutan's thirteenth Five Year Plan covering 2024 to 2029, a rail-link memorandum of understanding of 29 September 2025 for the Kokrajhar-Gelephu and Banarhat-Samtse links, and support for Gelephu Mindfulness City expressed on 12 November 2025; the evidentiary boundary is that these are a commitment, a memorandum and political support rather than commissioned rail links or an operating city, and that project delay, cost escalation, ecological effects and Bhutan's diversification concerns require balance.

Answer: D. Explanation: The 720 megawatt Mangdechhu project was commissioned in 2019 and handed over to Bhutan in 2022, illustrating joint project delivery and electricity trade that links Bhutanese revenue to Indian clean-power access, and the owners record India's commitment of one hundred billion Indian rupees, equivalently ten thousand crore rupees, for Bhutan's thirteenth Five Year Plan covering 2024 to 2029, a rail-link memorandum of understanding of 29 September 2025 for the Kokrajhar-Gelephu and Banarhat-Samtse links, and support for Gelephu Mindfulness City expressed on 12 November 2025; the evidentiary boundary is that these are a commitment, a memorandum and political support rather than commissioned rail links or an operating city, and that project delay, cost escalation, ecological effects and Bhutan's diversification concerns require balance. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q41. Which statement correctly identifies Teesta and the federal constraint on neighbourhood diplomacy?

A. The unresolved Teesta water-sharing issue demonstrates how Indian state-level interests can constrain a bilateral agreement with Bangladesh, and the owners draw the general lesson that neighbourhood diplomacy is shaped by domestic federal and border stakeholders rather than by the external ministry alone; the qualification carried with it is equally examinable, namely that one dispute should not be allowed to erase the wider record of connectivity and security cooperation, so the correct treatment is to name the federal constraint as a specific limiting mechanism instead of generalising it into a verdict on the whole relationship. B. During the Prime Minister's visit of 5 April 2025 seven memoranda of understanding were exchanged with Sri Lanka, covering high-voltage direct-current power interconnection, digital transformation, the India-Sri Lanka-United Arab Emirates Trincomalee energy hub, defence cooperation, Eastern Province grant assistance, health and medicine, and pharmacopoeial cooperation, and the Ministry of External Affairs bilateral brief on India-Sri Lanka was current to July 2026; the owners fix the evidentiary level precisely, recording that signed memoranda are not proof that each project is operational and that the 120 megawatt Sampur solar project had its ground-breaking rather than its commissioning, while the same visit inaugurated five thousand rooftop solar units and a warehouse. C. The India-Maldives Joint Vision of 7 October 2024 records support of four hundred million United States dollars and thirty billion Indian rupees as a currency-swap arrangement, the Terms of Reference for a free trade agreement were signed and negotiations launched on 25 July 2025, a line of credit of 4,850 crore Indian rupees is recorded, and the Ministry of External Affairs bilateral brief on India-Maldives was current to June 2026; the owners state expressly that a vision document, terms of reference and a line of credit are pre-delivery instruments and that no free trade agreement has been concluded, and they route the

deeper Maldives treatment to topic 04 because its geostrategic salience is primarily maritime and is addressed by the 2024 objective demand recorded there. D. The Kaladan Multi-Modal Transit Transport Project and the India-Myanmar-Thailand Trilateral Highway aim to connect India's Northeast with Myanmar and Southeast Asia, and the owners record that on Kaladan the waterway and Sittwe Port were operationalised in May 2023 while the road component lagged, with both sides still calling for completion on 1 June 2026; the recorded reading is that the real gap in neighbourhood infrastructure is typically between a segment delivered and a corridor completed rather than between announcement and total inaction, and that conflict, incomplete road segments and border procedures mean an announced corridor is not seamless connectivity.

Answer: A. Explanation: The unresolved Teesta water-sharing issue demonstrates how Indian state-level interests can constrain a bilateral agreement with Bangladesh, and the owners draw the general lesson that neighbourhood diplomacy is shaped by domestic federal and border stakeholders rather than by the external ministry alone; the qualification carried with it is equally examinable, namely that one dispute should not be allowed to erase the wider record of connectivity and security cooperation, so the correct treatment is to name the federal constraint as a specific limiting mechanism instead of generalising it into a verdict on the whole relationship. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q42. Which card should be filed under Teesta and the federal constraint on neighbourhood diplomacy in an International Relations answer?

A. During the Prime Minister's visit of 5 April 2025 seven memoranda of understanding were exchanged with Sri Lanka, covering high-voltage direct-current power interconnection, digital transformation, the India-Sri Lanka-United Arab Emirates Trincomalee energy hub, defence cooperation, Eastern Province grant assistance, health and medicine, and pharmacopoeial cooperation, and the Ministry of External Affairs bilateral brief on India-Sri Lanka was current to July 2026; the owners fix the evidentiary level precisely, recording that signed memoranda are not proof that each project is operational and that the 120 megawatt Sampur solar project had its ground-breaking rather than its commissioning, while the same visit inaugurated five thousand rooftop solar units and a warehouse. B. The unresolved Teesta water-sharing issue demonstrates how Indian state-level interests can constrain a bilateral agreement with Bangladesh, and the owners draw the general lesson that neighbourhood diplomacy is shaped by domestic federal and border stakeholders rather than by the external ministry alone; the qualification carried with it is equally examinable, namely that one dispute should not be allowed to erase the wider record of connectivity and security cooperation, so the correct treatment is to name the federal constraint as a specific limiting mechanism instead of generalising it into a verdict on the whole relationship. C. The India-Maldives Joint Vision of 7 October 2024 records support of four hundred million United States dollars and thirty billion Indian rupees as a currency-swap arrangement, the Terms of Reference for a free trade agreement were signed and negotiations launched on 25 July 2025, a line of credit of 4,850 crore Indian rupees is recorded, and the Ministry of External Affairs bilateral brief on India-Maldives was current to June 2026; the owners state expressly that a vision document, terms of reference and a line of credit are pre-delivery instruments and that no free trade agreement has been concluded, and they route the deeper Maldives treatment to topic 04 because its geostrategic salience is primarily maritime and is addressed by the 2024 objective demand recorded there. D. By 3 May 2022 India's High Commission recorded more than three billion United States dollars in assistance during 2022, comprising a one billion dollar facility for food, medicines and essentials, a five hundred million dollar petroleum credit line, about one billion dollars in Asian Clearing Union payment deferment and a four hundred million dollar Reserve Bank of India currency swap, while the petroleum line had delivered close to four hundred thousand tonnes of fuel across all twenty-five districts and the essentials facility had supplied rice and other necessities with medical consignments providing a humanitarian component; the owners require the aggregate to be time-bounded, since full-year descriptions commonly place support at around four billion dollars over 2022, and they record the limitation that emergency financing did not remove Sri Lanka's structural debt, revenue, governance and external-financing problems, whose durable resolution required domestic adjustment and an International Monetary Fund-supported programme.

Answer: B. Explanation: The unresolved Teesta water-sharing issue demonstrates how Indian state-level interests can constrain a bilateral agreement with Bangladesh, and the owners draw the general lesson that neighbourhood diplomacy is shaped by domestic federal and border stakeholders rather than by the external ministry alone; the qualification carried with it is equally examinable, namely that one dispute should not be allowed to erase the wider record of connectivity and security cooperation, so the correct treatment is to

name the federal constraint as a specific limiting mechanism instead of generalising it into a verdict on the whole relationship. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q43. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Teesta and the federal constraint on neighbourhood diplomacy?

A. The India-Maldives Joint Vision of 7 October 2024 records support of four hundred million United States dollars and thirty billion Indian rupees as a currency-swap arrangement, the Terms of Reference for a free trade agreement were signed and negotiations launched on 25 July 2025, a line of credit of 4,850 crore Indian rupees is recorded, and the Ministry of External Affairs bilateral brief on India-Maldives was current to June 2026; the owners state expressly that a vision document, terms of reference and a line of credit are pre-delivery instruments and that no free trade agreement has been concluded, and they route the deeper Maldives treatment to topic 04 because its geostrategic salience is primarily maritime and is addressed by the 2024 objective demand recorded there. B. India engaged Bangladesh's interim government from 16 August 2024 and pressed for early inclusive elections on 20 August 2025, parliamentary elections were held on 12 February 2026, and the 1996 Ganga Waters Treaty expires in December 2026 with India stating on 13 February 2026 that renewal talks had not begun; the owners classify this evidence exactly as engagement plus an election fact plus a treaty-expiry fact and no renewed treaty, which makes it the cleanest available test of whether Neighbourhood First engagement attaches to a state rather than to an incumbent government. C. The unresolved Teesta water-sharing issue demonstrates how Indian state-level interests can constrain a bilateral agreement with Bangladesh, and the owners draw the general lesson that neighbourhood diplomacy is shaped by domestic federal and border stakeholders rather than by the external ministry alone; the qualification carried with it is equally examinable, namely that one dispute should not be allowed to erase the wider record of connectivity and security cooperation, so the correct treatment is to name the federal constraint as a specific limiting mechanism instead of generalising it into a verdict on the whole relationship. D. By 3 May 2022 India's High Commission recorded more than three billion United States dollars in assistance during 2022, comprising a one billion dollar facility for food, medicines and essentials, a five hundred million dollar petroleum credit line, about one billion dollars in Asian Clearing Union payment deferment and a four hundred million dollar Reserve Bank of India currency swap, while the petroleum line had delivered close to four hundred thousand tonnes of fuel across all twenty-five districts and the essentials facility had supplied rice and other necessities with medical consignments providing a humanitarian component; the owners require the aggregate to be time-bounded, since full-year descriptions commonly place support at around four billion dollars over 2022, and they record the limitation that emergency financing did not remove Sri Lanka's structural debt, revenue, governance and external-financing problems, whose durable resolution required domestic adjustment and an International Monetary Fund-supported programme.

Answer: C. Explanation: The unresolved Teesta water-sharing issue demonstrates how Indian state-level interests can constrain a bilateral agreement with Bangladesh, and the owners draw the general lesson that neighbourhood diplomacy is shaped by domestic federal and border stakeholders rather than by the external ministry alone; the qualification carried with it is equally examinable, namely that one dispute should not be allowed to erase the wider record of connectivity and security cooperation, so the correct treatment is to name the federal constraint as a specific limiting mechanism instead of generalising it into a verdict on the whole relationship. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q44. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Teesta and the federal constraint on neighbourhood diplomacy?

A. India welcomed the interim government led by Sushila Karki on 12 September 2025 after the unrest of September 2025, elections were held on 5 March 2026, and the understanding on importing ten thousand megawatts over ten years dates from 2 June 2023; the owners classify this as political engagement plus an agreed power-trade target and record expressly that it is not a revised Treaty of 1950, so an answer must not convert an energy-trade understanding into a renegotiated foundational treaty, and must read the sequence alongside Bangladesh and Sri Lanka as three simultaneous transition tests inside a single cycle. B. By 3 May 2022 India's High Commission recorded more than three billion United States dollars in assistance during 2022, comprising a one billion dollar facility for food, medicines and essentials, a five hundred million dollar petroleum credit line, about one billion dollars in Asian Clearing Union payment deferment and a four hundred million dollar Reserve Bank of India currency swap, while the petroleum line

had delivered close to four hundred thousand tonnes of fuel across all twenty-five districts and the essentials facility had supplied rice and other necessities with medical consignments providing a humanitarian component; the owners require the aggregate to be time-bounded, since full-year descriptions commonly place support at around four billion dollars over 2022, and they record the limitation that emergency financing did not remove Sri Lanka's structural debt, revenue, governance and external-financing problems, whose durable resolution required domestic adjustment and an International Monetary Fund-supported programme. C. India engaged Bangladesh's interim government from 16 August 2024 and pressed for early inclusive elections on 20 August 2025, parliamentary elections were held on 12 February 2026, and the 1996 Ganga Waters Treaty expires in December 2026 with India stating on 13 February 2026 that renewal talks had not begun; the owners classify this evidence exactly as engagement plus an election fact plus a treaty-expiry fact and no renewed treaty, which makes it the cleanest available test of whether Neighbourhood First engagement attaches to a state rather than to an incumbent government. D. The unresolved Teesta water-sharing issue demonstrates how Indian state-level interests can constrain a bilateral agreement with Bangladesh, and the owners draw the general lesson that neighbourhood diplomacy is shaped by domestic federal and border stakeholders rather than by the external ministry alone; the qualification carried with it is equally examinable, namely that one dispute should not be allowed to erase the wider record of connectivity and security cooperation, so the correct treatment is to name the federal constraint as a specific limiting mechanism instead of generalising it into a verdict on the whole relationship.

Answer: D. Explanation: The unresolved Teesta water-sharing issue demonstrates how Indian state-level interests can constrain a bilateral agreement with Bangladesh, and the owners draw the general lesson that neighbourhood diplomacy is shaped by domestic federal and border stakeholders rather than by the external ministry alone; the qualification carried with it is equally examinable, namely that one dispute should not be allowed to erase the wider record of connectivity and security cooperation, so the correct treatment is to name the federal constraint as a specific limiting mechanism instead of generalising it into a verdict on the whole relationship. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q45. Which statement correctly identifies Act East physical routes and the segment-against-corridor distinction?

A. The Kaladan Multi-Modal Transit Transport Project and the India-Myanmar-Thailand Trilateral Highway aim to connect India's Northeast with Myanmar and Southeast Asia, and the owners record that on Kaladan the waterway and Sittwe Port were operationalised in May 2023 while the road component lagged, with both sides still calling for completion on 1 June 2026; the recorded reading is that the real gap in neighbourhood infrastructure is typically between a segment delivered and a corridor completed rather than between announcement and total inaction, and that conflict, incomplete road segments and border procedures mean an announced corridor is not seamless connectivity. B. The India-Maldives Joint Vision of 7 October 2024 records support of four hundred million United States dollars and thirty billion Indian rupees as a currency-swap arrangement, the Terms of Reference for a free trade agreement were signed and negotiations launched on 25 July 2025, a line of credit of 4,850 crore Indian rupees is recorded, and the Ministry of External Affairs bilateral brief on India-Maldives was current to June 2026; the owners state expressly that a vision document, terms of reference and a line of credit are pre-delivery instruments and that no free trade agreement has been concluded, and they route the deeper Maldives treatment to topic 04 because its geostrategic salience is primarily maritime and is addressed by the 2024 objective demand recorded there. C. By 3 May 2022 India's High Commission recorded more than three billion United States dollars in assistance during 2022, comprising a one billion dollar facility for food, medicines and essentials, a five hundred million dollar petroleum credit line, about one billion dollars in Asian Clearing Union payment deferment and a four hundred million dollar Reserve Bank of India currency swap, while the petroleum line had delivered close to four hundred thousand tonnes of fuel across all twenty-five districts and the essentials facility had supplied rice and other necessities with medical consignments providing a humanitarian component; the owners require the aggregate to be time-bounded, since full-year descriptions commonly place support at around four billion dollars over 2022, and they record the limitation that emergency financing did not remove Sri Lanka's structural debt, revenue, governance and external-financing problems, whose durable resolution required domestic adjustment and an International Monetary Fund-supported programme. D. During the Prime Minister's visit of 5 April 2025 seven memoranda of understanding were exchanged with Sri Lanka, covering high-voltage direct-current power interconnection, digital transformation, the India-Sri Lanka-United Arab Emirates Trincomalee energy hub, defence cooperation, Eastern Province grant assistance, health

and medicine, and pharmacopoeial cooperation, and the Ministry of External Affairs bilateral brief on India-Sri Lanka was current to July 2026; the owners fix the evidentiary level precisely, recording that signed memoranda are not proof that each project is operational and that the 120 megawatt Sampur solar project had its ground-breaking rather than its commissioning, while the same visit inaugurated five thousand rooftop solar units and a warehouse.

Answer: A. Explanation: The Kaladan Multi-Modal Transit Transport Project and the India-Myanmar-Thailand Trilateral Highway aim to connect India's Northeast with Myanmar and Southeast Asia, and the owners record that on Kaladan the waterway and Sittwe Port were operationalised in May 2023 while the road component lagged, with both sides still calling for completion on 1 June 2026; the recorded reading is that the real gap in neighbourhood infrastructure is typically between a segment delivered and a corridor completed rather than between announcement and total inaction, and that conflict, incomplete road segments and border procedures mean an announced corridor is not seamless connectivity. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q46. Which card should be filed under Act East physical routes and the segment-against-corridor distinction in an International Relations answer?

A. India engaged Bangladesh's interim government from 16 August 2024 and pressed for early inclusive elections on 20 August 2025, parliamentary elections were held on 12 February 2026, and the 1996 Ganga Waters Treaty expires in December 2026 with India stating on 13 February 2026 that renewal talks had not begun; the owners classify this evidence exactly as engagement plus an election fact plus a treaty-expiry fact and no renewed treaty, which makes it the cleanest available test of whether Neighbourhood First engagement attaches to a state rather than to an incumbent government. B. The Kaladan Multi-Modal Transit Transport Project and the India-Myanmar-Thailand Trilateral Highway aim to connect India's Northeast with Myanmar and Southeast Asia, and the owners record that on Kaladan the waterway and Sittwe Port were operationalised in May 2023 while the road component lagged, with both sides still calling for completion on 1 June 2026; the recorded reading is that the real gap in neighbourhood infrastructure is typically between a segment delivered and a corridor completed rather than between announcement and total inaction, and that conflict, incomplete road segments and border procedures mean an announced corridor is not seamless connectivity. C. The India-Maldives Joint Vision of 7 October 2024 records support of four hundred million United States dollars and thirty billion Indian rupees as a currency-swap arrangement, the Terms of Reference for a free trade agreement were signed and negotiations launched on 25 July 2025, a line of credit of 4,850 crore Indian rupees is recorded, and the Ministry of External Affairs bilateral brief on India-Maldives was current to June 2026; the owners state expressly that a vision document, terms of reference and a line of credit are pre-delivery instruments and that no free trade agreement has been concluded, and they route the deeper Maldives treatment to topic 04 because its geostrategic salience is primarily maritime and is addressed by the 2024 objective demand recorded there. D. By 3 May 2022 India's High Commission recorded more than three billion United States dollars in assistance during 2022, comprising a one billion dollar facility for food, medicines and essentials, a five hundred million dollar petroleum credit line, about one billion dollars in Asian Clearing Union payment deferment and a four hundred million dollar Reserve Bank of India currency swap, while the petroleum line had delivered close to four hundred thousand tonnes of fuel across all twenty-five districts and the essentials facility had supplied rice and other necessities with medical consignments providing a humanitarian component; the owners require the aggregate to be time-bounded, since full-year descriptions commonly place support at around four billion dollars over 2022, and they record the limitation that emergency financing did not remove Sri Lanka's structural debt, revenue, governance and external-financing problems, whose durable resolution required domestic adjustment and an International Monetary Fund-supported programme.

Answer: B. Explanation: The Kaladan Multi-Modal Transit Transport Project and the India-Myanmar-Thailand Trilateral Highway aim to connect India's Northeast with Myanmar and Southeast Asia, and the owners record that on Kaladan the waterway and Sittwe Port were operationalised in May 2023 while the road component lagged, with both sides still calling for completion on 1 June 2026; the recorded reading is that the real gap in neighbourhood infrastructure is typically between a segment delivered and a corridor completed rather than between announcement and total inaction, and that conflict, incomplete road segments and border procedures mean an announced corridor is not seamless connectivity. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q47. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Act East physical routes and the segment-against-corridor distinction?

A. India engaged Bangladesh's interim government from 16 August 2024 and pressed for early inclusive elections on 20 August 2025, parliamentary elections were held on 12 February 2026, and the 1996 Ganga Waters Treaty expires in December 2026 with India stating on 13 February 2026 that renewal talks had not begun; the owners classify this evidence exactly as engagement plus an election fact plus a treaty-expiry fact and no renewed treaty, which makes it the cleanest available test of whether Neighbourhood First engagement attaches to a state rather than to an incumbent government. B. India welcomed the interim government led by Sushila Karki on 12 September 2025 after the unrest of September 2025, elections were held on 5 March 2026, and the understanding on importing ten thousand megawatts over ten years dates from 2 June 2023; the owners classify this as political engagement plus an agreed power-trade target and record expressly that it is not a revised Treaty of 1950, so an answer must not convert an energy-trade understanding into a renegotiated foundational treaty, and must read the sequence alongside Bangladesh and Sri Lanka as three simultaneous transition tests inside a single cycle. C. The Kaladan Multi-Modal Transit Transport Project and the India-Myanmar-Thailand Trilateral Highway aim to connect India's Northeast with Myanmar and Southeast Asia, and the owners record that on Kaladan the waterway and Sittwe Port were operationalised in May 2023 while the road component lagged, with both sides still calling for completion on 1 June 2026; the recorded reading is that the real gap in neighbourhood infrastructure is typically between a segment delivered and a corridor completed rather than between announcement and total inaction, and that conflict, incomplete road segments and border procedures mean an announced corridor is not seamless connectivity. D. By 3 May 2022 India's High Commission recorded more than three billion United States dollars in assistance during 2022, comprising a one billion dollar facility for food, medicines and essentials, a five hundred million dollar petroleum credit line, about one billion dollars in Asian Clearing Union payment deferment and a four hundred million dollar Reserve Bank of India currency swap, while the petroleum line had delivered close to four hundred thousand tonnes of fuel across all twenty-five districts and the essentials facility had supplied rice and other necessities with medical consignments providing a humanitarian component; the owners require the aggregate to be time-bounded, since full-year descriptions commonly place support at around four billion dollars over 2022, and they record the limitation that emergency financing did not remove Sri Lanka's structural debt, revenue, governance and external-financing problems, whose durable resolution required domestic adjustment and an International Monetary Fund-supported programme.

Answer: C. Explanation: The Kaladan Multi-Modal Transit Transport Project and the India-Myanmar-Thailand Trilateral Highway aim to connect India's Northeast with Myanmar and Southeast Asia, and the owners record that on Kaladan the waterway and Sittwe Port were operationalised in May 2023 while the road component lagged, with both sides still calling for completion on 1 June 2026; the recorded reading is that the real gap in neighbourhood infrastructure is typically between a segment delivered and a corridor completed rather than between announcement and total inaction, and that conflict, incomplete road segments and border procedures mean an announced corridor is not seamless connectivity. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q48. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Act East physical routes and the segment-against-corridor distinction?

A. India welcomed the interim government led by Sushila Karki on 12 September 2025 after the unrest of September 2025, elections were held on 5 March 2026, and the understanding on importing ten thousand megawatts over ten years dates from 2 June 2023; the owners classify this as political engagement plus an agreed power-trade target and record expressly that it is not a revised Treaty of 1950, so an answer must not convert an energy-trade understanding into a renegotiated foundational treaty, and must read the sequence alongside Bangladesh and Sri Lanka as three simultaneous transition tests inside a single cycle. B. India engaged the Taliban administration through the Foreign Secretary's Dubai meeting of 8 January 2025 and the External Affairs Minister's New Delhi meeting of 10 October 2025, and restored its Kabul Technical Mission to Embassy status with immediate effect on 21 October 2025; the owners state explicitly that this is a change in the level of India's diplomatic presence and that the official record contains no recognition declaration, so the upgrade must never be reported as recognition of the administration, and the near-neighbour framing from Tharoor supplies the reason the relationship is treated as vital to national security despite the absence of a direct pre-1947 border. C. India engaged Bangladesh's interim government from 16 August 2024 and pressed for early inclusive elections on 20 August 2025, parliamentary elections were held on 12 February

2026, and the 1996 Ganga Waters Treaty expires in December 2026 with India stating on 13 February 2026 that renewal talks had not begun; the owners classify this evidence exactly as engagement plus an election fact plus a treaty-expiry fact and no renewed treaty, which makes it the cleanest available test of whether Neighbourhood First engagement attaches to a state rather than to an incumbent government. D. The Kaladan Multi-Modal Transit Transport Project and the India-Myanmar-Thailand Trilateral Highway aim to connect India's Northeast with Myanmar and Southeast Asia, and the owners record that on Kaladan the waterway and Sittwe Port were operationalised in May 2023 while the road component lagged, with both sides still calling for completion on 1 June 2026; the recorded reading is that the real gap in neighbourhood infrastructure is typically between a segment delivered and a corridor completed rather than between announcement and total inaction, and that conflict, incomplete road segments and border procedures mean an announced corridor is not seamless connectivity.

Answer: D. Explanation: The Kaladan Multi-Modal Transit Transport Project and the India-Myanmar-Thailand Trilateral Highway aim to connect India's Northeast with Myanmar and Southeast Asia, and the owners record that on Kaladan the waterway and Sittwe Port were operationalised in May 2023 while the road component lagged, with both sides still calling for completion on 1 June 2026; the recorded reading is that the real gap in neighbourhood infrastructure is typically between a segment delivered and a corridor completed rather than between announcement and total inaction, and that conflict, incomplete road segments and border procedures mean an announced corridor is not seamless connectivity. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q49. Which statement correctly identifies Sri Lanka's current instrument set and its pre-delivery status?

A. During the Prime Minister's visit of 5 April 2025 seven memoranda of understanding were exchanged with Sri Lanka, covering high-voltage direct-current power interconnection, digital transformation, the India-Sri Lanka-United Arab Emirates Trincomalee energy hub, defence cooperation, Eastern Province grant assistance, health and medicine, and pharmacopoeial cooperation, and the Ministry of External Affairs bilateral brief on India-Sri Lanka was current to July 2026; the owners fix the evidentiary level precisely, recording that signed memoranda are not proof that each project is operational and that the 120 megawatt Sampur solar project had its ground-breaking rather than its commissioning, while the same visit inaugurated five thousand rooftop solar units and a warehouse. B. The India-Maldives Joint Vision of 7 October 2024 records support of four hundred million United States dollars and thirty billion Indian rupees as a currency-swap arrangement, the Terms of Reference for a free trade agreement were signed and negotiations launched on 25 July 2025, a line of credit of 4,850 crore Indian rupees is recorded, and the Ministry of External Affairs bilateral brief on India-Maldives was current to June 2026; the owners state expressly that a vision document, terms of reference and a line of credit are pre-delivery instruments and that no free trade agreement has been concluded, and they route the deeper Maldives treatment to topic 04 because its geostrategic salience is primarily maritime and is addressed by the 2024 objective demand recorded there. C. By 3 May 2022 India's High Commission recorded more than three billion United States dollars in assistance during 2022, comprising a one billion dollar facility for food, medicines and essentials, a five hundred million dollar petroleum credit line, about one billion dollars in Asian Clearing Union payment deferment and a four hundred million dollar Reserve Bank of India currency swap, while the petroleum line had delivered close to four hundred thousand tonnes of fuel across all twenty-five districts and the essentials facility had supplied rice and other necessities with medical consignments providing a humanitarian component; the owners require the aggregate to be time-bounded, since full-year descriptions commonly place support at around four billion dollars over 2022, and they record the limitation that emergency financing did not remove Sri Lanka's structural debt, revenue, governance and external-financing problems, whose durable resolution required domestic adjustment and an International Monetary Fund-supported programme. D. India engaged Bangladesh's interim government from 16 August 2024 and pressed for early inclusive elections on 20 August 2025, parliamentary elections were held on 12 February 2026, and the 1996 Ganga Waters Treaty expires in December 2026 with India stating on 13 February 2026 that renewal talks had not begun; the owners classify this evidence exactly as engagement plus an election fact plus a treaty-expiry fact and no renewed treaty, which makes it the cleanest available test of whether Neighbourhood First engagement attaches to a state rather than to an incumbent government.

Answer: A. Explanation: During the Prime Minister's visit of 5 April 2025 seven memoranda of understanding were exchanged with Sri Lanka, covering high-voltage direct-current power interconnection, digital transformation, the India-Sri Lanka-United Arab Emirates Trincomalee energy hub, defence cooperation,

Eastern Province grant assistance, health and medicine, and pharmacopoeial cooperation, and the Ministry of External Affairs bilateral brief on India-Sri Lanka was current to July 2026; the owners fix the evidentiary level precisely, recording that signed memoranda are not proof that each project is operational and that the 120 megawatt Sampur solar project had its ground-breaking rather than its commissioning, while the same visit inaugurated five thousand rooftop solar units and a warehouse. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q50. Which card should be filed under Sri Lanka's current instrument set and its pre-delivery status in an International Relations answer?

A. India welcomed the interim government led by Sushila Karki on 12 September 2025 after the unrest of September 2025, elections were held on 5 March 2026, and the understanding on importing ten thousand megawatts over ten years dates from 2 June 2023; the owners classify this as political engagement plus an agreed power-trade target and record expressly that it is not a revised Treaty of 1950, so an answer must not convert an energy-trade understanding into a renegotiated foundational treaty, and must read the sequence alongside Bangladesh and Sri Lanka as three simultaneous transition tests inside a single cycle. B. During the Prime Minister's visit of 5 April 2025 seven memoranda of understanding were exchanged with Sri Lanka, covering high-voltage direct-current power interconnection, digital transformation, the India-Sri Lanka-United Arab Emirates Trincomalee energy hub, defence cooperation, Eastern Province grant assistance, health and medicine, and pharmacopoeial cooperation, and the Ministry of External Affairs bilateral brief on India-Sri Lanka was current to July 2026; the owners fix the evidentiary level precisely, recording that signed memoranda are not proof that each project is operational and that the 120 megawatt Sampur solar project had its ground-breaking rather than its commissioning, while the same visit inaugurated five thousand rooftop solar units and a warehouse. C. By 3 May 2022 India's High Commission recorded more than three billion United States dollars in assistance during 2022, comprising a one billion dollar facility for food, medicines and essentials, a five hundred million dollar petroleum credit line, about one billion dollars in Asian Clearing Union payment deferment and a four hundred million dollar Reserve Bank of India currency swap, while the petroleum line had delivered close to four hundred thousand tonnes of fuel across all twenty-five districts and the essentials facility had supplied rice and other necessities with medical consignments providing a humanitarian component; the owners require the aggregate to be time-bounded, since full-year descriptions commonly place support at around four billion dollars over 2022, and they record the limitation that emergency financing did not remove Sri Lanka's structural debt, revenue, governance and external-financing problems, whose durable resolution required domestic adjustment and an International Monetary Fund-supported programme. D. India engaged Bangladesh's interim government from 16 August 2024 and pressed for early inclusive elections on 20 August 2025, parliamentary elections were held on 12 February 2026, and the 1996 Ganga Waters Treaty expires in December 2026 with India stating on 13 February 2026 that renewal talks had not begun; the owners classify this evidence exactly as engagement plus an election fact plus a treaty-expiry fact and no renewed treaty, which makes it the cleanest available test of whether Neighbourhood First engagement attaches to a state rather than to an incumbent government.

Answer: B. Explanation: During the Prime Minister's visit of 5 April 2025 seven memoranda of understanding were exchanged with Sri Lanka, covering high-voltage direct-current power interconnection, digital transformation, the India-Sri Lanka-United Arab Emirates Trincomalee energy hub, defence cooperation, Eastern Province grant assistance, health and medicine, and pharmacopoeial cooperation, and the Ministry of External Affairs bilateral brief on India-Sri Lanka was current to July 2026; the owners fix the evidentiary level precisely, recording that signed memoranda are not proof that each project is operational and that the 120 megawatt Sampur solar project had its ground-breaking rather than its commissioning, while the same visit inaugurated five thousand rooftop solar units and a warehouse. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q51. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Sri Lanka's current instrument set and its pre-delivery status?

A. India welcomed the interim government led by Sushila Karki on 12 September 2025 after the unrest of September 2025, elections were held on 5 March 2026, and the understanding on importing ten thousand megawatts over ten years dates from 2 June 2023; the owners classify this as political engagement plus an agreed power-trade target and record expressly that it is not a revised Treaty of 1950, so an answer must not convert an energy-trade understanding into a renegotiated foundational treaty, and must read the sequence alongside Bangladesh and Sri Lanka as three simultaneous transition tests inside a single cycle. B. India engaged Bangladesh's interim government from 16 August 2024 and pressed for early inclusive elections on 20 August 2025, parliamentary elections were held on 12 February 2026, and the 1996 Ganga Waters Treaty expires in December 2026 with India stating on 13 February 2026 that renewal talks had not begun; the owners classify this evidence exactly as engagement plus an election fact plus a treaty-expiry fact and no renewed treaty, which makes it the cleanest available test of whether Neighbourhood First engagement attaches to a state rather than to an incumbent government. C. During the Prime Minister's visit of 5 April 2025 seven memoranda of understanding were exchanged with Sri Lanka, covering high-voltage direct-current power interconnection, digital transformation, the India-Sri Lanka-United Arab Emirates Trincomalee energy hub, defence cooperation, Eastern Province grant assistance, health and medicine, and pharmacopoeial cooperation, and the Ministry of External Affairs bilateral brief on India-Sri Lanka was current to July 2026; the owners fix the evidentiary level precisely, recording that signed memoranda are not proof that each project is operational and that the 120 megawatt Sampur solar project had its ground-breaking rather than its commissioning, while the same visit inaugurated five thousand rooftop solar units and a warehouse. D. India engaged the Taliban administration through the Foreign Secretary's Dubai meeting of 8 January 2025 and the External Affairs Minister's New Delhi meeting of 10 October 2025, and restored its Kabul Technical Mission to Embassy status with immediate effect on 21 October 2025; the owners state explicitly that this is a change in the level of India's diplomatic presence and that the official record contains no recognition declaration, so the upgrade must never be reported as recognition of the administration, and the near-neighbour framing from Tharoor supplies the reason the relationship is treated as vital to national security despite the absence of a direct pre-1947 border.

Answer: C. Explanation: During the Prime Minister's visit of 5 April 2025 seven memoranda of understanding were exchanged with Sri Lanka, covering high-voltage direct-current power interconnection, digital transformation, the India-Sri Lanka-United Arab Emirates Trincomalee energy hub, defence cooperation, Eastern Province grant assistance, health and medicine, and pharmacopoeial cooperation, and the Ministry of External Affairs bilateral brief on India-Sri Lanka was current to July 2026; the owners fix the evidentiary level precisely, recording that signed memoranda are not proof that each project is operational and that the 120 megawatt Sampur solar project had its ground-breaking rather than its commissioning, while the same visit inaugurated five thousand rooftop solar units and a warehouse. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q52. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Sri Lanka's current instrument set and its pre-delivery status?

A. India welcomed the interim government led by Sushila Karki on 12 September 2025 after the unrest of September 2025, elections were held on 5 March 2026, and the understanding on importing ten thousand megawatts over ten years dates from 2 June 2023; the owners classify this as political engagement plus an agreed power-trade target and record expressly that it is not a revised Treaty of 1950, so an answer must not convert an energy-trade understanding into a renegotiated foundational treaty, and must read the sequence alongside Bangladesh and Sri Lanka as three simultaneous transition tests inside a single cycle. B. The Cabinet Committee on Security decided on 23 April 2025 that the Indus Waters Treaty of 1960 will be held in abeyance with immediate effect until Pakistan credibly and irrevocably abjures its support for cross-border terrorism, Operation Sindoor was described officially on 7 May 2025 as measured, non-escalatory, proportionate, and responsible, and on 10 May 2025 India recorded an understanding to stop all military activities, while India separately maintains that the Court of Arbitration seized of the matter is illegally constituted and its awards null and void, a position restated on 16 May 2026; the owners fix the classification as an executive decision plus an operation plus an understanding, expressly not treaty termination and not a formal ceasefire agreement, and they draw the doctrinal point that non-reciprocal accommodation is least stable where the shared resource is finite, since it can be withdrawn when linked to a security condition. C. India engaged the Taliban administration through the Foreign Secretary's Dubai meeting of 8 January 2025 and the External Affairs Minister's

New Delhi meeting of 10 October 2025, and restored its Kabul Technical Mission to Embassy status with immediate effect on 21 October 2025; the owners state explicitly that this is a change in the level of India's diplomatic presence and that the official record contains no recognition declaration, so the upgrade must never be reported as recognition of the administration, and the near-neighbour framing from Tharoor supplies the reason the relationship is treated as vital to national security despite the absence of a direct pre-1947 border. D. During the Prime Minister's visit of 5 April 2025 seven memoranda of understanding were exchanged with Sri Lanka, covering high-voltage direct-current power interconnection, digital transformation, the India-Sri Lanka-United Arab Emirates Trincomalee energy hub, defence cooperation, Eastern Province grant assistance, health and medicine, and pharmacopoeial cooperation, and the Ministry of External Affairs bilateral brief on India-Sri Lanka was current to July 2026; the owners fix the evidentiary level precisely, recording that signed memoranda are not proof that each project is operational and that the 120 megawatt Sampur solar project had its ground-breaking rather than its commissioning, while the same visit inaugurated five thousand rooftop solar units and a warehouse.

Answer: D. Explanation: During the Prime Minister's visit of 5 April 2025 seven memoranda of understanding were exchanged with Sri Lanka, covering high-voltage direct-current power interconnection, digital transformation, the India-Sri Lanka-United Arab Emirates Trincomalee energy hub, defence cooperation, Eastern Province grant assistance, health and medicine, and pharmacopoeial cooperation, and the Ministry of External Affairs bilateral brief on India-Sri Lanka was current to July 2026; the owners fix the evidentiary level precisely, recording that signed memoranda are not proof that each project is operational and that the 120 megawatt Sampur solar project had its ground-breaking rather than its commissioning, while the same visit inaugurated five thousand rooftop solar units and a warehouse. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q53. Which statement correctly identifies Maldives instruments and the maritime cross-link?

A. The India-Maldives Joint Vision of 7 October 2024 records support of four hundred million United States dollars and thirty billion Indian rupees as a currency-swap arrangement, the Terms of Reference for a free trade agreement were signed and negotiations launched on 25 July 2025, a line of credit of 4,850 crore Indian rupees is recorded, and the Ministry of External Affairs bilateral brief on India-Maldives was current to June 2026; the owners state expressly that a vision document, terms of reference and a line of credit are pre-delivery instruments and that no free trade agreement has been concluded, and they route the deeper Maldives treatment to topic 04 because its geostrategic salience is primarily maritime and is addressed by the 2024 objective demand recorded there. B. India welcomed the interim government led by Sushila Karki on 12 September 2025 after the unrest of September 2025, elections were held on 5 March 2026, and the understanding on importing ten thousand megawatts over ten years dates from 2 June 2023; the owners classify this as political engagement plus an agreed power-trade target and record expressly that it is not a revised Treaty of 1950, so an answer must not convert an energy-trade understanding into a renegotiated foundational treaty, and must read the sequence alongside Bangladesh and Sri Lanka as three simultaneous transition tests inside a single cycle. C. By 3 May 2022 India's High Commission recorded more than three billion United States dollars in assistance during 2022, comprising a one billion dollar facility for food, medicines and essentials, a five hundred million dollar petroleum credit line, about one billion dollars in Asian Clearing Union payment deferment and a four hundred million dollar Reserve Bank of India currency swap, while the petroleum line had delivered close to four hundred thousand tonnes of fuel across all twenty-five districts and the essentials facility had supplied rice and other necessities with medical consignments providing a humanitarian component; the owners require the aggregate to be time-bounded, since full-year descriptions commonly place support at around four billion dollars over 2022, and they record the limitation that emergency financing did not remove Sri Lanka's structural debt, revenue, governance and external-financing problems, whose durable resolution required domestic adjustment and an International Monetary Fund-supported programme. D. India engaged Bangladesh's interim government from 16 August 2024 and pressed for early inclusive elections on 20 August 2025, parliamentary elections were held on 12 February 2026, and the 1996 Ganga Waters Treaty expires in December 2026 with India stating on 13 February 2026 that renewal talks had not begun; the owners classify this evidence exactly as engagement plus an election fact plus a treaty-expiry fact and no renewed treaty, which makes it the cleanest available test of whether Neighbourhood First engagement attaches to a state rather than to an incumbent government.

Answer: A. Explanation: The India-Maldives Joint Vision of 7 October 2024 records support of four hundred million United States dollars and thirty billion Indian rupees as a currency-swap arrangement, the Terms of Reference for a free trade agreement were signed and negotiations launched on 25 July 2025, a line of credit

of 4,850 crore Indian rupees is recorded, and the Ministry of External Affairs bilateral brief on India-Maldives was current to June 2026; the owners state expressly that a vision document, terms of reference and a line of credit are pre-delivery instruments and that no free trade agreement has been concluded, and they route the deeper Maldives treatment to topic 04 because its geostrategic salience is primarily maritime and is addressed by the 2024 objective demand recorded there. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q54. Which card should be filed under Maldives instruments and the maritime cross-link in an International Relations answer?

A. India engaged the Taliban administration through the Foreign Secretary's Dubai meeting of 8 January 2025 and the External Affairs Minister's New Delhi meeting of 10 October 2025, and restored its Kabul Technical Mission to Embassy status with immediate effect on 21 October 2025; the owners state explicitly that this is a change in the level of India's diplomatic presence and that the official record contains no recognition declaration, so the upgrade must never be reported as recognition of the administration, and the near-neighbour framing from Tharoor supplies the reason the relationship is treated as vital to national security despite the absence of a direct pre-1947 border. B. The India-Maldives Joint Vision of 7 October 2024 records support of four hundred million United States dollars and thirty billion Indian rupees as a currency-swap arrangement, the Terms of Reference for a free trade agreement were signed and negotiations launched on 25 July 2025, a line of credit of 4,850 crore Indian rupees is recorded, and the Ministry of External Affairs bilateral brief on India-Maldives was current to June 2026; the owners state expressly that a vision document, terms of reference and a line of credit are pre-delivery instruments and that no free trade agreement has been concluded, and they route the deeper Maldives treatment to topic 04 because its geostrategic salience is primarily maritime and is addressed by the 2024 objective demand recorded there. C. India welcomed the interim government led by Sushila Karki on 12 September 2025 after the unrest of September 2025, elections were held on 5 March 2026, and the understanding on importing ten thousand megawatts over ten years dates from 2 June 2023; the owners classify this as political engagement plus an agreed power-trade target and record expressly that it is not a revised Treaty of 1950, so an answer must not convert an energy-trade understanding into a renegotiated foundational treaty, and must read the sequence alongside Bangladesh and Sri Lanka as three simultaneous transition tests inside a single cycle. D. India engaged Bangladesh's interim government from 16 August 2024 and pressed for early inclusive elections on 20 August 2025, parliamentary elections were held on 12 February 2026, and the 1996 Ganga Waters Treaty expires in December 2026 with India stating on 13 February 2026 that renewal talks had not begun; the owners classify this evidence exactly as engagement plus an election fact plus a treaty-expiry fact and no renewed treaty, which makes it the cleanest available test of whether Neighbourhood First engagement attaches to a state rather than to an incumbent government.

Answer: B. Explanation: The India-Maldives Joint Vision of 7 October 2024 records support of four hundred million United States dollars and thirty billion Indian rupees as a currency-swap arrangement, the Terms of Reference for a free trade agreement were signed and negotiations launched on 25 July 2025, a line of credit of 4,850 crore Indian rupees is recorded, and the Ministry of External Affairs bilateral brief on India-Maldives was current to June 2026; the owners state expressly that a vision document, terms of reference and a line of credit are pre-delivery instruments and that no free trade agreement has been concluded, and they route the deeper Maldives treatment to topic 04 because its geostrategic salience is primarily maritime and is addressed by the 2024 objective demand recorded there. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q55. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Maldives instruments and the maritime cross-link?

A. India welcomed the interim government led by Sushila Karki on 12 September 2025 after the unrest of September 2025, elections were held on 5 March 2026, and the understanding on importing ten thousand megawatts over ten years dates from 2 June 2023; the owners classify this as political engagement plus an agreed power-trade target and record expressly that it is not a revised Treaty of 1950, so an answer must not convert an energy-trade understanding into a renegotiated foundational treaty, and must read the sequence alongside Bangladesh and Sri Lanka as three simultaneous transition tests inside a single cycle. B. India engaged the Taliban administration through the Foreign Secretary's Dubai meeting of 8 January 2025 and the External Affairs Minister's New Delhi meeting of 10 October 2025, and restored its Kabul Technical Mission to Embassy status with immediate effect on 21 October 2025; the

owners state explicitly that this is a change in the level of India's diplomatic presence and that the official record contains no recognition declaration, so the upgrade must never be reported as recognition of the administration, and the near-neighbour framing from Tharoor supplies the reason the relationship is treated as vital to national security despite the absence of a direct pre-1947 border. C. The India-Maldives Joint Vision of 7 October 2024 records support of four hundred million United States dollars and thirty billion Indian rupees as a currency-swap arrangement, the Terms of Reference for a free trade agreement were signed and negotiations launched on 25 July 2025, a line of credit of 4,850 crore Indian rupees is recorded, and the Ministry of External Affairs bilateral brief on India-Maldives was current to June 2026; the owners state expressly that a vision document, terms of reference and a line of credit are pre-delivery instruments and that no free trade agreement has been concluded, and they route the deeper Maldives treatment to topic 04 because its geostrategic salience is primarily maritime and is addressed by the 2024 objective demand recorded there. D. The Cabinet Committee on Security decided on 23 April 2025 that the Indus Waters Treaty of 1960 will be held in abeyance with immediate effect until Pakistan credibly and irrevocably abjures its support for cross-border terrorism, Operation Sindoor was described officially on 7 May 2025 as measured, non-escalatory, proportionate, and responsible, and on 10 May 2025 India recorded an understanding to stop all military activities, while India separately maintains that the Court of Arbitration seized of the matter is illegally constituted and its awards null and void, a position restated on 16 May 2026; the owners fix the classification as an executive decision plus an operation plus an understanding, expressly not treaty termination and not a formal ceasefire agreement, and they draw the doctrinal point that non-reciprocal accommodation is least stable where the shared resource is finite, since it can be withdrawn when linked to a security condition.

Answer: C. Explanation: The India-Maldives Joint Vision of 7 October 2024 records support of four hundred million United States dollars and thirty billion Indian rupees as a currency-swap arrangement, the Terms of Reference for a free trade agreement were signed and negotiations launched on 25 July 2025, a line of credit of 4,850 crore Indian rupees is recorded, and the Ministry of External Affairs bilateral brief on India-Maldives was current to June 2026; the owners state expressly that a vision document, terms of reference and a line of credit are pre-delivery instruments and that no free trade agreement has been concluded, and they route the deeper Maldives treatment to topic 04 because its geostrategic salience is primarily maritime and is addressed by the 2024 objective demand recorded there. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q56. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Maldives instruments and the maritime cross-link?

A. The Cabinet Committee on Security decided on 23 April 2025 that the Indus Waters Treaty of 1960 will be held in abeyance with immediate effect until Pakistan credibly and irrevocably abjures its support for cross-border terrorism, Operation Sindoor was described officially on 7 May 2025 as measured, non-escalatory, proportionate, and responsible, and on 10 May 2025 India recorded an understanding to stop all military activities, while India separately maintains that the Court of Arbitration seized of the matter is illegally constituted and its awards null and void, a position restated on 16 May 2026; the owners fix the classification as an executive decision plus an operation plus an understanding, expressly not treaty termination and not a formal ceasefire agreement, and they draw the doctrinal point that non-reciprocal accommodation is least stable where the shared resource is finite, since it can be withdrawn when linked to a security condition. B. India engaged the Taliban administration through the Foreign Secretary's Dubai meeting of 8 January 2025 and the External Affairs Minister's New Delhi meeting of 10 October 2025, and restored its Kabul Technical Mission to Embassy status with immediate effect on 21 October 2025; the owners state explicitly that this is a change in the level of India's diplomatic presence and that the official record contains no recognition declaration, so the upgrade must never be reported as recognition of the administration, and the near-neighbour framing from Tharoor supplies the reason the relationship is treated as vital to national security despite the absence of a direct pre-1947 border. C. The owners state that neighbourhood policy success is not measured by the number of agreements signed but by whether connectivity and development commitments are delivered and sustained across changes of government in the partner state, and they add the outside-power variable through Sikri's period-specific critique that India's policy on Pakistan, Bangladesh, Nepal and Sri Lanka was being guided by the United States and that the government of the day seemed to have outsourced its South Asia policy, which must be cited as a dated author-specific argument about the risk of external-power involvement rather than as a description of current policy; on ownership the ledgers route one Mains demand from 2022 General Studies Paper II and four objective demands, namely 2020 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 64 on India's trade with Sri Lanka, Bangladesh and Nepal,

2023 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 10 on regional connectivity projects including the Trilateral Highway and the Bangladesh-China-India-Myanmar corridor, and 2026 Prelims General Studies Paper I questions 61 and 67 on cross-border bridges with Bangladesh, Myanmar and Nepal and on development-assistance projects matched with neighbouring partner countries and locations, with no option or answer recorded or inferred for any of them. D. The India-Maldives Joint Vision of 7 October 2024 records support of four hundred million United States dollars and thirty billion Indian rupees as a currency-swap arrangement, the Terms of Reference for a free trade agreement were signed and negotiations launched on 25 July 2025, a line of credit of 4,850 crore Indian rupees is recorded, and the Ministry of External Affairs bilateral brief on India-Maldives was current to June 2026; the owners state expressly that a vision document, terms of reference and a line of credit are pre-delivery instruments and that no free trade agreement has been concluded, and they route the deeper Maldives treatment to topic 04 because its geostrategic salience is primarily maritime and is addressed by the 2024 objective demand recorded there.

Answer: D. Explanation: The India-Maldives Joint Vision of 7 October 2024 records support of four hundred million United States dollars and thirty billion Indian rupees as a currency-swap arrangement, the Terms of Reference for a free trade agreement were signed and negotiations launched on 25 July 2025, a line of credit of 4,850 crore Indian rupees is recorded, and the Ministry of External Affairs bilateral brief on India-Maldives was current to June 2026; the owners state expressly that a vision document, terms of reference and a line of credit are pre-delivery instruments and that no free trade agreement has been concluded, and they route the deeper Maldives treatment to topic 04 because its geostrategic salience is primarily maritime and is addressed by the 2024 objective demand recorded there. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q57. Which statement correctly identifies Sri Lanka's 2022 crisis as the first-responder evidence set?

A. By 3 May 2022 India's High Commission recorded more than three billion United States dollars in assistance during 2022, comprising a one billion dollar facility for food, medicines and essentials, a five hundred million dollar petroleum credit line, about one billion dollars in Asian Clearing Union payment deferment and a four hundred million dollar Reserve Bank of India currency swap, while the petroleum line had delivered close to four hundred thousand tonnes of fuel across all twenty-five districts and the essentials facility had supplied rice and other necessities with medical consignments providing a humanitarian component; the owners require the aggregate to be time-bounded, since full-year descriptions commonly place support at around four billion dollars over 2022, and they record the limitation that emergency financing did not remove Sri Lanka's structural debt, revenue, governance and external-financing problems, whose durable resolution required domestic adjustment and an International Monetary Fund-supported programme. B. India engaged Bangladesh's interim government from 16 August 2024 and pressed for early inclusive elections on 20 August 2025, parliamentary elections were held on 12 February 2026, and the 1996 Ganga Waters Treaty expires in December 2026 with India stating on 13 February 2026 that renewal talks had not begun; the owners classify this evidence exactly as engagement plus an election fact plus a treaty-expiry fact and no renewed treaty, which makes it the cleanest available test of whether Neighbourhood First engagement attaches to a state rather than to an incumbent government. C. India engaged the Taliban administration through the Foreign Secretary's Dubai meeting of 8 January 2025 and the External Affairs Minister's New Delhi meeting of 10 October 2025, and restored its Kabul Technical Mission to Embassy status with immediate effect on 21 October 2025; the owners state explicitly that this is a change in the level of India's diplomatic presence and that the official record contains no recognition declaration, so the upgrade must never be reported as recognition of the administration, and the near-neighbour framing from Tharoor supplies the reason the relationship is treated as vital to national security despite the absence of a direct pre-1947 border. D. India welcomed the interim government led by Sushila Karki on 12 September 2025 after the unrest of September 2025, elections were held on 5 March 2026, and the understanding on importing ten thousand megawatts over ten years dates from 2 June 2023; the owners classify this as political engagement plus an agreed power-trade target and record expressly that it is not a revised Treaty of 1950, so an answer must not convert an energy-trade understanding into a renegotiated foundational treaty, and must read the sequence alongside Bangladesh and Sri Lanka as three simultaneous transition tests inside a single cycle.

Answer: A. Explanation: By 3 May 2022 India's High Commission recorded more than three billion United States dollars in assistance during 2022, comprising a one billion dollar facility for food, medicines and essentials, a five hundred million dollar petroleum credit line, about one billion dollars in Asian Clearing Union payment deferment and a four hundred million dollar Reserve Bank of India currency swap, while the

petroleum line had delivered close to four hundred thousand tonnes of fuel across all twenty-five districts and the essentials facility had supplied rice and other necessities with medical consignments providing a humanitarian component; the owners require the aggregate to be time-bounded, since full-year descriptions commonly place support at around four billion dollars over 2022, and they record the limitation that emergency financing did not remove Sri Lanka's structural debt, revenue, governance and external-financing problems, whose durable resolution required domestic adjustment and an International Monetary Fund-supported programme. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q58. Which card should be filed under Sri Lanka's 2022 crisis as the first-responder evidence set in an International Relations answer?

A. India engaged the Taliban administration through the Foreign Secretary's Dubai meeting of 8 January 2025 and the External Affairs Minister's New Delhi meeting of 10 October 2025, and restored its Kabul Technical Mission to Embassy status with immediate effect on 21 October 2025; the owners state explicitly that this is a change in the level of India's diplomatic presence and that the official record contains no recognition declaration, so the upgrade must never be reported as recognition of the administration, and the near-neighbour framing from Tharoor supplies the reason the relationship is treated as vital to national security despite the absence of a direct pre-1947 border. B. By 3 May 2022 India's High Commission recorded more than three billion United States dollars in assistance during 2022, comprising a one billion dollar facility for food, medicines and essentials, a five hundred million dollar petroleum credit line, about one billion dollars in Asian Clearing Union payment deferment and a four hundred million dollar Reserve Bank of India currency swap, while the petroleum line had delivered close to four hundred thousand tonnes of fuel across all twenty-five districts and the essentials facility had supplied rice and other necessities with medical consignments providing a humanitarian component; the owners require the aggregate to be time-bounded, since full-year descriptions commonly place support at around four billion dollars over 2022, and they record the limitation that emergency financing did not remove Sri Lanka's structural debt, revenue, governance and external-financing problems, whose durable resolution required domestic adjustment and an International Monetary Fund-supported programme. C. The Cabinet Committee on Security decided on 23 April 2025 that the Indus Waters Treaty of 1960 will be held in abeyance with immediate effect until Pakistan credibly and irrevocably abjures its support for cross-border terrorism, Operation Sindoor was described officially on 7 May 2025 as measured, non-escalatory, proportionate, and responsible, and on 10 May 2025 India recorded an understanding to stop all military activities, while India separately maintains that the Court of Arbitration seized of the matter is illegally constituted and its awards null and void, a position restated on 16 May 2026; the owners fix the classification as an executive decision plus an operation plus an understanding, expressly not treaty termination and not a formal ceasefire agreement, and they draw the doctrinal point that non-reciprocal accommodation is least stable where the shared resource is finite, since it can be withdrawn when linked to a security condition. D. India welcomed the interim government led by Sushila Karki on 12 September 2025 after the unrest of September 2025, elections were held on 5 March 2026, and the understanding on importing ten thousand megawatts over ten years dates from 2 June 2023; the owners classify this as political engagement plus an agreed power-trade target and record expressly that it is not a revised Treaty of 1950, so an answer must not convert an energy-trade understanding into a renegotiated foundational treaty, and must read the sequence alongside Bangladesh and Sri Lanka as three simultaneous transition tests inside a single cycle.

Answer: B. Explanation: By 3 May 2022 India's High Commission recorded more than three billion United States dollars in assistance during 2022, comprising a one billion dollar facility for food, medicines and essentials, a five hundred million dollar petroleum credit line, about one billion dollars in Asian Clearing Union payment deferment and a four hundred million dollar Reserve Bank of India currency swap, while the petroleum line had delivered close to four hundred thousand tonnes of fuel across all twenty-five districts and the essentials facility had supplied rice and other necessities with medical consignments providing a humanitarian component; the owners require the aggregate to be time-bounded, since full-year descriptions commonly place support at around four billion dollars over 2022, and they record the limitation that emergency financing did not remove Sri Lanka's structural debt, revenue, governance and external-financing problems, whose durable resolution required domestic adjustment and an International Monetary Fund-supported programme. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q59. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Sri Lanka's 2022 crisis as the first-responder evidence set?

A. India engaged the Taliban administration through the Foreign Secretary's Dubai meeting of 8 January 2025 and the External Affairs Minister's New Delhi meeting of 10 October 2025, and restored its Kabul Technical Mission to Embassy status with immediate effect on 21 October 2025; the owners state explicitly that this is a change in the level of India's diplomatic presence and that the official record contains no recognition declaration, so the upgrade must never be reported as recognition of the administration, and the near-neighbour framing from Tharoor supplies the reason the relationship is treated as vital to national security despite the absence of a direct pre-1947 border. B. The owners state that neighbourhood policy success is not measured by the number of agreements signed but by whether connectivity and development commitments are delivered and sustained across changes of government in the partner state, and they add the outside-power variable through Sikri's period-specific critique that India's policy on Pakistan, Bangladesh, Nepal and Sri Lanka was being guided by the United States and that the government of the day seemed to have outsourced its South Asia policy, which must be cited as a dated author-specific argument about the risk of external-power involvement rather than as a description of current policy; on ownership the ledgers route one Mains demand from 2022 General Studies Paper II and four objective demands, namely 2020 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 64 on India's trade with Sri Lanka, Bangladesh and Nepal, 2023 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 10 on regional connectivity projects including the Trilateral Highway and the Bangladesh-China-India-Myanmar corridor, and 2026 Prelims General Studies Paper I questions 61 and 67 on cross-border bridges with Bangladesh, Myanmar and Nepal and on development-assistance projects matched with neighbouring partner countries and locations, with no option or answer recorded or inferred for any of them. C. By 3 May 2022 India's High Commission recorded more than three billion United States dollars in assistance during 2022, comprising a one billion dollar facility for food, medicines and essentials, a five hundred million dollar petroleum credit line, about one billion dollars in Asian Clearing Union payment deferment and a four hundred million dollar Reserve Bank of India currency swap, while the petroleum line had delivered close to four hundred thousand tonnes of fuel across all twenty-five districts and the essentials facility had supplied rice and other necessities with medical consignments providing a humanitarian component; the owners require the aggregate to be time-bounded, since full-year descriptions commonly place support at around four billion dollars over 2022, and they record the limitation that emergency financing did not remove Sri Lanka's structural debt, revenue, governance and external-financing problems, whose durable resolution required domestic adjustment and an International Monetary Fund-supported programme. D. The Cabinet Committee on Security decided on 23 April 2025 that the Indus Waters Treaty of 1960 will be held in abeyance with immediate effect until Pakistan credibly and irrevocably abjures its support for cross-border terrorism, Operation Sindoor was described officially on 7 May 2025 as measured, non-escalatory, proportionate, and responsible, and on 10 May 2025 India recorded an understanding to stop all military activities, while India separately maintains that the Court of Arbitration seized of the matter is illegally constituted and its awards null and void, a position restated on 16 May 2026; the owners fix the classification as an executive decision plus an operation plus an understanding, expressly not treaty termination and not a formal ceasefire agreement, and they draw the doctrinal point that non-reciprocal accommodation is least stable where the shared resource is finite, since it can be withdrawn when linked to a security condition.

Answer: C. Explanation: By 3 May 2022 India's High Commission recorded more than three billion United States dollars in assistance during 2022, comprising a one billion dollar facility for food, medicines and essentials, a five hundred million dollar petroleum credit line, about one billion dollars in Asian Clearing Union payment deferment and a four hundred million dollar Reserve Bank of India currency swap, while the petroleum line had delivered close to four hundred thousand tonnes of fuel across all twenty-five districts and the essentials facility had supplied rice and other necessities with medical consignments providing a humanitarian component; the owners require the aggregate to be time-bounded, since full-year descriptions commonly place support at around four billion dollars over 2022, and they record the limitation that emergency financing did not remove Sri Lanka's structural debt, revenue, governance and external-financing problems, whose durable resolution required domestic adjustment and an International Monetary Fund-supported programme. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q60. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Sri Lanka's 2022 crisis as the first-responder evidence set?

A. The Cabinet Committee on Security decided on 23 April 2025 that the Indus Waters Treaty of 1960 will be held in abeyance with immediate effect until Pakistan credibly and irrevocably abjures its support for cross-border terrorism, Operation Sindoor was described officially on 7 May 2025 as measured, non-escalatory, proportionate, and responsible, and on 10 May 2025 India recorded an understanding to stop all military activities, while India separately maintains that the Court of Arbitration seized of the matter is illegally constituted and its awards null and void, a position restated on 16 May 2026; the owners fix the classification as an executive decision plus an operation plus an understanding, expressly not treaty termination and not a formal ceasefire agreement, and they draw the doctrinal point that non-reciprocal accommodation is least stable where the shared resource is finite, since it can be withdrawn when linked to a security condition. B. This topic owns India's engagement with Bangladesh, Bhutan, Nepal, Sri Lanka, Myanmar, Pakistan and Afghanistan, together with the Neighbourhood First policy, the Gujral Doctrine, and the development, connectivity and people-to-people instruments that carry them, and its distinctive feature is that it is simultaneously doctrinal and heavily evidence-bound: one General Studies Paper II Mains demand from 2022 is routed to it in the audited ledgers alongside four objective demands from 2020, 2023 and 2026; Maldives is deliberately cross-linked to topic 04 because its salience is primarily maritime, the SAARC and BIMSTEC institutional comparison is reserved for topic 10, and the physical border and route geography belongs to the Geography owner. C. The owners state that neighbourhood policy success is not measured by the number of agreements signed but by whether connectivity and development commitments are delivered and sustained across changes of government in the partner state, and they add the outside-power variable through Sikri's period-specific critique that India's policy on Pakistan, Bangladesh, Nepal and Sri Lanka was being guided by the United States and that the government of the day seemed to have outsourced its South Asia policy, which must be cited as a dated author-specific argument about the risk of external-power involvement rather than as a description of current policy; on ownership the ledgers route one Mains demand from 2022 General Studies Paper II and four objective demands, namely 2020 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 64 on India's trade with Sri Lanka, Bangladesh and Nepal, 2023 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 10 on regional connectivity projects including the Trilateral Highway and the Bangladesh-China-India-Myanmar corridor, and 2026 Prelims General Studies Paper I questions 61 and 67 on cross-border bridges with Bangladesh, Myanmar and Nepal and on development-assistance projects matched with neighbouring partner countries and locations, with no option or answer recorded or inferred for any of them. D. By 3 May 2022 India's High Commission recorded more than three billion United States dollars in assistance during 2022, comprising a one billion dollar facility for food, medicines and essentials, a five hundred million dollar petroleum credit line, about one billion dollars in Asian Clearing Union payment deferment and a four hundred million dollar Reserve Bank of India currency swap, while the petroleum line had delivered close to four hundred thousand tonnes of fuel across all twenty-five districts and the essentials facility had supplied rice and other necessities with medical consignments providing a humanitarian component; the owners require the aggregate to be time-bounded, since full-year descriptions commonly place support at around four billion dollars over 2022, and they record the limitation that emergency financing did not remove Sri Lanka's structural debt, revenue, governance and external-financing problems, whose durable resolution required domestic adjustment and an International Monetary Fund-supported programme.

Answer: D. Explanation: By 3 May 2022 India's High Commission recorded more than three billion United States dollars in assistance during 2022, comprising a one billion dollar facility for food, medicines and essentials, a five hundred million dollar petroleum credit line, about one billion dollars in Asian Clearing Union payment deferment and a four hundred million dollar Reserve Bank of India currency swap, while the petroleum line had delivered close to four hundred thousand tonnes of fuel across all twenty-five districts and the essentials facility had supplied rice and other necessities with medical consignments providing a humanitarian component; the owners require the aggregate to be time-bounded, since full-year descriptions commonly place support at around four billion dollars over 2022, and they record the limitation that emergency financing did not remove Sri Lanka's structural debt, revenue, governance and external-financing problems, whose durable resolution required domestic adjustment and an International Monetary Fund-supported programme. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q61. Which statement correctly identifies Bangladesh's political transition and the Ganga Waters Treaty horizon?

A. India engaged Bangladesh's interim government from 16 August 2024 and pressed for early inclusive elections on 20 August 2025, parliamentary elections were held on 12 February 2026, and the 1996 Ganga Waters Treaty expires in December 2026 with India stating on 13 February 2026 that renewal talks had not begun; the owners classify this evidence exactly as engagement plus an election fact plus a treaty-expiry fact and no renewed treaty, which makes it the cleanest available test of whether Neighbourhood First engagement attaches to a state rather than to an incumbent government. B. The Cabinet Committee on Security decided on 23 April 2025 that the Indus Waters Treaty of 1960 will be held in abeyance with immediate effect until Pakistan credibly and irrevocably abjures its support for cross-border terrorism, Operation Sindoor was described officially on 7 May 2025 as measured, non-escalatory, proportionate, and responsible, and on 10 May 2025 India recorded an understanding to stop all military activities, while India separately maintains that the Court of Arbitration seized of the matter is illegally constituted and its awards null and void, a position restated on 16 May 2026; the owners fix the classification as an executive decision plus an operation plus an understanding, expressly not treaty termination and not a formal ceasefire agreement, and they draw the doctrinal point that non-reciprocal accommodation is least stable where the shared resource is finite, since it can be withdrawn when linked to a security condition. C. India engaged the Taliban administration through the Foreign Secretary's Dubai meeting of 8 January 2025 and the External Affairs Minister's New Delhi meeting of 10 October 2025, and restored its Kabul Technical Mission to Embassy status with immediate effect on 21 October 2025; the owners state explicitly that this is a change in the level of India's diplomatic presence and that the official record contains no recognition declaration, so the upgrade must never be reported as recognition of the administration, and the near-neighbour framing from Tharoor supplies the reason the relationship is treated as vital to national security despite the absence of a direct pre-1947 border. D. India welcomed the interim government led by Sushila Karki on 12 September 2025 after the unrest of September 2025, elections were held on 5 March 2026, and the understanding on importing ten thousand megawatts over ten years dates from 2 June 2023; the owners classify this as political engagement plus an agreed power-trade target and record expressly that it is not a revised Treaty of 1950, so an answer must not convert an energy-trade understanding into a renegotiated foundational treaty, and must read the sequence alongside Bangladesh and Sri Lanka as three simultaneous transition tests inside a single cycle.

Answer: A. Explanation: India engaged Bangladesh's interim government from 16 August 2024 and pressed for early inclusive elections on 20 August 2025, parliamentary elections were held on 12 February 2026, and the 1996 Ganga Waters Treaty expires in December 2026 with India stating on 13 February 2026 that renewal talks had not begun; the owners classify this evidence exactly as engagement plus an election fact plus a treaty-expiry fact and no renewed treaty, which makes it the cleanest available test of whether Neighbourhood First engagement attaches to a state rather than to an incumbent government. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q62. Which card should be filed under Bangladesh's political transition and the Ganga Waters Treaty horizon in an International Relations answer?

A. The Cabinet Committee on Security decided on 23 April 2025 that the Indus Waters Treaty of 1960 will be held in abeyance with immediate effect until Pakistan credibly and irrevocably abjures its support for cross-border terrorism, Operation Sindoor was described officially on 7 May 2025 as measured, non-escalatory, proportionate, and responsible, and on 10 May 2025 India recorded an understanding to stop all military activities, while India separately maintains that the Court of Arbitration seized of the matter is illegally constituted and its awards null and void, a position restated on 16 May 2026; the owners fix the classification as an executive decision plus an operation plus an understanding, expressly not treaty termination and not a formal ceasefire agreement, and they draw the doctrinal point that non-reciprocal accommodation is least stable where the shared resource is finite, since it can be withdrawn when linked to a security condition. B. India engaged Bangladesh's interim government from 16 August 2024 and pressed for early inclusive elections on 20 August 2025, parliamentary elections were held on 12 February 2026, and the 1996 Ganga Waters Treaty expires in December 2026 with India stating on 13 February 2026 that renewal talks had not begun; the owners classify this evidence exactly as engagement plus an election fact plus a treaty-expiry fact and no renewed treaty, which makes it the cleanest available test of whether Neighbourhood First engagement attaches to a state rather than to an incumbent government. C. The owners state that neighbourhood policy success is not measured by the number of agreements signed but by whether connectivity and development commitments are delivered and sustained across changes of government in the partner state, and they add the outside-power variable

through Sikri's period-specific critique that India's policy on Pakistan, Bangladesh, Nepal and Sri Lanka was being guided by the United States and that the government of the day seemed to have outsourced its South Asia policy, which must be cited as a dated author-specific argument about the risk of external-power involvement rather than as a description of current policy; on ownership the ledgers route one Mains demand from 2022 General Studies Paper II and four objective demands, namely 2020 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 64 on India's trade with Sri Lanka, Bangladesh and Nepal, 2023 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 10 on regional connectivity projects including the Trilateral Highway and the Bangladesh-China-India-Myanmar corridor, and 2026 Prelims General Studies Paper I questions 61 and 67 on cross-border bridges with Bangladesh, Myanmar and Nepal and on development-assistance projects matched with neighbouring partner countries and locations, with no option or answer recorded or inferred for any of them. D. India engaged the Taliban administration through the Foreign Secretary's Dubai meeting of 8 January 2025 and the External Affairs Minister's New Delhi meeting of 10 October 2025, and restored its Kabul Technical Mission to Embassy status with immediate effect on 21 October 2025; the owners state explicitly that this is a change in the level of India's diplomatic presence and that the official record contains no recognition declaration, so the upgrade must never be reported as recognition of the administration, and the near-neighbour framing from Tharoor supplies the reason the relationship is treated as vital to national security despite the absence of a direct pre-1947 border.

Answer: B. Explanation: India engaged Bangladesh's interim government from 16 August 2024 and pressed for early inclusive elections on 20 August 2025, parliamentary elections were held on 12 February 2026, and the 1996 Ganga Waters Treaty expires in December 2026 with India stating on 13 February 2026 that renewal talks had not begun; the owners classify this evidence exactly as engagement plus an election fact plus a treaty-expiry fact and no renewed treaty, which makes it the cleanest available test of whether Neighbourhood First engagement attaches to a state rather than to an incumbent government. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q63. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Bangladesh's political transition and the Ganga Waters Treaty horizon?

A. This topic owns India's engagement with Bangladesh, Bhutan, Nepal, Sri Lanka, Myanmar, Pakistan and Afghanistan, together with the Neighbourhood First policy, the Gujral Doctrine, and the development, connectivity and people-to-people instruments that carry them, and its distinctive feature is that it is simultaneously doctrinal and heavily evidence-bound: one General Studies Paper II Mains demand from 2022 is routed to it in the audited ledgers alongside four objective demands from 2020, 2023 and 2026; Maldives is deliberately cross-linked to topic 04 because its salience is primarily maritime, the SAARC and BIMSTEC institutional comparison is reserved for topic 10, and the physical border and route geography belongs to the Geography owner. B. The Cabinet Committee on Security decided on 23 April 2025 that the Indus Waters Treaty of 1960 will be held in abeyance with immediate effect until Pakistan credibly and irrevocably abjures its support for cross-border terrorism, Operation Sindoor was described officially on 7 May 2025 as measured, non-escalatory, proportionate, and responsible, and on 10 May 2025 India recorded an understanding to stop all military activities, while India separately maintains that the Court of Arbitration seized of the matter is illegally constituted and its awards null and void, a position restated on 16 May 2026; the owners fix the classification as an executive decision plus an operation plus an understanding, expressly not treaty termination and not a formal ceasefire agreement, and they draw the doctrinal point that non-reciprocal accommodation is least stable where the shared resource is finite, since it can be withdrawn when linked to a security condition. C. India engaged Bangladesh's interim government from 16 August 2024 and pressed for early inclusive elections on 20 August 2025, parliamentary elections were held on 12 February 2026, and the 1996 Ganga Waters Treaty expires in December 2026 with India stating on 13 February 2026 that renewal talks had not begun; the owners classify this evidence exactly as engagement plus an election fact plus a treaty-expiry fact and no renewed treaty, which makes it the cleanest available test of whether Neighbourhood First engagement attaches to a state rather than to an incumbent government. D. The owners state that neighbourhood policy success is not measured by the number of agreements signed but by whether connectivity and development commitments are delivered and sustained across changes of government in the partner state, and they add the outside-power variable through Sikri's period-specific critique that India's policy on Pakistan, Bangladesh, Nepal and Sri Lanka was being guided by the United States and that the government of the day seemed to have outsourced its South Asia policy, which must be cited as a dated author-specific argument about the risk of external-power involvement rather than as a description of current policy; on ownership the ledgers route one Mains demand from 2022 General Studies Paper II and four objective demands,

namely 2020 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 64 on India's trade with Sri Lanka, Bangladesh and Nepal, 2023 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 10 on regional connectivity projects including the Trilateral Highway and the Bangladesh-China-India-Myanmar corridor, and 2026 Prelims General Studies Paper I questions 61 and 67 on cross-border bridges with Bangladesh, Myanmar and Nepal and on development-assistance projects matched with neighbouring partner countries and locations, with no option or answer recorded or inferred for any of them.

Answer: C. Explanation: India engaged Bangladesh's interim government from 16 August 2024 and pressed for early inclusive elections on 20 August 2025, parliamentary elections were held on 12 February 2026, and the 1996 Ganga Waters Treaty expires in December 2026 with India stating on 13 February 2026 that renewal talks had not begun; the owners classify this evidence exactly as engagement plus an election fact plus a treaty-expiry fact and no renewed treaty, which makes it the cleanest available test of whether Neighbourhood First engagement attaches to a state rather than to an incumbent government. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q64. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Bangladesh's political transition and the Ganga Waters Treaty horizon?

A. Tharoor counts Pakistan, China, Nepal, Bhutan, Bangladesh, Myanmar, Sri Lanka and Maldives as sharing a land or maritime border with India, and adds Afghanistan as a near-neighbour because Pakistan's capture in 1948 of a strip of north-western Kashmir made Afghanistan territorially adjacent, and he separately records that of the eight bordering states there has been a history of problems, of varying degrees of difficulty, with six; the examinable consequence is that neighbourhood in Indian strategic practice is defined by security relevance and not only by strict territorial contiguity, and that friction is a structural feature rather than an aberration. B. The owners state that neighbourhood policy success is not measured by the number of agreements signed but by whether connectivity and development commitments are delivered and sustained across changes of government in the partner state, and they add the outside-power variable through Sikri's period-specific critique that India's policy on Pakistan, Bangladesh, Nepal and Sri Lanka was being guided by the United States and that the government of the day seemed to have outsourced its South Asia policy, which must be cited as a dated author-specific argument about the risk of external-power involvement rather than as a description of current policy; on ownership the ledgers route one Mains demand from 2022 General Studies Paper II and four objective demands, namely 2020 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 64 on India's trade with Sri Lanka, Bangladesh and Nepal, 2023 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 10 on regional connectivity projects including the Trilateral Highway and the Bangladesh-China-India-Myanmar corridor, and 2026 Prelims General Studies Paper I questions 61 and 67 on cross-border bridges with Bangladesh, Myanmar and Nepal and on development-assistance projects matched with neighbouring partner countries and locations, with no option or answer recorded or inferred for any of them. C. This topic owns India's engagement with Bangladesh, Bhutan, Nepal, Sri Lanka, Myanmar, Pakistan and Afghanistan, together with the Neighbourhood First policy, the Gujral Doctrine, and the development, connectivity and people-to-people instruments that carry them, and its distinctive feature is that it is simultaneously doctrinal and heavily evidence-bound: one General Studies Paper II Mains demand from 2022 is routed to it in the audited ledgers alongside four objective demands from 2020, 2023 and 2026; Maldives is deliberately cross-linked to topic 04 because its salience is primarily maritime, the SAARC and BIMSTEC institutional comparison is reserved for topic 10, and the physical border and route geography belongs to the Geography owner. D. India engaged Bangladesh's interim government from 16 August 2024 and pressed for early inclusive elections on 20 August 2025, parliamentary elections were held on 12 February 2026, and the 1996 Ganga Waters Treaty expires in December 2026 with India stating on 13 February 2026 that renewal talks had not begun; the owners classify this evidence exactly as engagement plus an election fact plus a treaty-expiry fact and no renewed treaty, which makes it the cleanest available test of whether Neighbourhood First engagement attaches to a state rather than to an incumbent government.

Answer: D. Explanation: India engaged Bangladesh's interim government from 16 August 2024 and pressed for early inclusive elections on 20 August 2025, parliamentary elections were held on 12 February 2026, and the 1996 Ganga Waters Treaty expires in December 2026 with India stating on 13 February 2026 that renewal talks had not begun; the owners classify this evidence exactly as engagement plus an election fact plus a treaty-expiry fact and no renewed treaty, which makes it the cleanest available test of whether Neighbourhood First engagement attaches to a state rather than to an incumbent government. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q65. Which statement correctly identifies Nepal's transition and the power-trade understanding?

A. India welcomed the interim government led by Sushila Karki on 12 September 2025 after the unrest of September 2025, elections were held on 5 March 2026, and the understanding on importing ten thousand megawatts over ten years dates from 2 June 2023; the owners classify this as political engagement plus an agreed power-trade target and record expressly that it is not a revised Treaty of 1950, so an answer must not convert an energy-trade understanding into a renegotiated foundational treaty, and must read the sequence alongside Bangladesh and Sri Lanka as three simultaneous transition tests inside a single cycle. B. The owners state that neighbourhood policy success is not measured by the number of agreements signed but by whether connectivity and development commitments are delivered and sustained across changes of government in the partner state, and they add the outside-power variable through Sikri's period-specific critique that India's policy on Pakistan, Bangladesh, Nepal and Sri Lanka was being guided by the United States and that the government of the day seemed to have outsourced its South Asia policy, which must be cited as a dated author-specific argument about the risk of external-power involvement rather than as a description of current policy; on ownership the ledgers route one Mains demand from 2022 General Studies Paper II and four objective demands, namely 2020 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 64 on India's trade with Sri Lanka, Bangladesh and Nepal, 2023 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 10 on regional connectivity projects including the Trilateral Highway and the Bangladesh-China-India-Myanmar corridor, and 2026 Prelims General Studies Paper I questions 61 and 67 on cross-border bridges with Bangladesh, Myanmar and Nepal and on development-assistance projects matched with neighbouring partner countries and locations, with no option or answer recorded or inferred for any of them. C. The Cabinet Committee on Security decided on 23 April 2025 that the Indus Waters Treaty of 1960 will be held in abeyance with immediate effect until Pakistan credibly and irrevocably abjures its support for cross-border terrorism, Operation Sindoor was described officially on 7 May 2025 as measured, non-escalatory, proportionate, and responsible, and on 10 May 2025 India recorded an understanding to stop all military activities, while India separately maintains that the Court of Arbitration seized of the matter is illegally constituted and its awards null and void, a position restated on 16 May 2026; the owners fix the classification as an executive decision plus an operation plus an understanding, expressly not treaty termination and not a formal ceasefire agreement, and they draw the doctrinal point that non-reciprocal accommodation is least stable where the shared resource is finite, since it can be withdrawn when linked to a security condition. D. India engaged the Taliban administration through the Foreign Secretary's Dubai meeting of 8 January 2025 and the External Affairs Minister's New Delhi meeting of 10 October 2025, and restored its Kabul Technical Mission to Embassy status with immediate effect on 21 October 2025; the owners state explicitly that this is a change in the level of India's diplomatic presence and that the official record contains no recognition declaration, so the upgrade must never be reported as recognition of the administration, and the near-neighbour framing from Tharoor supplies the reason the relationship is treated as vital to national security despite the absence of a direct pre-1947 border.

Answer: A. Explanation: India welcomed the interim government led by Sushila Karki on 12 September 2025 after the unrest of September 2025, elections were held on 5 March 2026, and the understanding on importing ten thousand megawatts over ten years dates from 2 June 2023; the owners classify this as political engagement plus an agreed power-trade target and record expressly that it is not a revised Treaty of 1950, so an answer must not convert an energy-trade understanding into a renegotiated foundational treaty, and must read the sequence alongside Bangladesh and Sri Lanka as three simultaneous transition tests inside a single cycle. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q66. Which card should be filed under Nepal's transition and the power-trade understanding in an International Relations answer?

A. This topic owns India's engagement with Bangladesh, Bhutan, Nepal, Sri Lanka, Myanmar, Pakistan and Afghanistan, together with the Neighbourhood First policy, the Gujral Doctrine, and the development, connectivity and people-to-people instruments that carry them, and its distinctive feature is that it is simultaneously doctrinal and heavily evidence-bound: one General Studies Paper II Mains demand from 2022 is routed to it in the audited ledgers alongside four objective demands from 2020, 2023 and 2026; Maldives is deliberately cross-linked to topic 04 because its salience is primarily maritime, the SAARC and BIMSTEC institutional comparison is reserved for topic 10, and the physical border and route geography belongs to the Geography owner. B. India welcomed the interim government led by Sushila Karki on 12 September 2025 after the unrest of September 2025, elections were held on 5 March 2026, and the understanding on importing ten thousand megawatts over ten years dates from 2 June 2023; the

owners classify this as political engagement plus an agreed power-trade target and record expressly that it is not a revised Treaty of 1950, so an answer must not convert an energy-trade understanding into a renegotiated foundational treaty, and must read the sequence alongside Bangladesh and Sri Lanka as three simultaneous transition tests inside a single cycle. C. The owners state that neighbourhood policy success is not measured by the number of agreements signed but by whether connectivity and development commitments are delivered and sustained across changes of government in the partner state, and they add the outside-power variable through Sikri's period-specific critique that India's policy on Pakistan, Bangladesh, Nepal and Sri Lanka was being guided by the United States and that the government of the day seemed to have outsourced its South Asia policy, which must be cited as a dated author-specific argument about the risk of external-power involvement rather than as a description of current policy; on ownership the ledgers route one Mains demand from 2022 General Studies Paper II and four objective demands, namely 2020 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 64 on India's trade with Sri Lanka, Bangladesh and Nepal, 2023 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 10 on regional connectivity projects including the Trilateral Highway and the Bangladesh-China-India-Myanmar corridor, and 2026 Prelims General Studies Paper I questions 61 and 67 on cross-border bridges with Bangladesh, Myanmar and Nepal and on development-assistance projects matched with neighbouring partner countries and locations, with no option or answer recorded or inferred for any of them. D. The Cabinet Committee on Security decided on 23 April 2025 that the Indus Waters Treaty of 1960 will be held in abeyance with immediate effect until Pakistan credibly and irrevocably abjures its support for cross-border terrorism, Operation Sindoor was described officially on 7 May 2025 as measured, non-escalatory, proportionate, and responsible, and on 10 May 2025 India recorded an understanding to stop all military activities, while India separately maintains that the Court of Arbitration seized of the matter is illegally constituted and its awards null and void, a position restated on 16 May 2026; the owners fix the classification as an executive decision plus an operation plus an understanding, expressly not treaty termination and not a formal ceasefire agreement, and they draw the doctrinal point that non-reciprocal accommodation is least stable where the shared resource is finite, since it can be withdrawn when linked to a security condition.

Answer: B. Explanation: India welcomed the interim government led by Sushila Karki on 12 September 2025 after the unrest of September 2025, elections were held on 5 March 2026, and the understanding on importing ten thousand megawatts over ten years dates from 2 June 2023; the owners classify this as political engagement plus an agreed power-trade target and record expressly that it is not a revised Treaty of 1950, so an answer must not convert an energy-trade understanding into a renegotiated foundational treaty, and must read the sequence alongside Bangladesh and Sri Lanka as three simultaneous transition tests inside a single cycle. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q67. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Nepal's transition and the power-trade understanding?

A. The owners state that neighbourhood policy success is not measured by the number of agreements signed but by whether connectivity and development commitments are delivered and sustained across changes of government in the partner state, and they add the outside-power variable through Sikri's period-specific critique that India's policy on Pakistan, Bangladesh, Nepal and Sri Lanka was being guided by the United States and that the government of the day seemed to have outsourced its South Asia policy, which must be cited as a dated author-specific argument about the risk of external-power involvement rather than as a description of current policy; on ownership the ledgers route one Mains demand from 2022 General Studies Paper II and four objective demands, namely 2020 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 64 on India's trade with Sri Lanka, Bangladesh and Nepal, 2023 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 10 on regional connectivity projects including the Trilateral Highway and the Bangladesh-China-India-Myanmar corridor, and 2026 Prelims General Studies Paper I questions 61 and 67 on cross-border bridges with Bangladesh, Myanmar and Nepal and on development-assistance projects matched with neighbouring partner countries and locations, with no option or answer recorded or inferred for any of them. B. Tharoor counts Pakistan, China, Nepal, Bhutan, Bangladesh, Myanmar, Sri Lanka and Maldives as sharing a land or maritime border with India, and adds Afghanistan as a near-neighbour because Pakistan's capture in 1948 of a strip of north-western Kashmir made Afghanistan territorially adjacent, and he separately records that of the eight bordering states there has been a history of problems, of varying degrees of difficulty, with six; the examinable consequence is that neighbourhood in Indian strategic practice is defined by security relevance and not only by strict territorial contiguity, and that friction is a structural feature rather than an aberration. C. India welcomed the interim government

led by Sushila Karki on 12 September 2025 after the unrest of September 2025, elections were held on 5 March 2026, and the understanding on importing ten thousand megawatts over ten years dates from 2 June 2023; the owners classify this as political engagement plus an agreed power-trade target and record expressly that it is not a revised Treaty of 1950, so an answer must not convert an energy-trade understanding into a renegotiated foundational treaty, and must read the sequence alongside Bangladesh and Sri Lanka as three simultaneous transition tests inside a single cycle. D. This topic owns India's engagement with Bangladesh, Bhutan, Nepal, Sri Lanka, Myanmar, Pakistan and Afghanistan, together with the Neighbourhood First policy, the Gujral Doctrine, and the development, connectivity and people-to-people instruments that carry them, and its distinctive feature is that it is simultaneously doctrinal and heavily evidence-bound: one General Studies Paper II Mains demand from 2022 is routed to it in the audited ledgers alongside four objective demands from 2020, 2023 and 2026; Maldives is deliberately cross-linked to topic 04 because its salience is primarily maritime, the SAARC and BIMSTEC institutional comparison is reserved for topic 10, and the physical border and route geography belongs to the Geography owner.

Answer: C. Explanation: India welcomed the interim government led by Sushila Karki on 12 September 2025 after the unrest of September 2025, elections were held on 5 March 2026, and the understanding on importing ten thousand megawatts over ten years dates from 2 June 2023; the owners classify this as political engagement plus an agreed power-trade target and record expressly that it is not a revised Treaty of 1950, so an answer must not convert an energy-trade understanding into a renegotiated foundational treaty, and must read the sequence alongside Bangladesh and Sri Lanka as three simultaneous transition tests inside a single cycle. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q68. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Nepal's transition and the power-trade understanding?

A. Neighbourhood First is India's stated policy priority of engaging South Asian neighbours ahead of more distant partners through connectivity, development assistance and people-to-people ties, delivered by prime-ministerial visits, policy statements, lines of credit, power-grid interlinkage, transit and transport protocols and river-water cooperation, with readiness for humanitarian assistance and disaster relief built in; the qualification the owners insist upon is that the doctrine is not applied identically to every neighbour, because its emphasis is calibrated by the partner's size, history and current politics. B. This topic owns India's engagement with Bangladesh, Bhutan, Nepal, Sri Lanka, Myanmar, Pakistan and Afghanistan, together with the Neighbourhood First policy, the Gujral Doctrine, and the development, connectivity and people-to-people instruments that carry them, and its distinctive feature is that it is simultaneously doctrinal and heavily evidence-bound: one General Studies Paper II Mains demand from 2022 is routed to it in the audited ledgers alongside four objective demands from 2020, 2023 and 2026; Maldives is deliberately cross-linked to topic 04 because its salience is primarily maritime, the SAARC and BIMSTEC institutional comparison is reserved for topic 10, and the physical border and route geography belongs to the Geography owner. C. Tharoor counts Pakistan, China, Nepal, Bhutan, Bangladesh, Myanmar, Sri Lanka and Maldives as sharing a land or maritime border with India, and adds Afghanistan as a near-neighbour because Pakistan's capture in 1948 of a strip of north-western Kashmir made Afghanistan territorially adjacent, and he separately records that of the eight bordering states there has been a history of problems, of varying degrees of difficulty, with six; the examinable consequence is that neighbourhood in Indian strategic practice is defined by security relevance and not only by strict territorial contiguity, and that friction is a structural feature rather than an aberration. D. India welcomed the interim government led by Sushila Karki on 12 September 2025 after the unrest of September 2025, elections were held on 5 March 2026, and the understanding on importing ten thousand megawatts over ten years dates from 2 June 2023; the owners classify this as political engagement plus an agreed power-trade target and record expressly that it is not a revised Treaty of 1950, so an answer must not convert an energy-trade understanding into a renegotiated foundational treaty, and must read the sequence alongside Bangladesh and Sri Lanka as three simultaneous transition tests inside a single cycle.

Answer: D. Explanation: India welcomed the interim government led by Sushila Karki on 12 September 2025 after the unrest of September 2025, elections were held on 5 March 2026, and the understanding on importing ten thousand megawatts over ten years dates from 2 June 2023; the owners classify this as political engagement plus an agreed power-trade target and record expressly that it is not a revised Treaty of 1950, so an answer must not convert an energy-trade understanding into a renegotiated foundational treaty, and must read the sequence alongside Bangladesh and Sri Lanka as three simultaneous transition tests inside a single

cycle. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q69. Which statement correctly identifies Afghanistan engagement and the presence-against-recognition distinction?

A. India engaged the Taliban administration through the Foreign Secretary's Dubai meeting of 8 January 2025 and the External Affairs Minister's New Delhi meeting of 10 October 2025, and restored its Kabul Technical Mission to Embassy status with immediate effect on 21 October 2025; the owners state explicitly that this is a change in the level of India's diplomatic presence and that the official record contains no recognition declaration, so the upgrade must never be reported as recognition of the administration, and the near-neighbour framing from Tharoor supplies the reason the relationship is treated as vital to national security despite the absence of a direct pre-1947 border. B. This topic owns India's engagement with Bangladesh, Bhutan, Nepal, Sri Lanka, Myanmar, Pakistan and Afghanistan, together with the Neighbourhood First policy, the Gujral Doctrine, and the development, connectivity and people-to-people instruments that carry them, and its distinctive feature is that it is simultaneously doctrinal and heavily evidence-bound: one General Studies Paper II Mains demand from 2022 is routed to it in the audited ledgers alongside four objective demands from 2020, 2023 and 2026; Maldives is deliberately cross-linked to topic 04 because its salience is primarily maritime, the SAARC and BIMSTEC institutional comparison is reserved for topic 10, and the physical border and route geography belongs to the Geography owner. C. The Cabinet Committee on Security decided on 23 April 2025 that the Indus Waters Treaty of 1960 will be held in abeyance with immediate effect until Pakistan credibly and irrevocably abjures its support for cross-border terrorism, Operation Sindoor was described officially on 7 May 2025 as measured, non-escalatory, proportionate, and responsible, and on 10 May 2025 India recorded an understanding to stop all military activities, while India separately maintains that the Court of Arbitration seized of the matter is illegally constituted and its awards null and void, a position restated on 16 May 2026; the owners fix the classification as an executive decision plus an operation plus an understanding, expressly not treaty termination and not a formal ceasefire agreement, and they draw the doctrinal point that non-reciprocal accommodation is least stable where the shared resource is finite, since it can be withdrawn when linked to a security condition. D. The owners state that neighbourhood policy success is not measured by the number of agreements signed but by whether connectivity and development commitments are delivered and sustained across changes of government in the partner state, and they add the outside-power variable through Sikri's period-specific critique that India's policy on Pakistan, Bangladesh, Nepal and Sri Lanka was being guided by the United States and that the government of the day seemed to have outsourced its South Asia policy, which must be cited as a dated author-specific argument about the risk of external-power involvement rather than as a description of current policy; on ownership the ledgers route one Mains demand from 2022 General Studies Paper II and four objective demands, namely 2020 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 64 on India's trade with Sri Lanka, Bangladesh and Nepal, 2023 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 10 on regional connectivity projects including the Trilateral Highway and the Bangladesh-China-India-Myanmar corridor, and 2026 Prelims General Studies Paper I questions 61 and 67 on cross-border bridges with Bangladesh, Myanmar and Nepal and on development-assistance projects matched with neighbouring partner countries and locations, with no option or answer recorded or inferred for any of them.

Answer: A. Explanation: India engaged the Taliban administration through the Foreign Secretary's Dubai meeting of 8 January 2025 and the External Affairs Minister's New Delhi meeting of 10 October 2025, and restored its Kabul Technical Mission to Embassy status with immediate effect on 21 October 2025; the owners state explicitly that this is a change in the level of India's diplomatic presence and that the official record contains no recognition declaration, so the upgrade must never be reported as recognition of the administration, and the near-neighbour framing from Tharoor supplies the reason the relationship is treated as vital to national security despite the absence of a direct pre-1947 border. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q70. Which card should be filed under Afghanistan engagement and the presence-against-recognition distinction in an International Relations answer?

A. This topic owns India's engagement with Bangladesh, Bhutan, Nepal, Sri Lanka, Myanmar, Pakistan and Afghanistan, together with the Neighbourhood First policy, the Gujral Doctrine, and the development, connectivity and people-to-people instruments that carry them, and its distinctive feature is that it is simultaneously doctrinal and heavily evidence-bound: one General Studies Paper II Mains demand from 2022 is routed to it in the audited ledgers alongside four objective demands from 2020, 2023 and 2026; Maldives is deliberately cross-linked to topic 04 because its salience is primarily maritime, the SAARC and BIMSTEC institutional comparison is reserved for topic 10, and the physical border and route geography belongs to the Geography owner. B. India engaged the Taliban administration through the Foreign Secretary's Dubai meeting of 8 January 2025 and the External Affairs Minister's New Delhi meeting of 10 October 2025, and restored its Kabul Technical Mission to Embassy status with immediate effect on 21 October 2025; the owners state explicitly that this is a change in the level of India's diplomatic presence and that the official record contains no recognition declaration, so the upgrade must never be reported as recognition of the administration, and the near-neighbour framing from Tharoor supplies the reason the relationship is treated as vital to national security despite the absence of a direct pre-1947 border. C. Tharoor counts Pakistan, China, Nepal, Bhutan, Bangladesh, Myanmar, Sri Lanka and Maldives as sharing a land or maritime border with India, and adds Afghanistan as a near-neighbour because Pakistan's capture in 1948 of a strip of north-western Kashmir made Afghanistan territorially adjacent, and he separately records that of the eight bordering states there has been a history of problems, of varying degrees of difficulty, with six; the examinable consequence is that neighbourhood in Indian strategic practice is defined by security relevance and not only by strict territorial contiguity, and that friction is a structural feature rather than an aberration. D. The owners state that neighbourhood policy success is not measured by the number of agreements signed but by whether connectivity and development commitments are delivered and sustained across changes of government in the partner state, and they add the outside-power variable through Sikri's period-specific critique that India's policy on Pakistan, Bangladesh, Nepal and Sri Lanka was being guided by the United States and that the government of the day seemed to have outsourced its South Asia policy, which must be cited as a dated author-specific argument about the risk of external-power involvement rather than as a description of current policy; on ownership the ledgers route one Mains demand from 2022 General Studies Paper II and four objective demands, namely 2020 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 64 on India's trade with Sri Lanka, Bangladesh and Nepal, 2023 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 10 on regional connectivity projects including the Trilateral Highway and the Bangladesh-China-India-Myanmar corridor, and 2026 Prelims General Studies Paper I questions 61 and 67 on cross-border bridges with Bangladesh, Myanmar and Nepal and on development-assistance projects matched with neighbouring partner countries and locations, with no option or answer recorded or inferred for any of them.

Answer: B. Explanation: India engaged the Taliban administration through the Foreign Secretary's Dubai meeting of 8 January 2025 and the External Affairs Minister's New Delhi meeting of 10 October 2025, and restored its Kabul Technical Mission to Embassy status with immediate effect on 21 October 2025; the owners state explicitly that this is a change in the level of India's diplomatic presence and that the official record contains no recognition declaration, so the upgrade must never be reported as recognition of the administration, and the near-neighbour framing from Tharoor supplies the reason the relationship is treated as vital to national security despite the absence of a direct pre-1947 border. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q71. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Afghanistan engagement and the presence-against-recognition distinction?

A. This topic owns India's engagement with Bangladesh, Bhutan, Nepal, Sri Lanka, Myanmar, Pakistan and Afghanistan, together with the Neighbourhood First policy, the Gujral Doctrine, and the development, connectivity and people-to-people instruments that carry them, and its distinctive feature is that it is simultaneously doctrinal and heavily evidence-bound: one General Studies Paper II Mains demand from 2022 is routed to it in the audited ledgers alongside four objective demands from 2020, 2023 and 2026; Maldives is deliberately cross-linked to topic 04 because its salience is primarily maritime, the SAARC and BIMSTEC institutional comparison is reserved for topic 10, and the physical border and route geography belongs to the Geography owner. B. Tharoor counts Pakistan, China, Nepal, Bhutan, Bangladesh, Myanmar, Sri Lanka and Maldives as sharing a land or maritime border with India, and adds Afghanistan as a near-neighbour because Pakistan's capture in 1948 of a strip of north-western Kashmir made

Afghanistan territorially adjacent, and he separately records that of the eight bordering states there has been a history of problems, of varying degrees of difficulty, with six; the examinable consequence is that neighbourhood in Indian strategic practice is defined by security relevance and not only by strict territorial contiguity, and that friction is a structural feature rather than an aberration. C. India engaged the Taliban administration through the Foreign Secretary's Dubai meeting of 8 January 2025 and the External Affairs Minister's New Delhi meeting of 10 October 2025, and restored its Kabul Technical Mission to Embassy status with immediate effect on 21 October 2025; the owners state explicitly that this is a change in the level of India's diplomatic presence and that the official record contains no recognition declaration, so the upgrade must never be reported as recognition of the administration, and the near-neighbour framing from Tharoor supplies the reason the relationship is treated as vital to national security despite the absence of a direct pre-1947 border. D. Neighbourhood First is India's stated policy priority of engaging South Asian neighbours ahead of more distant partners through connectivity, development assistance and people-to-people ties, delivered by prime-ministerial visits, policy statements, lines of credit, power-grid interlinkage, transit and transport protocols and river-water cooperation, with readiness for humanitarian assistance and disaster relief built in; the qualification the owners insist upon is that the doctrine is not applied identically to every neighbour, because its emphasis is calibrated by the partner's size, history and current politics.

Answer: C. Explanation: India engaged the Taliban administration through the Foreign Secretary's Dubai meeting of 8 January 2025 and the External Affairs Minister's New Delhi meeting of 10 October 2025, and restored its Kabul Technical Mission to Embassy status with immediate effect on 21 October 2025; the owners state explicitly that this is a change in the level of India's diplomatic presence and that the official record contains no recognition declaration, so the upgrade must never be reported as recognition of the administration, and the near-neighbour framing from Tharoor supplies the reason the relationship is treated as vital to national security despite the absence of a direct pre-1947 border. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q72. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Afghanistan engagement and the presence-against-recognition distinction?

A. Neighbourhood First is India's stated policy priority of engaging South Asian neighbours ahead of more distant partners through connectivity, development assistance and people-to-people ties, delivered by prime-ministerial visits, policy statements, lines of credit, power-grid interlinkage, transit and transport protocols and river-water cooperation, with readiness for humanitarian assistance and disaster relief built in; the qualification the owners insist upon is that the doctrine is not applied identically to every neighbour, because its emphasis is calibrated by the partner's size, history and current politics. B. Tharoor counts Pakistan, China, Nepal, Bhutan, Bangladesh, Myanmar, Sri Lanka and Maldives as sharing a land or maritime border with India, and adds Afghanistan as a near-neighbour because Pakistan's capture in 1948 of a strip of north-western Kashmir made Afghanistan territorially adjacent, and he separately records that of the eight bordering states there has been a history of problems, of varying degrees of difficulty, with six; the examinable consequence is that neighbourhood in Indian strategic practice is defined by security relevance and not only by strict territorial contiguity, and that friction is a structural feature rather than an aberration. C. The Gujral Doctrine, associated with former Prime Minister I. K. Gujral, is a five-principle approach under which India does not seek reciprocity from smaller neighbours, does not interfere in their internal affairs, does not allow its territory to be used against them, respects their territorial integrity, and settles disputes bilaterally and peacefully, and it remains the standard doctrinal reference for South Asia policy; the defining feature that examiners test is non-reciprocal accommodation, so any statement that the doctrine demands reciprocity as a precondition for cooperation inverts its meaning exactly. D. India engaged the Taliban administration through the Foreign Secretary's Dubai meeting of 8 January 2025 and the External Affairs Minister's New Delhi meeting of 10 October 2025, and restored its Kabul Technical Mission to Embassy status with immediate effect on 21 October 2025; the owners state explicitly that this is a change in the level of India's diplomatic presence and that the official record contains no recognition declaration, so the upgrade must never be reported as recognition of the administration, and the near-neighbour framing from Tharoor supplies the reason the relationship is treated as vital to national security despite the absence of a direct pre-1947 border.

Answer: D. Explanation: India engaged the Taliban administration through the Foreign Secretary's Dubai meeting of 8 January 2025 and the External Affairs Minister's New Delhi meeting of 10 October 2025, and restored its Kabul Technical Mission to Embassy status with immediate effect on 21 October 2025; the owners state explicitly that this is a change in the level of India's diplomatic presence and that the official

record contains no recognition declaration, so the upgrade must never be reported as recognition of the administration, and the near-neighbour framing from Tharoor supplies the reason the relationship is treated as vital to national security despite the absence of a direct pre-1947 border. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q73. Which statement correctly identifies Pakistan and the water-security linkage under adversarial conditions?

A. The Cabinet Committee on Security decided on 23 April 2025 that the Indus Waters Treaty of 1960 will be held in abeyance with immediate effect until Pakistan credibly and irrevocably abjures its support for cross-border terrorism, Operation Sindoor was described officially on 7 May 2025 as measured, non-escalatory, proportionate, and responsible, and on 10 May 2025 India recorded an understanding to stop all military activities, while India separately maintains that the Court of Arbitration seized of the matter is illegally constituted and its awards null and void, a position restated on 16 May 2026; the owners fix the classification as an executive decision plus an operation plus an understanding, expressly not treaty termination and not a formal ceasefire agreement, and they draw the doctrinal point that non-reciprocal accommodation is least stable where the shared resource is finite, since it can be withdrawn when linked to a security condition. B. The owners state that neighbourhood policy success is not measured by the number of agreements signed but by whether connectivity and development commitments are delivered and sustained across changes of government in the partner state, and they add the outside-power variable through Sikri's period-specific critique that India's policy on Pakistan, Bangladesh, Nepal and Sri Lanka was being guided by the United States and that the government of the day seemed to have outsourced its South Asia policy, which must be cited as a dated author-specific argument about the risk of external-power involvement rather than as a description of current policy; on ownership the ledgers route one Mains demand from 2022 General Studies Paper II and four objective demands, namely 2020 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 64 on India's trade with Sri Lanka, Bangladesh and Nepal, 2023 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 10 on regional connectivity projects including the Trilateral Highway and the Bangladesh-China-India-Myanmar corridor, and 2026 Prelims General Studies Paper I questions 61 and 67 on cross-border bridges with Bangladesh, Myanmar and Nepal and on development-assistance projects matched with neighbouring partner countries and locations, with no option or answer recorded or inferred for any of them. C. Tharoor counts Pakistan, China, Nepal, Bhutan, Bangladesh, Myanmar, Sri Lanka and Maldives as sharing a land or maritime border with India, and adds Afghanistan as a near-neighbour because Pakistan's capture in 1948 of a strip of north-western Kashmir made Afghanistan territorially adjacent, and he separately records that of the eight bordering states there has been a history of problems, of varying degrees of difficulty, with six; the examinable consequence is that neighbourhood in Indian strategic practice is defined by security relevance and not only by strict territorial contiguity, and that friction is a structural feature rather than an aberration. D. This topic owns India's engagement with Bangladesh, Bhutan, Nepal, Sri Lanka, Myanmar, Pakistan and Afghanistan, together with the Neighbourhood First policy, the Gujral Doctrine, and the development, connectivity and people-to-people instruments that carry them, and its distinctive feature is that it is simultaneously doctrinal and heavily evidence-bound: one General Studies Paper II Mains demand from 2022 is routed to it in the audited ledgers alongside four objective demands from 2020, 2023 and 2026; Maldives is deliberately cross-linked to topic 04 because its salience is primarily maritime, the SAARC and BIMSTEC institutional comparison is reserved for topic 10, and the physical border and route geography belongs to the Geography owner.

Answer: A. Explanation: The Cabinet Committee on Security decided on 23 April 2025 that the Indus Waters Treaty of 1960 will be held in abeyance with immediate effect until Pakistan credibly and irrevocably abjures its support for cross-border terrorism, Operation Sindoor was described officially on 7 May 2025 as measured, non-escalatory, proportionate, and responsible, and on 10 May 2025 India recorded an understanding to stop all military activities, while India separately maintains that the Court of Arbitration seized of the matter is illegally constituted and its awards null and void, a position restated on 16 May 2026; the owners fix the classification as an executive decision plus an operation plus an understanding, expressly not treaty termination and not a formal ceasefire agreement, and they draw the doctrinal point that non-reciprocal accommodation is least stable where the shared resource is finite, since it can be withdrawn when linked to a security condition. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q74. Which card should be filed under Pakistan and the water-security linkage under adversarial conditions in an International Relations answer?

A. Neighbourhood First is India's stated policy priority of engaging South Asian neighbours ahead of more distant partners through connectivity, development assistance and people-to-people ties, delivered by prime-ministerial visits, policy statements, lines of credit, power-grid interlinkage, transit and transport protocols and river-water cooperation, with readiness for humanitarian assistance and disaster relief built in; the qualification the owners insist upon is that the doctrine is not applied identically to every neighbour, because its emphasis is calibrated by the partner's size, history and current politics. B. The Cabinet Committee on Security decided on 23 April 2025 that the Indus Waters Treaty of 1960 will be held in abeyance with immediate effect until Pakistan credibly and irrevocably abjures its support for cross-border terrorism, Operation Sindoor was described officially on 7 May 2025 as measured, non-escalatory, proportionate, and responsible, and on 10 May 2025 India recorded an understanding to stop all military activities, while India separately maintains that the Court of Arbitration seized of the matter is illegally constituted and its awards null and void, a position restated on 16 May 2026; the owners fix the classification as an executive decision plus an operation plus an understanding, expressly not treaty termination and not a formal ceasefire agreement, and they draw the doctrinal point that non-reciprocal accommodation is least stable where the shared resource is finite, since it can be withdrawn when linked to a security condition. C. Tharoor counts Pakistan, China, Nepal, Bhutan, Bangladesh, Myanmar, Sri Lanka and Maldives as sharing a land or maritime border with India, and adds Afghanistan as a near-neighbour because Pakistan's capture in 1948 of a strip of north-western Kashmir made Afghanistan territorially adjacent, and he separately records that of the eight bordering states there has been a history of problems, of varying degrees of difficulty, with six; the examinable consequence is that neighbourhood in Indian strategic practice is defined by security relevance and not only by strict territorial contiguity, and that friction is a structural feature rather than an aberration. D. This topic owns India's engagement with Bangladesh, Bhutan, Nepal, Sri Lanka, Myanmar, Pakistan and Afghanistan, together with the Neighbourhood First policy, the Gujral Doctrine, and the development, connectivity and people-to-people instruments that carry them, and its distinctive feature is that it is simultaneously doctrinal and heavily evidence-bound: one General Studies Paper II Mains demand from 2022 is routed to it in the audited ledgers alongside four objective demands from 2020, 2023 and 2026; Maldives is deliberately cross-linked to topic 04 because its salience is primarily maritime, the SAARC and BIMSTEC institutional comparison is reserved for topic 10, and the physical border and route geography belongs to the Geography owner.

Answer: B. Explanation: The Cabinet Committee on Security decided on 23 April 2025 that the Indus Waters Treaty of 1960 will be held in abeyance with immediate effect until Pakistan credibly and irrevocably abjures its support for cross-border terrorism, Operation Sindoor was described officially on 7 May 2025 as measured, non-escalatory, proportionate, and responsible, and on 10 May 2025 India recorded an understanding to stop all military activities, while India separately maintains that the Court of Arbitration seized of the matter is illegally constituted and its awards null and void, a position restated on 16 May 2026; the owners fix the classification as an executive decision plus an operation plus an understanding, expressly not treaty termination and not a formal ceasefire agreement, and they draw the doctrinal point that non-reciprocal accommodation is least stable where the shared resource is finite, since it can be withdrawn when linked to a security condition. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q75. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Pakistan and the water-security linkage under adversarial conditions?

A. Neighbourhood First is India's stated policy priority of engaging South Asian neighbours ahead of more distant partners through connectivity, development assistance and people-to-people ties, delivered by prime-ministerial visits, policy statements, lines of credit, power-grid interlinkage, transit and transport protocols and river-water cooperation, with readiness for humanitarian assistance and disaster relief built in; the qualification the owners insist upon is that the doctrine is not applied identically to every neighbour, because its emphasis is calibrated by the partner's size, history and current politics. B. Tharoor counts Pakistan, China, Nepal, Bhutan, Bangladesh, Myanmar, Sri Lanka and Maldives as sharing a land or maritime border with India, and adds Afghanistan as a near-neighbour because Pakistan's capture in 1948 of a strip of north-western Kashmir made Afghanistan territorially adjacent, and he separately records that of the eight bordering states there has been a history of problems, of varying degrees of difficulty, with six; the examinable consequence is that neighbourhood in Indian strategic practice is defined by security relevance and not only by strict territorial contiguity, and that friction is a structural feature rather than an

aberration. C. The Cabinet Committee on Security decided on 23 April 2025 that the Indus Waters Treaty of 1960 will be held in abeyance with immediate effect until Pakistan credibly and irrevocably abjures its support for cross-border terrorism, Operation Sindoor was described officially on 7 May 2025 as measured, non-escalatory, proportionate, and responsible, and on 10 May 2025 India recorded an understanding to stop all military activities, while India separately maintains that the Court of Arbitration seized of the matter is illegally constituted and its awards null and void, a position restated on 16 May 2026; the owners fix the classification as an executive decision plus an operation plus an understanding, expressly not treaty termination and not a formal ceasefire agreement, and they draw the doctrinal point that non-reciprocal accommodation is least stable where the shared resource is finite, since it can be withdrawn when linked to a security condition. D. The Gujral Doctrine, associated with former Prime Minister I. K. Gujral, is a five-principle approach under which India does not seek reciprocity from smaller neighbours, does not interfere in their internal affairs, does not allow its territory to be used against them, respects their territorial integrity, and settles disputes bilaterally and peacefully, and it remains the standard doctrinal reference for South Asia policy; the defining feature that examiners test is non-reciprocal accommodation, so any statement that the doctrine demands reciprocity as a precondition for cooperation inverts its meaning exactly.

Answer: C. Explanation: The Cabinet Committee on Security decided on 23 April 2025 that the Indus Waters Treaty of 1960 will be held in abeyance with immediate effect until Pakistan credibly and irrevocably abjures its support for cross-border terrorism, Operation Sindoor was described officially on 7 May 2025 as measured, non-escalatory, proportionate, and responsible, and on 10 May 2025 India recorded an understanding to stop all military activities, while India separately maintains that the Court of Arbitration seized of the matter is illegally constituted and its awards null and void, a position restated on 16 May 2026; the owners fix the classification as an executive decision plus an operation plus an understanding, expressly not treaty termination and not a formal ceasefire agreement, and they draw the doctrinal point that non-reciprocal accommodation is least stable where the shared resource is finite, since it can be withdrawn when linked to a security condition. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q76. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Pakistan and the water-security linkage under adversarial conditions?

A. India is larger in economy, population and military capacity than its entire immediate neighbourhood combined, and the owners treat this asymmetry as the structural condition that shapes how smaller states balance cooperation with India against anxiety about dependence, so the Gujral Doctrine is best read as a response to that anxiety rather than as generosity for its own sake; the analytical move that raises an answer is to treat asymmetry as a design problem to be converted into reliable public goods, instead of treating size disparity as inherently adversarial. B. The Gujral Doctrine, associated with former Prime Minister I. K. Gujral, is a five-principle approach under which India does not seek reciprocity from smaller neighbours, does not interfere in their internal affairs, does not allow its territory to be used against them, respects their territorial integrity, and settles disputes bilaterally and peacefully, and it remains the standard doctrinal reference for South Asia policy; the defining feature that examiners test is non-reciprocal accommodation, so any statement that the doctrine demands reciprocity as a precondition for cooperation inverts its meaning exactly. C. Neighbourhood First is India's stated policy priority of engaging South Asian neighbours ahead of more distant partners through connectivity, development assistance and people-to-people ties, delivered by prime-ministerial visits, policy statements, lines of credit, power-grid interlinkage, transit and transport protocols and river-water cooperation, with readiness for humanitarian assistance and disaster relief built in; the qualification the owners insist upon is that the doctrine is not applied identically to every neighbour, because its emphasis is calibrated by the partner's size, history and current politics. D. The Cabinet Committee on Security decided on 23 April 2025 that the Indus Waters Treaty of 1960 will be held in abeyance with immediate effect until Pakistan credibly and irrevocably abjures its support for cross-border terrorism, Operation Sindoor was described officially on 7 May 2025 as measured, non-escalatory, proportionate, and responsible, and on 10 May 2025 India recorded an understanding to stop all military activities, while India separately maintains that the Court of Arbitration seized of the matter is illegally constituted and its awards null and void, a position restated on 16 May 2026; the owners fix the classification as an executive decision plus an operation plus an understanding, expressly not treaty termination and not a formal ceasefire agreement, and they draw the doctrinal point that non-reciprocal accommodation is least stable where the shared resource is finite, since it can be withdrawn when linked to a security condition.

Answer: D. Explanation: The Cabinet Committee on Security decided on 23 April 2025 that the Indus Waters Treaty of 1960 will be held in abeyance with immediate effect until Pakistan credibly and irrevocably abjures its support for cross-border terrorism, Operation Sindoor was described officially on 7 May 2025 as measured, non-escalatory, proportionate, and responsible, and on 10 May 2025 India recorded an understanding to stop all military activities, while India separately maintains that the Court of Arbitration seized of the matter is illegally constituted and its awards null and void, a position restated on 16 May 2026; the owners fix the classification as an executive decision plus an operation plus an understanding, expressly not treaty termination and not a formal ceasefire agreement, and they draw the doctrinal point that non-reciprocal accommodation is least stable where the shared resource is finite, since it can be withdrawn when linked to a security condition. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q77. Which statement correctly identifies The implementation-credibility test, the outside-power variable and honest question ownership?

A. The owners state that neighbourhood policy success is not measured by the number of agreements signed but by whether connectivity and development commitments are delivered and sustained across changes of government in the partner state, and they add the outside-power variable through Sikri's period-specific critique that India's policy on Pakistan, Bangladesh, Nepal and Sri Lanka was being guided by the United States and that the government of the day seemed to have outsourced its South Asia policy, which must be cited as a dated author-specific argument about the risk of external-power involvement rather than as a description of current policy; on ownership the ledgers route one Mains demand from 2022 General Studies Paper II and four objective demands, namely 2020 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 64 on India's trade with Sri Lanka, Bangladesh and Nepal, 2023 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 10 on regional connectivity projects including the Trilateral Highway and the Bangladesh-China-India-Myanmar corridor, and 2026 Prelims General Studies Paper I questions 61 and 67 on cross-border bridges with Bangladesh, Myanmar and Nepal and on development-assistance projects matched with neighbouring partner countries and locations, with no option or answer recorded or inferred for any of them. B. This topic owns India's engagement with Bangladesh, Bhutan, Nepal, Sri Lanka, Myanmar, Pakistan and Afghanistan, together with the Neighbourhood First policy, the Gujral Doctrine, and the development, connectivity and people-to-people instruments that carry them, and its distinctive feature is that it is simultaneously doctrinal and heavily evidence-bound: one General Studies Paper II Mains demand from 2022 is routed to it in the audited ledgers alongside four objective demands from 2020, 2023 and 2026; Maldives is deliberately cross-linked to topic 04 because its salience is primarily maritime, the SAARC and BIMSTEC institutional comparison is reserved for topic 10, and the physical border and route geography belongs to the Geography owner. C. Tharoor counts Pakistan, China, Nepal, Bhutan, Bangladesh, Myanmar, Sri Lanka and Maldives as sharing a land or maritime border with India, and adds Afghanistan as a near-neighbour because Pakistan's capture in 1948 of a strip of north-western Kashmir made Afghanistan territorially adjacent, and he separately records that of the eight bordering states there has been a history of problems, of varying degrees of difficulty, with six; the examinable consequence is that neighbourhood in Indian strategic practice is defined by security relevance and not only by strict territorial contiguity, and that friction is a structural feature rather than an aberration. D. Neighbourhood First is India's stated policy priority of engaging South Asian neighbours ahead of more distant partners through connectivity, development assistance and people-to-people ties, delivered by prime-ministerial visits, policy statements, lines of credit, power-grid interlinkage, transit and transport protocols and river-water cooperation, with readiness for humanitarian assistance and disaster relief built in; the qualification the owners insist upon is that the doctrine is not applied identically to every neighbour, because its emphasis is calibrated by the partner's size, history and current politics.

Answer: A. Explanation: The owners state that neighbourhood policy success is not measured by the number of agreements signed but by whether connectivity and development commitments are delivered and sustained across changes of government in the partner state, and they add the outside-power variable through Sikri's period-specific critique that India's policy on Pakistan, Bangladesh, Nepal and Sri Lanka was being guided by the United States and that the government of the day seemed to have outsourced its South Asia policy, which must be cited as a dated author-specific argument about the risk of external-power involvement rather than as a description of current policy; on ownership the ledgers route one Mains demand from 2022 General Studies Paper II and four objective demands, namely 2020 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 64 on India's trade with Sri Lanka, Bangladesh and Nepal, 2023 Prelims General Studies Paper I

question 10 on regional connectivity projects including the Trilateral Highway and the Bangladesh-China-India-Myanmar corridor, and 2026 Prelims General Studies Paper I questions 61 and 67 on cross-border bridges with Bangladesh, Myanmar and Nepal and on development-assistance projects matched with neighbouring partner countries and locations, with no option or answer recorded or inferred for any of them. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q78. Which card should be filed under The implementation-credibility test, the outside-power variable and honest question ownership in an International Relations answer?

A. The Gujral Doctrine, associated with former Prime Minister I. K. Gujral, is a five-principle approach under which India does not seek reciprocity from smaller neighbours, does not interfere in their internal affairs, does not allow its territory to be used against them, respects their territorial integrity, and settles disputes bilaterally and peacefully, and it remains the standard doctrinal reference for South Asia policy; the defining feature that examiners test is non-reciprocal accommodation, so any statement that the doctrine demands reciprocity as a precondition for cooperation inverts its meaning exactly. B. The owners state that neighbourhood policy success is not measured by the number of agreements signed but by whether connectivity and development commitments are delivered and sustained across changes of government in the partner state, and they add the outside-power variable through Sikri's period-specific critique that India's policy on Pakistan, Bangladesh, Nepal and Sri Lanka was being guided by the United States and that the government of the day seemed to have outsourced its South Asia policy, which must be cited as a dated author-specific argument about the risk of external-power involvement rather than as a description of current policy; on ownership the ledgers route one Mains demand from 2022 General Studies Paper II and four objective demands, namely 2020 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 64 on India's trade with Sri Lanka, Bangladesh and Nepal, 2023 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 10 on regional connectivity projects including the Trilateral Highway and the Bangladesh-China-India-Myanmar corridor, and 2026 Prelims General Studies Paper I questions 61 and 67 on cross-border bridges with Bangladesh, Myanmar and Nepal and on development-assistance projects matched with neighbouring partner countries and locations, with no option or answer recorded or inferred for any of them. C. Tharoor counts Pakistan, China, Nepal, Bhutan, Bangladesh, Myanmar, Sri Lanka and Maldives as sharing a land or maritime border with India, and adds Afghanistan as a near-neighbour because Pakistan's capture in 1948 of a strip of north-western Kashmir made Afghanistan territorially adjacent, and he separately records that of the eight bordering states there has been a history of problems, of varying degrees of difficulty, with six; the examinable consequence is that neighbourhood in Indian strategic practice is defined by security relevance and not only by strict territorial contiguity, and that friction is a structural feature rather than an aberration. D. Neighbourhood First is India's stated policy priority of engaging South Asian neighbours ahead of more distant partners through connectivity, development assistance and people-to-people ties, delivered by prime-ministerial visits, policy statements, lines of credit, power-grid interlinkage, transit and transport protocols and river-water cooperation, with readiness for humanitarian assistance and disaster relief built in; the qualification the owners insist upon is that the doctrine is not applied identically to every neighbour, because its emphasis is calibrated by the partner's size, history and current politics.

Answer: B. Explanation: The owners state that neighbourhood policy success is not measured by the number of agreements signed but by whether connectivity and development commitments are delivered and sustained across changes of government in the partner state, and they add the outside-power variable through Sikri's period-specific critique that India's policy on Pakistan, Bangladesh, Nepal and Sri Lanka was being guided by the United States and that the government of the day seemed to have outsourced its South Asia policy, which must be cited as a dated author-specific argument about the risk of external-power involvement rather than as a description of current policy; on ownership the ledgers route one Mains demand from 2022 General Studies Paper II and four objective demands, namely 2020 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 64 on India's trade with Sri Lanka, Bangladesh and Nepal, 2023 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 10 on regional connectivity projects including the Trilateral Highway and the Bangladesh-China-India-Myanmar corridor, and 2026 Prelims General Studies Paper I questions 61 and 67 on cross-border bridges with Bangladesh, Myanmar and Nepal and on development-assistance projects matched with neighbouring partner countries and locations, with no option or answer recorded or inferred for any of them. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q79. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of The implementation-credibility test, the outside-power variable and honest question ownership?

A. The Gujral Doctrine, associated with former Prime Minister I. K. Gujral, is a five-principle approach under which India does not seek reciprocity from smaller neighbours, does not interfere in their internal affairs, does not allow its territory to be used against them, respects their territorial integrity, and settles disputes bilaterally and peacefully, and it remains the standard doctrinal reference for South Asia policy; the defining feature that examiners test is non-reciprocal accommodation, so any statement that the doctrine demands reciprocity as a precondition for cooperation inverts its meaning exactly. B. Neighbourhood First is India's stated policy priority of engaging South Asian neighbours ahead of more distant partners through connectivity, development assistance and people-to-people ties, delivered by prime-ministerial visits, policy statements, lines of credit, power-grid interlinkage, transit and transport protocols and river-water cooperation, with readiness for humanitarian assistance and disaster relief built in; the qualification the owners insist upon is that the doctrine is not applied identically to every neighbour, because its emphasis is calibrated by the partner's size, history and current politics. C. The owners state that neighbourhood policy success is not measured by the number of agreements signed but by whether connectivity and development commitments are delivered and sustained across changes of government in the partner state, and they add the outside-power variable through Sikri's period-specific critique that India's policy on Pakistan, Bangladesh, Nepal and Sri Lanka was being guided by the United States and that the government of the day seemed to have outsourced its South Asia policy, which must be cited as a dated author-specific argument about the risk of external-power involvement rather than as a description of current policy; on ownership the ledgers route one Mains demand from 2022 General Studies Paper II and four objective demands, namely 2020 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 64 on India's trade with Sri Lanka, Bangladesh and Nepal, 2023 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 10 on regional connectivity projects including the Trilateral Highway and the Bangladesh-China-India-Myanmar corridor, and 2026 Prelims General Studies Paper I questions 61 and 67 on cross-border bridges with Bangladesh, Myanmar and Nepal and on development-assistance projects matched with neighbouring partner countries and locations, with no option or answer recorded or inferred for any of them. D. India is larger in economy, population and military capacity than its entire immediate neighbourhood combined, and the owners treat this asymmetry as the structural condition that shapes how smaller states balance cooperation with India against anxiety about dependence, so the Gujral Doctrine is best read as a response to that anxiety rather than as generosity for its own sake; the analytical move that raises an answer is to treat asymmetry as a design problem to be converted into reliable public goods, instead of treating size disparity as inherently adversarial.

Answer: C. Explanation: The owners state that neighbourhood policy success is not measured by the number of agreements signed but by whether connectivity and development commitments are delivered and sustained across changes of government in the partner state, and they add the outside-power variable through Sikri's period-specific critique that India's policy on Pakistan, Bangladesh, Nepal and Sri Lanka was being guided by the United States and that the government of the day seemed to have outsourced its South Asia policy, which must be cited as a dated author-specific argument about the risk of external-power involvement rather than as a description of current policy; on ownership the ledgers route one Mains demand from 2022 General Studies Paper II and four objective demands, namely 2020 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 64 on India's trade with Sri Lanka, Bangladesh and Nepal, 2023 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 10 on regional connectivity projects including the Trilateral Highway and the Bangladesh-China-India-Myanmar corridor, and 2026 Prelims General Studies Paper I questions 61 and 67 on cross-border bridges with Bangladesh, Myanmar and Nepal and on development-assistance projects matched with neighbouring partner countries and locations, with no option or answer recorded or inferred for any of them. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q80. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about The implementation-credibility test, the outside-power variable and honest question ownership?

A. The Gujral Doctrine, associated with former Prime Minister I. K. Gujral, is a five-principle approach under which India does not seek reciprocity from smaller neighbours, does not interfere in their internal affairs, does not allow its territory to be used against them, respects their territorial integrity, and settles disputes bilaterally and peacefully, and it remains the standard doctrinal reference for South Asia policy; the defining feature that examiners test is non-reciprocal accommodation, so any statement that the doctrine demands reciprocity as a precondition for cooperation inverts its meaning exactly. B. Sikri records that smaller neighbours like Bhutan, Nepal, Maldives and Sri Lanka have shown greater interest in economic integration with India than the larger ones like Pakistan and Bangladesh, and that they are more receptive to cooperation within a regional framework than on a bilateral basis because numbers give them a sense of greater security, which the owners treat as a structural rather than merely tactical preference; the necessary qualification is that this preference does not amount to rejecting bilateral engagement, because the substantive connectivity work still proceeds bilaterally while the regional overlay supplies political reassurance. C. India is larger in economy, population and military capacity than its entire immediate neighbourhood combined, and the owners treat this asymmetry as the structural condition that shapes how smaller states balance cooperation with India against anxiety about dependence, so the Gujral Doctrine is best read as a response to that anxiety rather than as generosity for its own sake; the analytical move that raises an answer is to treat asymmetry as a design problem to be converted into reliable public goods, instead of treating size disparity as inherently adversarial. D. The owners state that neighbourhood policy success is not measured by the number of agreements signed but by whether connectivity and development commitments are delivered and sustained across changes of government in the partner state, and they add the outside-power variable through Sikri's period-specific critique that India's policy on Pakistan, Bangladesh, Nepal and Sri Lanka was being guided by the United States and that the government of the day seemed to have outsourced its South Asia policy, which must be cited as a dated author-specific argument about the risk of external-power involvement rather than as a description of current policy; on ownership the ledgers route one Mains demand from 2022 General Studies Paper II and four objective demands, namely 2020 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 64 on India's trade with Sri Lanka, Bangladesh and Nepal, 2023 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 10 on regional connectivity projects including the Trilateral Highway and the Bangladesh-China-India-Myanmar corridor, and 2026 Prelims General Studies Paper I questions 61 and 67 on cross-border bridges with Bangladesh, Myanmar and Nepal and on development-assistance projects matched with neighbouring partner countries and locations, with no option or answer recorded or inferred for any of them.

Answer: D. Explanation: The owners state that neighbourhood policy success is not measured by the number of agreements signed but by whether connectivity and development commitments are delivered and sustained across changes of government in the partner state, and they add the outside-power variable through Sikri's period-specific critique that India's policy on Pakistan, Bangladesh, Nepal and Sri Lanka was being guided by the United States and that the government of the day seemed to have outsourced its South Asia policy, which must be cited as a dated author-specific argument about the risk of external-power involvement rather than as a description of current policy; on ownership the ledgers route one Mains demand from 2022 General Studies Paper II and four objective demands, namely 2020 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 64 on India's trade with Sri Lanka, Bangladesh and Nepal, 2023 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 10 on regional connectivity projects including the Trilateral Highway and the Bangladesh-China-India-Myanmar corridor, and 2026 Prelims General Studies Paper I questions 61 and 67 on cross-border bridges with Bangladesh, Myanmar and Nepal and on development-assistance projects matched with neighbouring partner countries and locations, with no option or answer recorded or inferred for any of them. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

VERIFIED PYQ OWNERSHIP AUDIT

One General Studies Paper II Mains demand is routed to this topic in the audited routing ledgers and it is reproduced below as a demand card with its printed year, paper, question number, directive, marks and word limit exactly as the ledger records them: 2022 General Studies Paper II question 9, on India's role in the recent crisis in Sri Lanka, a Discuss demand of 10 marks and 150 words, where the ledger records that the Core route supersedes the older Advanced ownership. Four objective demands are also routed to this owner and are carried as coverage requirements only: 2020 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 64 on India's trade with Sri Lanka, Bangladesh and Nepal, for which the official key is not held locally; 2023 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 10 on India's regional connectivity projects including the Trilateral Highway and the Bangladesh-China-India-Myanmar corridor, for which the official key is not held locally; and 2026 Prelims General Studies Paper I questions 61 and 67 on India's cross-border bridges with Bangladesh, Myanmar and Nepal and on Indian development-assistance projects matched with neighbouring partner countries and locations, for which only a provisional 2026 Set-A key is present locally. No option or answer letter is recorded or inferred for any objective demand, and the provisional status of the 2026 key is preserved exactly. The audited ledgers record no 2024-2025 Mains demand naming the wider South Asian neighbourhood, Maldives being separately addressed by the 2024 objective demand routed to topic 04, and that absence is stated honestly rather than filled by force-fitting an unrelated question. The locally held OCR-searchable official General Studies papers were read only to confirm the printed wording of the routed Mains demand; no question was invented from them, no stem was paraphrased into an apparent routing, and no marking scheme or page precision was imported. Every model solution below is original work written to the repository's examiner-grade standard using the claim, named evidence, analysis and qualification pattern, and none of them reproduces or claims an official answer.

Demand decoding: The directive **answer** requires a direct position on "VERIFIED PYQ OWNERSHIP AUDIT", every clause, bilateral/regional/systemic mapping, interests and constraints, objective-instrument-implementation-outcome separation, named Indian evidence, trade-offs, alternatives, implementation risks and a qualified conclusion.

Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

Introduction and thesis: The answer must resolve the International Relations demand in "VERIFIED PYQ OWNERSHIP AUDIT".

Analytical body:

- 1. Claim and named evidence:** Define the foreign-policy concept and distinguish the nearest doctrine, grouping, treaty or operational category. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.
- 2. Claim and named evidence:** Map India's interests, capabilities and constraints against the partner's agency at bilateral, regional and systemic levels. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.
- 3. Claim and named evidence:** Identify the exact treaty, institution, corridor, agreement, operation or summit with membership, mandate, date and status. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.
- 4. Claim and named evidence:** Trace strategic objective, selected instrument, implementing actors, resources, bottleneck, output and outcome. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.

5. **Claim and named evidence:** Use named India-centric diplomatic, security, trade, connectivity, diaspora or development evidence without event-listing. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.
6. **Claim and named evidence:** Test dependence, escalation, legitimacy, domestic distribution, financing, partner divergence, alternatives and residual risk. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.

Counter-position / limit: A doctrine label, summit declaration, signed document, project announcement, military exercise, trade change or diplomatic statement cannot alone establish binding obligation, operational delivery or strategic outcome; test legal character, implementation, partner response, alternatives and evidence status.

Qualified conclusion: The answer must resolve the International Relations demand in "VERIFIED PYQ OWNERSHIP AUDIT".

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For 15 marks, spend one-sixth of the time decoding the directive and drawing level -> interest -> instrument -> implementation -> outcome -> alternative; state a thesis; write four to seven claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification points; reserve the final minute for source, date, membership, operative status, partner agency, causation, escalation and residual risk.

Why this earns marks: The answer obeys the directive, explains strategy and implementation rather than listing visits or groupings, uses named India-centric evidence and preserves institutional, status, level, causal and geopolitical distinctions.

How to improve this answer: For "VERIFIED PYQ OWNERSHIP AUDIT", replace the weakest event-list point with one named actor, interest, instrument, implementation bottleneck, measurable outcome, alternative and source-date-status qualification.

OWNER PYQ LEDGER EXTRACTS

9. PYQ application

- **FACT: 2022 GS-II:** "India is an age-old friend of Sri Lanka. Discuss

India's role in the recent crisis in Sri Lanka in the light of the preceding statement." Distinguish emergency assistance from durable connectivity/development partnership and apply the implementation- credibility test.

- **ANALYSIS:** No 2024-2025 question directly names the wider South Asian neighbourhood; Maldives is addressed separately by 2024 Q20.

2026 PYQ Integration

Status: 2026 question-level PYQ demand is integrated into this owner. **Provenance:** Audited local official-paper routing ledgers: _PYQ-ROUTING-PRELIMS-2026.md. **Answer-key rule:** The 2026 Prelims and CSAT Set-A keys held locally are **provisional**; no option or answer is recorded or inferred in this integration.

- **Year represented:** 2026
- **Paper(s):** Prelims GS-I
- **Routed question demands:** 2

Year	Paper	Q	PYQ demand (neutral rendering)	Directive / format	Source status	Owner requirement
2026	Prelims GS-I	61	India's cross-border bridges with Bangladesh, Myanmar, and Nepal	Objective question; provisional 2026 Set-A key present locally, answer not inferred	Provisional 2026 Set-A key present locally (Ans - ■2026 - ■GS1 - ■Provis ional); key is provisional - no answer letter recorded or inferred here	Cover the named fact/concept and its likely statement-level distinctions.
2026	Prelims GS-I	67	Indian development-assistance projects matched with neighbouring partner countries and locations	Objective question; provisional 2026 Set-A key present locally, answer not inferred	Provisional 2026 Set-A key present locally (Ans - ■2026 - ■GS1 - ■Provis ional); key is provisional - no answer letter recorded or inferred here	Cover the named fact/concept and its likely statement-level distinctions.

What this owner must now support

- India's cross-border bridges with Bangladesh, Myanmar, and Nepal
- Indian development-assistance projects matched with neighbouring partner countries and locations

This block integrates the 2026 examinable demand and paper metadata. It is kept separate from the 2018-2023 and 2024-2025 blocks and does not convert a provisionally-keyed, answer-free objective question into a solved answer.

Historical PYQ Integration (2018-2023)

Status: Question-level PYQ demand is integrated into this owner. **Provenance:** Audited local official-paper routing ledgers: _PYQ-ROUTING-MAINS-GS1-GS2-ESSAY-2018-2023.md, _PYQ-ROUTING-PRELIMS-2018-2023.md. **Answer-key rule:** The official 2018-2023 Prelims/CSAT keys are not held locally; no option or answer has been inferred.

- **Years represented:** 2020, 2022, 2023
- **Paper(s):** GS-II, Prelims GS-I
- **Routed question demands:** 3

Year	Paper	Q	PYQ demand (neutral rendering)	Directive / format	Source status	Owner requirement
2020	Prelims GS-I	64	India trade with Sri Lanka Bangladesh and Nepal	Objective question; official key unavailable locally	Routed; key unavailable locally	Cover the named fact/concept and its likely statement-level distinctions.
2022	GS-II	9	India's role in the recent crisis in Sri Lanka	Discuss · 10 marks · 150 words	Core route supersedes older Advanced ownership	Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
2023	Prelims GS-I	10	India regional connectivity projects Trilateral Highway BCIM	Objective question; official key unavailable locally	Routed; key unavailable locally	Cover the named fact/concept and its likely statement-level distinctions.

What this owner must now support

- India trade with Sri Lanka Bangladesh and Nepal
- India's role in the recent crisis in Sri Lanka
- India regional connectivity projects Trilateral Highway BCIM

The table integrates the examinable demand and paper metadata. It does not turn an unkeyed objective question into a solved answer, and it does not claim that lexical presence alone proves full conceptual sufficiency.

10. PYQ-based analytical application

- **FACT: 2022 GS-II** on India's role in Sri Lanka's crisis directly tests

whether historical friendship converts into timely, credible assistance; separate emergency support from long-term delivery and acknowledge Sri Lankan agency.

- **ANALYSIS:** No 2024-2025 question names the wider neighbourhood (Maldives is separately addressed by 2024 Q20). A strong analytical answer should:

1. Open with the structural-asymmetry framing.
2. Distinguish smaller-state and larger-state engagement patterns (Sikri).
3. Acknowledge the non-interference/historical-involvement tension explicitly.
4. Close with the implementation-credibility test as the true measure of

policy success.

Historical PYQ Integration (2018-2023)

Status: Question-level PYQ demand is integrated into this owner. **Provenance:** Audited local official-paper routing ledgers: _PYQ-ROUTING-MAINS-GS1-GS2-ESSAY-2018-2023.md.

- **Years represented:** 2022
- **Paper(s):** GS-II
- **Routed question demands:** 1

Year	Paper	Q	PYQ demand (neutral rendering)	Directive / format	Source status	Owner requirement
2022	GS-II	9	India's role in the recent crisis in Sri Lanka	Discuss · 10 marks · 150 words	Routed to owning topic	Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.

What this owner must now support

- India's role in the recent crisis in Sri Lanka

The table integrates the examinable demand and paper metadata. It does not turn an unkeyed objective question into a solved answer, and it does not claim that lexical presence alone proves full conceptual sufficiency.

PYQ DEMAND CARD 1 - 2022 General Studies Paper II Question 9

Demand: India is an age-old friend of Sri Lanka. Discuss India's role in the recent crisis in Sri Lanka in the light of the preceding statement, a Discuss demand of 10 marks and 150 words, exactly as recorded in the audited 2018-2023 Mains routing ledger.

Status: Routed to this owner in the audited 2018-2023 Mains routing ledger, where the Core route is recorded as superseding the older Advanced ownership and the word limit is taken from the instruction block. No official answer key exists for a Mains demand and none is claimed.

Model solution: Claim: India converted an inherited friendship into measurable first-responder capacity in 2022, but first-responder credibility and durable partnership are different achievements and only the first was demonstrated inside the crisis window. Named evidence and example: India's High Commission recorded more than three billion United States dollars in assistance during 2022 by 3 May 2022, comprising a one billion dollar facility for food, medicines and essentials, a five hundred million dollar petroleum credit line that had delivered close to four hundred thousand tonnes of fuel across all twenty-five districts, about one billion dollars in Asian Clearing Union payment deferment and a four hundred million dollar Reserve Bank of India currency swap; the seven memoranda of

understanding exchanged on 5 April 2025 covering high-voltage direct-current power interconnection, digital transformation, the Trincomalee energy hub, defence cooperation, Eastern Province grant assistance, health and medicine and pharmacopoeial cooperation; and the Ministry of External Affairs bilateral brief current to July 2026. Analysis: the speed and composition of the 2022 package mattered because a foreign-exchange crisis attacks fuel, food and medicine simultaneously, so a credit line, a currency swap and a payment deferment together bought macroeconomic space that a grant alone could not, which is precisely the reliable public good that the Gujral Doctrine's non-reciprocal logic is meant to supply; the later instrument set shows the relationship moving from emergency support toward connectivity and energy partnership, yet the 120 megawatt Sampur solar project had its ground-breaking rather than its commissioning, so the implementation-credibility test is still running. Qualification: the answer must not claim that Indian assistance resolved the crisis, because the owners record that emergency financing did not remove Sri Lanka's structural debt, revenue, governance and external-financing problems and that durable recovery required domestic adjustment and an International Monetary Fund-supported programme, and the aggregate must be time-bounded as more than three billion dollars by May against around four billion dollars over the full year. Why this earns marks: it answers the Discuss directive by weighing an itemised, dated evidence set against a stated limit, respects Sri Lankan agency, and closes on a measurement test instead of a declaration of friendship.

Demand decoding: The directive **answer** requires a direct position on "PYQ DEMAND CARD 1 - 2022 General Studies Paper II Question 9", every clause, bilateral/regional/systemic mapping, interests and constraints, objective-instrument-implementation-outcome separation, named Indian evidence, trade-offs, alternatives, implementation risks and a qualified conclusion.

Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

Introduction and thesis: Claim: India converted an inherited friendship into measurable first-responder capacity in 2022, but first-responder credibility and durable partnership are different achievements and only the first was demonstrated inside the crisis window. Named evidence and example: India's High Commission recorded more than three billion United States dollars in assistance during 2022 by 3 May 2022, comprising a one billion dollar facility for food, medicines and essentials, a five hundred million dollar petroleum credit line that had delivered close to four hundred thousand tonnes of fuel across all twenty-five districts, about one billion dollars in Asian Clearing Union payment deferment and a four hundred million dollar Reserve Bank of India currency swap; the seven memoranda of understanding exchanged on 5 April 2025 covering high-voltage direct-current power interconnection, digital transformation, the Trincomalee energy hub, defence cooperation, Eastern Province grant assistance, health and medicine and pharmacopoeial cooperation; and the Ministry of External Affairs bilateral brief current to July 2026. Analysis: the speed and composition of the 2022 package mattered because a foreign-exchange crisis attacks fuel, food and medicine simultaneously, so a credit line, a currency swap and a payment deferment together bought macroeconomic space that a grant alone could not, which is precisely the reliable public good that the Gujral Doctrine's non-reciprocal logic is meant to supply; the later instrument set shows the relationship moving from emergency support toward connectivity and energy partnership, yet the 120 megawatt Sampur solar project had its ground-breaking rather than its commissioning, so the implementation-credibility test is still running. Qualification: the answer must not claim that Indian assistance resolved the crisis, because the owners record that emergency financing did not remove Sri Lanka's structural debt, revenue, governance and external-financing problems and that durable recovery required domestic adjustment and an International Monetary Fund-supported programme, and the aggregate must be time-bounded as more than three billion dollars by May against around four billion dollars over the full year. Why this earns marks: it answers the Discuss directive by weighing an itemised, dated evidence set against a stated limit, respects Sri Lankan agency, and closes on a measurement test instead of a declaration of friendship.

Analytical body:

1. **Claim and named evidence:** PYQ DEMAND CARD 1 - 2022 General Studies Paper II Question 9 **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.

Counter-position / limit: A doctrine label, summit declaration, signed document, project announcement, military exercise, trade change or diplomatic statement cannot alone establish binding obligation, operational delivery or strategic outcome; test legal character, implementation, partner response, alternatives and evidence status.

Qualified conclusion: Claim: India converted an inherited friendship into measurable first-responder capacity in 2022, but first-responder credibility and durable partnership are different achievements and only the first was demonstrated inside the crisis window. Named evidence and example: India's High Commission recorded more than three billion United States dollars in assistance during 2022 by 3 May 2022, comprising a one billion dollar facility for food, medicines and essentials, a five hundred million dollar petroleum credit line that had delivered close to four hundred thousand tonnes of fuel across all twenty-five districts, about one billion dollars in Asian Clearing Union payment deferment and a four hundred million dollar Reserve Bank of India currency swap; the seven memoranda of understanding exchanged on 5 April 2025 covering high-voltage direct-current power interconnection, digital transformation, the Trincomalee energy hub, defence cooperation, Eastern Province grant assistance, health and medicine and pharmacopoeial cooperation; and the Ministry of External Affairs bilateral brief current to July 2026. Analysis: the speed and composition of the 2022 package mattered because a foreign-exchange crisis attacks fuel, food and medicine simultaneously, so a credit line, a currency swap and a payment deferment together bought macroeconomic space that a grant alone could not, which is precisely the reliable public good that the Gujral Doctrine's non-reciprocal logic is meant to supply; the later instrument set shows the relationship moving from emergency support toward connectivity and energy partnership, yet the 120 megawatt Sampur solar project had its ground-breaking rather than its commissioning, so the implementation-credibility test is still running. Qualification: the answer must not claim that Indian assistance resolved the crisis, because the owners record that emergency financing did not remove Sri Lanka's structural debt, revenue, governance and external-financing problems and that durable recovery required domestic adjustment and an International Monetary Fund-supported programme, and the aggregate must be time-bounded as more than three billion dollars by May against around four billion dollars over the full year. Why this earns marks: it answers the Discuss directive by weighing an itemised, dated evidence set against a stated limit, respects Sri Lankan agency, and closes on a measurement test instead of a declaration of friendship.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For 15 marks, spend one-sixth of the time decoding the directive and drawing level -> interest -> instrument -> implementation -> outcome -> alternative; state a thesis; write four to seven claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification points; reserve the final minute for source, date, membership, operative status, partner agency, causation, escalation and residual risk.

How to improve this answer: For "PYQ DEMAND CARD 1 - 2022 General Studies Paper II Question 9", replace the weakest event-list point with one named actor, interest, instrument, implementation bottleneck, measurable outcome, alternative and source-date-status qualification.

ORIGINAL MAINS 1 - 10 MARKS

Question: Explain the core principles of the Gujral Doctrine and show how they address the structural asymmetry between India and its smaller neighbours. Answer in about 150 words.

Model thesis: The doctrine converts asymmetry from a source of dependence anxiety into a basis for cooperation by removing reciprocity as a precondition, so the answer must state the five principles precisely, connect each to the anxiety it addresses, and qualify the claim with the fiscal and political cost of sustained non-reciprocity.

Claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification:

- The Gujral Doctrine, associated with former Prime Minister I. K. Gujral, is a five-principle approach under which India does not seek reciprocity from smaller neighbours, does not interfere in their internal affairs, does not allow its territory to be used against them, respects their territorial integrity, and settles disputes bilaterally and peacefully, and it remains the standard doctrinal reference for South Asia policy; the defining feature that examiners test is non-reciprocal accommodation, so any statement that the doctrine demands reciprocity as a precondition for cooperation inverts its meaning exactly.
- India is larger in economy, population and military capacity than its entire immediate neighbourhood combined, and the owners treat this asymmetry as the structural condition that shapes how smaller states balance cooperation with India against anxiety about dependence, so the Gujral Doctrine is best read as a response to that anxiety rather than as generosity for its own sake; the analytical move that raises an answer is to treat asymmetry as a design problem to be converted into reliable public goods, instead of treating size disparity as inherently adversarial.
- Neighbourhood First is India's stated policy priority of engaging South Asian neighbours ahead of more distant partners through connectivity, development assistance and people-to-people ties, delivered by prime-ministerial

visits, policy statements, lines of credit, power-grid interlinkage, transit and transport protocols and river-water cooperation, with readiness for humanitarian assistance and disaster relief built in; the qualification the owners insist upon is that the doctrine is not applied identically to every neighbour, because its emphasis is calibrated by the partner's size, history and current politics.

- Sikri records that smaller neighbours like Bhutan, Nepal, Maldives and Sri Lanka have shown greater interest in economic integration with India than the larger ones like Pakistan and Bangladesh, and that they are more receptive to cooperation within a regional framework than on a bilateral basis because numbers give them a sense of greater security, which the owners treat as a structural rather than merely tactical preference; the necessary qualification is that this preference does not amount to rejecting bilateral engagement, because the substantive connectivity work still proceeds bilaterally while the regional overlay supplies political reassurance.

Qualified conclusion: The doctrine converts asymmetry from a source of dependence anxiety into a basis for cooperation by removing reciprocity as a precondition, so the answer must state the five principles precisely, connect each to the anxiety it addresses, and qualify the claim with the fiscal and political cost of sustained non-reciprocity.

Demand decoding: The directive **explain** requires a direct position on "Explain the core principles of the Gujral Doctrine and show how they address the structural...", every clause, bilateral/regional/systemic mapping, interests and constraints, objective-instrument-implementation-outcome separation, named Indian evidence, trade-offs, alternatives, implementation risks and a qualified conclusion.

Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

Introduction and thesis: The doctrine converts asymmetry from a source of dependence anxiety into a basis for cooperation by removing reciprocity as a precondition, so the answer must state the five principles precisely, connect each to the anxiety it addresses, and qualify the claim with the fiscal and political cost of sustained non-reciprocity.

Analytical body:

1. **Claim and named evidence:** The Gujral Doctrine, associated with former Prime Minister I. K. Gujral, is a five-principle approach under which India does not seek reciprocity from smaller neighbours, does not interfere in their internal affairs, does not allow its territory to be used against them, respects their territorial integrity, and settles disputes bilaterally and peacefully, and it remains the standard doctrinal reference for South Asia policy; the defining feature that examiners test is non-reciprocal accommodation, so any statement that the doctrine demands reciprocity as a precondition for cooperation inverts its meaning exactly. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.
2. **Claim and named evidence:** India is larger in economy, population and military capacity than its entire immediate neighbourhood combined, and the owners treat this asymmetry as the structural condition that shapes how smaller states balance cooperation with India against anxiety about dependence, so the Gujral Doctrine is best read as a response to that anxiety rather than as generosity for its own sake; the analytical move that raises an answer is to treat asymmetry as a design problem to be converted into reliable public goods, instead of treating size disparity as inherently adversarial. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.
3. **Claim and named evidence:** Neighbourhood First is India's stated policy priority of engaging South Asian neighbours ahead of more distant partners through connectivity, development assistance and people-to-people ties, delivered by prime-ministerial visits, policy statements, lines of credit, power-grid interlinkage, transit and transport protocols and river-water cooperation, with readiness for humanitarian assistance and disaster relief built in; the qualification the owners insist upon is that the doctrine is not applied identically to every neighbour, because its emphasis is calibrated by the partner's size, history and current politics. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.

4. **Claim and named evidence:** Sikri records that smaller neighbours like Bhutan, Nepal, Maldives and Sri Lanka have shown greater interest in economic integration with India than the larger ones like Pakistan and Bangladesh, and that they are more receptive to cooperation within a regional framework than on a bilateral basis because numbers give them a sense of greater security, which the owners treat as a structural rather than merely tactical preference; the necessary qualification is that this preference does not amount to rejecting bilateral engagement, because the substantive connectivity work still proceeds bilaterally while the regional overlay supplies political reassurance. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence.

Qualification: State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.

Counter-position / limit: A doctrine label, summit declaration, signed document, project announcement, military exercise, trade change or diplomatic statement cannot alone establish binding obligation, operational delivery or strategic outcome; test legal character, implementation, partner response, alternatives and evidence status.

Qualified conclusion: The doctrine converts asymmetry from a source of dependence anxiety into a basis for cooperation by removing reciprocity as a precondition, so the answer must state the five principles precisely, connect each to the anxiety it addresses, and qualify the claim with the fiscal and political cost of sustained non-reciprocity.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For 10 marks, spend one-sixth of the time decoding the directive and drawing level -> interest -> instrument -> implementation -> outcome -> alternative; state a thesis; write four to seven claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification points; reserve the final minute for source, date, membership, operative status, partner agency, causation, escalation and residual risk.

Why this earns marks: The answer obeys the directive, explains strategy and implementation rather than listing visits or groupings, uses named India-centric evidence and preserves institutional, status, level, causal and geopolitical distinctions.

How to improve this answer: For "Explain the core principles of the Gujral Doctrine and show how they address the structural...", replace the weakest event-list point with one named actor, interest, instrument, implementation bottleneck, measurable outcome, alternative and source-date-status qualification.

ORIGINAL MAINS 2 - 10 MARKS

Question: Examine why the durability of India's neighbourhood engagement is tested by political transitions in partner states rather than by the number of agreements signed. Answer in about 150 words.

Model thesis: Durability is the real test because a regime-oriented relationship discontinues whenever the incumbent changes, so the examination must state Sikri's people-to-people prescription, use the Bangladesh, Nepal and Sri Lanka transitions of a single cycle as the dated evidence, and qualify the prescription as a partial mitigation rather than a guarantee.

Claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification:

- Sikri argues that India must move away from its excessive regime-oriented policies towards people-to-people relations on the reasoning that only neighbouring regimes which reflect their own people's interests are likely to sustain friendly relations with India, and the owners convert this into the operative test of Neighbourhood First, namely whether engagement survives a change of government in the partner state; the regime-orientation trap emerges when engagement depends too heavily on one incumbent, producing discontinuity whenever that incumbent changes, and the people-to-people reorientation is presented as a partial mitigation rather than a guarantee.
- India engaged Bangladesh's interim government from 16 August 2024 and pressed for early inclusive elections on 20 August 2025, parliamentary elections were held on 12 February 2026, and the 1996 Ganga Waters Treaty expires in December 2026 with India stating on 13 February 2026 that renewal talks had not begun; the owners classify this evidence exactly as engagement plus an election fact plus a treaty-expiry fact and no renewed treaty, which makes it the cleanest available test of whether Neighbourhood First engagement attaches to a state rather than to an incumbent government.
- India welcomed the interim government led by Sushila Karki on 12 September 2025 after the unrest of September 2025, elections were held on 5 March 2026, and the understanding on importing ten thousand megawatts over ten

years dates from 2 June 2023; the owners classify this as political engagement plus an agreed power-trade target and record expressly that it is not a revised Treaty of 1950, so an answer must not convert an energy-trade understanding into a renegotiated foundational treaty, and must read the sequence alongside Bangladesh and Sri Lanka as three simultaneous transition tests inside a single cycle.

- The owners state that neighbourhood policy success is not measured by the number of agreements signed but by whether connectivity and development commitments are delivered and sustained across changes of government in the partner state, and they add the outside-power variable through Sikri's period-specific critique that India's policy on Pakistan, Bangladesh, Nepal and Sri Lanka was being guided by the United States and that the government of the day seemed to have outsourced its South Asia policy, which must be cited as a dated author-specific argument about the risk of external-power involvement rather than as a description of current policy; on ownership the ledgers route one Mains demand from 2022 General Studies Paper II and four objective demands, namely 2020 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 64 on India's trade with Sri Lanka, Bangladesh and Nepal, 2023 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 10 on regional connectivity projects including the Trilateral Highway and the Bangladesh-China-India-Myanmar corridor, and 2026 Prelims General Studies Paper I questions 61 and 67 on cross-border bridges with Bangladesh, Myanmar and Nepal and on development-assistance projects matched with neighbouring partner countries and locations, with no option or answer recorded or inferred for any of them.

Qualified conclusion: Durability is the real test because a regime-oriented relationship discontinues whenever the incumbent changes, so the examination must state Sikri's people-to-people prescription, use the Bangladesh, Nepal and Sri Lanka transitions of a single cycle as the dated evidence, and qualify the prescription as a partial mitigation rather than a guarantee.

Demand decoding: The directive **examine** requires a direct position on "Examine why the durability of India's neighbourhood engagement is tested by political...", every clause, bilateral/regional/systemic mapping, interests and constraints, objective-instrument-implementation-outcome separation, named Indian evidence, trade-offs, alternatives, implementation risks and a qualified conclusion.

Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

Introduction and thesis: Durability is the real test because a regime-oriented relationship discontinues whenever the incumbent changes, so the examination must state Sikri's people-to-people prescription, use the Bangladesh, Nepal and Sri Lanka transitions of a single cycle as the dated evidence, and qualify the prescription as a partial mitigation rather than a guarantee.

Analytical body:

1. **Claim and named evidence:** Sikri argues that India must move away from its excessive regime-oriented policies towards people-to-people relations on the reasoning that only neighbouring regimes which reflect their own people's interests are likely to sustain friendly relations with India, and the owners convert this into the operative test of Neighbourhood First, namely whether engagement survives a change of government in the partner state; the regime-orientation trap emerges when engagement depends too heavily on one incumbent, producing discontinuity whenever that incumbent changes, and the people-to-people reorientation is presented as a partial mitigation rather than a guarantee. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.
2. **Claim and named evidence:** India engaged Bangladesh's interim government from 16 August 2024 and pressed for early inclusive elections on 20 August 2025, parliamentary elections were held on 12 February 2026, and the 1996 Ganga Waters Treaty expires in December 2026 with India stating on 13 February 2026 that renewal talks had not begun; the owners classify this evidence exactly as engagement plus an election fact plus a treaty-expiry fact and no renewed treaty, which makes it the cleanest available test of whether Neighbourhood First engagement attaches to a state rather than to an incumbent government. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.

3. **Claim and named evidence:** India welcomed the interim government led by Sushila Karki on 12 September 2025 after the unrest of September 2025, elections were held on 5 March 2026, and the understanding on importing ten thousand megawatts over ten years dates from 2 June 2023; the owners classify this as political engagement plus an agreed power-trade target and record expressly that it is not a revised Treaty of 1950, so an answer must not convert an energy-trade understanding into a renegotiated foundational treaty, and must read the sequence alongside Bangladesh and Sri Lanka as three simultaneous transition tests inside a single cycle.

Analysis: Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.

4. **Claim and named evidence:** The owners state that neighbourhood policy success is not measured by the number of agreements signed but by whether connectivity and development commitments are delivered and sustained across changes of government in the partner state, and they add the outside-power variable through Sikri's period-specific critique that India's policy on Pakistan, Bangladesh, Nepal and Sri Lanka was being guided by the United States and that the government of the day seemed to have outsourced its South Asia policy, which must be cited as a dated author-specific argument about the risk of external-power involvement rather than as a description of current policy; on ownership the ledgers route one Mains demand from 2022 General Studies Paper II and four objective demands, namely 2020 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 64 on India's trade with Sri Lanka, Bangladesh and Nepal, 2023 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 10 on regional connectivity projects including the Trilateral Highway and the Bangladesh-China-India-Myanmar corridor, and 2026 Prelims General Studies Paper I questions 61 and 67 on cross-border bridges with Bangladesh, Myanmar and Nepal and on development-assistance projects matched with neighbouring partner countries and locations, with no option or answer recorded or inferred for any of them. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.

Counter-position / limit: A doctrine label, summit declaration, signed document, project announcement, military exercise, trade change or diplomatic statement cannot alone establish binding obligation, operational delivery or strategic outcome; test legal character, implementation, partner response, alternatives and evidence status.

Qualified conclusion: Durability is the real test because a regime-oriented relationship discontinues whenever the incumbent changes, so the examination must state Sikri's people-to-people prescription, use the Bangladesh, Nepal and Sri Lanka transitions of a single cycle as the dated evidence, and qualify the prescription as a partial mitigation rather than a guarantee.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For 10 marks, spend one-sixth of the time decoding the directive and drawing level -> interest -> instrument -> implementation -> outcome -> alternative; state a thesis; write four to seven claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification points; reserve the final minute for source, date, membership, operative status, partner agency, causation, escalation and residual risk.

Why this earns marks: The answer obeys the directive, explains strategy and implementation rather than listing visits or groupings, uses named India-centric evidence and preserves institutional, status, level, causal and geopolitical distinctions.

How to improve this answer: For "Examine why the durability of India's neighbourhood engagement is tested by political...", replace the weakest event-list point with one named actor, interest, instrument, implementation bottleneck, measurable outcome, alternative and source-date-status qualification.

ORIGINAL MAINS 3 - 15 MARKS

Question: Examine the observation that regional-framework cooperation appeals more to India's smaller neighbours than purely bilateral engagement. Answer in about 250 words.

Model thesis: The preference is structural rather than tactical because numbers supply reassurance against asymmetry, so the examination must state Sikri's finding, distinguish smaller from larger neighbours, and qualify it with the fact that substantive connectivity work still proceeds bilaterally while the regional overlay supplies political reassurance.

Claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification:

- Sikri records that smaller neighbours like Bhutan, Nepal, Maldives and Sri Lanka have shown greater interest in economic integration with India than the larger ones like Pakistan and Bangladesh, and that they are more receptive to cooperation within a regional framework than on a bilateral basis because numbers give them a sense of greater security, which the owners treat as a structural rather than merely tactical preference; the necessary qualification is that this preference does not amount to rejecting bilateral engagement, because the substantive connectivity work still proceeds bilaterally while the regional overlay supplies political reassurance.
- India is larger in economy, population and military capacity than its entire immediate neighbourhood combined, and the owners treat this asymmetry as the structural condition that shapes how smaller states balance cooperation with India against anxiety about dependence, so the Gujral Doctrine is best read as a response to that anxiety rather than as generosity for its own sake; the analytical move that raises an answer is to treat asymmetry as a design problem to be converted into reliable public goods, instead of treating size disparity as inherently adversarial.
- Tharoor counts Pakistan, China, Nepal, Bhutan, Bangladesh, Myanmar, Sri Lanka and Maldives as sharing a land or maritime border with India, and adds Afghanistan as a near-neighbour because Pakistan's capture in 1948 of a strip of north-western Kashmir made Afghanistan territorially adjacent, and he separately records that of the eight bordering states there has been a history of problems, of varying degrees of difficulty, with six; the examinable consequence is that neighbourhood in Indian strategic practice is defined by security relevance and not only by strict territorial contiguity, and that friction is a structural feature rather than an aberration.
- The Akhaura-Agartala cross-border rail link was inaugurated on 1 November 2023, complementing restored rail, inland-waterway, road and power links, and the Bangladesh, Bhutan, India and Nepal Motor Vehicles Agreement was signed in 2015 to facilitate cross-border passenger and cargo movement; the owners attach a limitation to each, namely that customs, trans-shipment, domestic politics and last-mile infrastructure determine actual use of a rail link, and that Bhutan's non-ratification has constrained four-country implementation of the Motor Vehicles Agreement, so subregionalism progresses where SAARC-wide consensus is unavailable but does not by itself deliver seamless movement.

Qualified conclusion: The preference is structural rather than tactical because numbers supply reassurance against asymmetry, so the examination must state Sikri's finding, distinguish smaller from larger neighbours, and qualify it with the fact that substantive connectivity work still proceeds bilaterally while the regional overlay supplies political reassurance.

Demand decoding: The directive **examine** requires a direct position on "Examine the observation that regional-framework cooperation appeals more to India's smaller...", every clause, bilateral/regional/systemic mapping, interests and constraints, objective-instrument-implementation-outcome separation, named Indian evidence, trade-offs, alternatives, implementation risks and a qualified conclusion.

Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

Introduction and thesis: The preference is structural rather than tactical because numbers supply reassurance against asymmetry, so the examination must state Sikri's finding, distinguish smaller from larger neighbours, and qualify it with the fact that substantive connectivity work still proceeds bilaterally while the regional overlay supplies political reassurance.

Analytical body:

1. **Claim and named evidence:** Sikri records that smaller neighbours like Bhutan, Nepal, Maldives and Sri Lanka have shown greater interest in economic integration with India than the larger ones like Pakistan and Bangladesh, and that they are more receptive to cooperation within a regional framework than on a bilateral basis because

numbers give them a sense of greater security, which the owners treat as a structural rather than merely tactical preference; the necessary qualification is that this preference does not amount to rejecting bilateral engagement, because the substantive connectivity work still proceeds bilaterally while the regional overlay supplies political reassurance. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence.

Qualification: State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.

2. **Claim and named evidence:** India is larger in economy, population and military capacity than its entire immediate neighbourhood combined, and the owners treat this asymmetry as the structural condition that shapes how smaller states balance cooperation with India against anxiety about dependence, so the Gujral Doctrine is best read as a response to that anxiety rather than as generosity for its own sake; the analytical move that raises an answer is to treat asymmetry as a design problem to be converted into reliable public goods, instead of treating size disparity as inherently adversarial. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.
3. **Claim and named evidence:** Tharoor counts Pakistan, China, Nepal, Bhutan, Bangladesh, Myanmar, Sri Lanka and Maldives as sharing a land or maritime border with India, and adds Afghanistan as a near-neighbour because Pakistan's capture in 1948 of a strip of north-western Kashmir made Afghanistan territorially adjacent, and he separately records that of the eight bordering states there has been a history of problems, of varying degrees of difficulty, with six; the examinable consequence is that neighbourhood in Indian strategic practice is defined by security relevance and not only by strict territorial contiguity, and that friction is a structural feature rather than an aberration. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.
4. **Claim and named evidence:** The Akhaura-Agartala cross-border rail link was inaugurated on 1 November 2023, complementing restored rail, inland-waterway, road and power links, and the Bangladesh, Bhutan, India and Nepal Motor Vehicles Agreement was signed in 2015 to facilitate cross-border passenger and cargo movement; the owners attach a limitation to each, namely that customs, trans-shipment, domestic politics and last-mile infrastructure determine actual use of a rail link, and that Bhutan's non-ratification has constrained four-country implementation of the Motor Vehicles Agreement, so subregionalism progresses where SAARC-wide consensus is unavailable but does not by itself deliver seamless movement. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.

Counter-position / limit: A doctrine label, summit declaration, signed document, project announcement, military exercise, trade change or diplomatic statement cannot alone establish binding obligation, operational delivery or strategic outcome; test legal character, implementation, partner response, alternatives and evidence status.

Qualified conclusion: The preference is structural rather than tactical because numbers supply reassurance against asymmetry, so the examination must state Sikri's finding, distinguish smaller from larger neighbours, and qualify it with the fact that substantive connectivity work still proceeds bilaterally while the regional overlay supplies political reassurance.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For 15 marks, spend one-sixth of the time decoding the directive and drawing level -> interest -> instrument -> implementation -> outcome -> alternative; state a thesis; write four to seven claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification points; reserve the final minute for source, date, membership, operative status, partner agency, causation, escalation and residual risk.

Why this earns marks: The answer obeys the directive, explains strategy and implementation rather than listing visits or groupings, uses named India-centric evidence and preserves institutional, status, level, causal and geopolitical distinctions.

How to improve this answer: For "Examine the observation that regional-framework cooperation appeals more to India's smaller...", replace the weakest event-list point with one named actor, interest, instrument, implementation bottleneck, measurable outcome, alternative and source-date-status qualification.

ORIGINAL MAINS 4 - 15 MARKS

Question: Examine the implementation-credibility gap in India's neighbourhood connectivity and development commitments. Answer in about 250 words.

Model thesis: The gap is typically between a segment delivered and a corridor completed rather than between announcement and inaction, so the examination must date the Akhaura-Agartala link, the Kaladan waterway and port, the Sri Lanka memoranda and the Bhutan commitments, and close by naming the specific mechanism that stalled each one.

Claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification:

- The Akhaura-Agartala cross-border rail link was inaugurated on 1 November 2023, complementing restored rail, inland-waterway, road and power links, and the Bangladesh, Bhutan, India and Nepal Motor Vehicles Agreement was signed in 2015 to facilitate cross-border passenger and cargo movement; the owners attach a limitation to each, namely that customs, trans-shipment, domestic politics and last-mile infrastructure determine actual use of a rail link, and that Bhutan's non-ratification has constrained four-country implementation of the Motor Vehicles Agreement, so subregionalism progresses where SAARC-wide consensus is unavailable but does not by itself deliver seamless movement.
- The Kaladan Multi-Modal Transit Transport Project and the India-Myanmar-Thailand Trilateral Highway aim to connect India's Northeast with Myanmar and Southeast Asia, and the owners record that on Kaladan the waterway and Sittwe Port were operationalised in May 2023 while the road component lagged, with both sides still calling for completion on 1 June 2026; the recorded reading is that the real gap in neighbourhood infrastructure is typically between a segment delivered and a corridor completed rather than between announcement and total inaction, and that conflict, incomplete road segments and border procedures mean an announced corridor is not seamless connectivity.
- During the Prime Minister's visit of 5 April 2025 seven memoranda of understanding were exchanged with Sri Lanka, covering high-voltage direct-current power interconnection, digital transformation, the India-Sri Lanka-United Arab Emirates Trincomalee energy hub, defence cooperation, Eastern Province grant assistance, health and medicine, and pharmacopoeial cooperation, and the Ministry of External Affairs bilateral brief on India-Sri Lanka was current to July 2026; the owners fix the evidentiary level precisely, recording that signed memoranda are not proof that each project is operational and that the 120 megawatt Sampur solar project had its ground-breaking rather than its commissioning, while the same visit inaugurated five thousand rooftop solar units and a warehouse.
- The 720 megawatt Mangdechhu project was commissioned in 2019 and handed over to Bhutan in 2022, illustrating joint project delivery and electricity trade that links Bhutanese revenue to Indian clean-power access, and the owners record India's commitment of one hundred billion Indian rupees, equivalently ten thousand crore rupees, for Bhutan's thirteenth Five Year Plan covering 2024 to 2029, a rail-link memorandum of understanding of 29 September 2025 for the Kokrajhar-Gelephu and Banarhat-Samtse links, and support for Gelephu Mindfulness City expressed on 12 November 2025; the evidentiary boundary is that these are a commitment, a memorandum and political support rather than commissioned rail links or an operating city, and that project delay, cost escalation, ecological effects and Bhutan's diversification concerns require balance.

Qualified conclusion: The gap is typically between a segment delivered and a corridor completed rather than between announcement and inaction, so the examination must date the Akhaura-Agartala link, the Kaladan waterway and port, the Sri Lanka memoranda and the Bhutan commitments, and close by naming the specific mechanism that stalled each one.

Demand decoding: The directive **examine** requires a direct position on "Examine the implementation-credibility gap in India's neighbourhood connectivity and...", every clause, bilateral/regional/systemic mapping, interests and constraints, objective-instrument-implementation-outcome separation, named Indian evidence, trade-offs, alternatives, implementation risks and a qualified conclusion.

Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

Introduction and thesis: The gap is typically between a segment delivered and a corridor completed rather than between announcement and inaction, so the examination must date the Akhaura-Agartala link, the Kaladan waterway and port, the Sri Lanka memoranda and the Bhutan commitments, and close by naming the specific mechanism that stalled each one.

Analytical body:

1. **Claim and named evidence:** The Akhaura-Agartala cross-border rail link was inaugurated on 1 November 2023, complementing restored rail, inland-waterway, road and power links, and the Bangladesh, Bhutan, India and Nepal Motor Vehicles Agreement was signed in 2015 to facilitate cross-border passenger and cargo movement; the owners attach a limitation to each, namely that customs, trans-shipment, domestic politics and last-mile infrastructure determine actual use of a rail link, and that Bhutan's non-ratification has constrained four-country implementation of the Motor Vehicles Agreement, so subregionalism progresses where SAARC-wide consensus is unavailable but does not by itself deliver seamless movement. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.
2. **Claim and named evidence:** The Kaladan Multi-Modal Transit Transport Project and the India-Myanmar-Thailand Trilateral Highway aim to connect India's Northeast with Myanmar and Southeast Asia, and the owners record that on Kaladan the waterway and Sittwe Port were operationalised in May 2023 while the road component lagged, with both sides still calling for completion on 1 June 2026; the recorded reading is that the real gap in neighbourhood infrastructure is typically between a segment delivered and a corridor completed rather than between announcement and total inaction, and that conflict, incomplete road segments and border procedures mean an announced corridor is not seamless connectivity. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.
3. **Claim and named evidence:** During the Prime Minister's visit of 5 April 2025 seven memoranda of understanding were exchanged with Sri Lanka, covering high-voltage direct-current power interconnection, digital transformation, the India-Sri Lanka-United Arab Emirates Trincomalee energy hub, defence cooperation, Eastern Province grant assistance, health and medicine, and pharmacopoeial cooperation, and the Ministry of External Affairs bilateral brief on India-Sri Lanka was current to July 2026; the owners fix the evidentiary level precisely, recording that signed memoranda are not proof that each project is operational and that the 120 megawatt Sampur solar project had its ground-breaking rather than its commissioning, while the same visit inaugurated five thousand rooftop solar units and a warehouse. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.
4. **Claim and named evidence:** The 720 megawatt Mangdechhu project was commissioned in 2019 and handed over to Bhutan in 2022, illustrating joint project delivery and electricity trade that links Bhutanese revenue to Indian clean-power access, and the owners record India's commitment of one hundred billion Indian rupees, equivalently ten thousand crore rupees, for Bhutan's thirteenth Five Year Plan covering 2024 to 2029, a rail-link memorandum of understanding of 29 September 2025 for the Kokrajhar-Gelephu and Banarhat-Samtse links, and support for Gelephu Mindfulness City expressed on 12 November 2025; the evidentiary boundary is that these are a commitment, a memorandum and political support rather than commissioned rail links or an operating city, and that project delay, cost escalation, ecological effects and Bhutan's diversification concerns require balance. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.

Counter-position / limit: A doctrine label, summit declaration, signed document, project announcement, military exercise, trade change or diplomatic statement cannot alone establish binding obligation, operational delivery or

strategic outcome; test legal character, implementation, partner response, alternatives and evidence status.

Qualified conclusion: The gap is typically between a segment delivered and a corridor completed rather than between announcement and inaction, so the examination must date the Akhaura-Agartala link, the Kaladan waterway and port, the Sri Lanka memoranda and the Bhutan commitments, and close by naming the specific mechanism that stalled each one.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For 15 marks, spend one-sixth of the time decoding the directive and drawing level -> interest -> instrument -> implementation -> outcome -> alternative; state a thesis; write four to seven claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification points; reserve the final minute for source, date, membership, operative status, partner agency, causation, escalation and residual risk.

Why this earns marks: The answer obeys the directive, explains strategy and implementation rather than listing visits or groupings, uses named India-centric evidence and preserves institutional, status, level, causal and geopolitical distinctions.

How to improve this answer: For "Examine the implementation-credibility gap in India's neighbourhood connectivity and...", replace the weakest event-list point with one named actor, interest, instrument, implementation bottleneck, measurable outcome, alternative and source-date-status qualification.

ORIGINAL MAINS 5 - 20 MARKS

Question: Assess how India's neighbourhood doctrine performs when water-sharing and security conditions are linked. Answer in about 300 words.

Model thesis: Non-reciprocal accommodation is least stable where the shared resource is finite, so the assessment must separate the executive abeyance decision from treaty termination, date the Ganga Waters Treaty expiry and the state of renewal talks, add the Teesta federal constraint as the domestic mirror of the same problem, and end with a graded verdict rather than a prediction.

Claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification:

- The Cabinet Committee on Security decided on 23 April 2025 that the Indus Waters Treaty of 1960 will be held in abeyance with immediate effect until Pakistan credibly and irrevocably abjures its support for cross-border terrorism, Operation Sindoor was described officially on 7 May 2025 as measured, non-escalatory, proportionate, and responsible, and on 10 May 2025 India recorded an understanding to stop all military activities, while India separately maintains that the Court of Arbitration seized of the matter is illegally constituted and its awards null and void, a position restated on 16 May 2026; the owners fix the classification as an executive decision plus an operation plus an understanding, expressly not treaty termination and not a formal ceasefire agreement, and they draw the doctrinal point that non-reciprocal accommodation is least stable where the shared resource is finite, since it can be withdrawn when linked to a security condition.
- India engaged Bangladesh's interim government from 16 August 2024 and pressed for early inclusive elections on 20 August 2025, parliamentary elections were held on 12 February 2026, and the 1996 Ganga Waters Treaty expires in December 2026 with India stating on 13 February 2026 that renewal talks had not begun; the owners classify this evidence exactly as engagement plus an election fact plus a treaty-expiry fact and no renewed treaty, which makes it the cleanest available test of whether Neighbourhood First engagement attaches to a state rather than to an incumbent government.
- The unresolved Teesta water-sharing issue demonstrates how Indian state-level interests can constrain a bilateral agreement with Bangladesh, and the owners draw the general lesson that neighbourhood diplomacy is shaped by domestic federal and border stakeholders rather than by the external ministry alone; the qualification carried with it is equally examinable, namely that one dispute should not be allowed to erase the wider record of connectivity and security cooperation, so the correct treatment is to name the federal constraint as a specific limiting mechanism instead of generalising it into a verdict on the whole relationship.
- The Gujral Doctrine, associated with former Prime Minister I. K. Gujral, is a five-principle approach under which India does not seek reciprocity from smaller neighbours, does not interfere in their internal affairs, does not allow its territory to be used against them, respects their territorial integrity, and settles disputes bilaterally and peacefully, and it remains the standard doctrinal reference for South Asia policy; the defining feature that examiners test is non-reciprocal accommodation, so any statement that the doctrine demands reciprocity as a

precondition for cooperation inverts its meaning exactly.

Qualified conclusion: Non-reciprocal accommodation is least stable where the shared resource is finite, so the assessment must separate the executive abeyance decision from treaty termination, date the Ganga Waters Treaty expiry and the state of renewal talks, add the Teesta federal constraint as the domestic mirror of the same problem, and end with a graded verdict rather than a prediction.

Demand decoding: The directive **assess** requires a direct position on "Assess how India's neighbourhood doctrine performs when water-sharing and security conditions...", every clause, bilateral/regional/systemic mapping, interests and constraints, objective-instrument-implementation-outcome separation, named Indian evidence, trade-offs, alternatives, implementation risks and a qualified conclusion.

Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

Introduction and thesis: Non-reciprocal accommodation is least stable where the shared resource is finite, so the assessment must separate the executive abeyance decision from treaty termination, date the Ganga Waters Treaty expiry and the state of renewal talks, add the Teesta federal constraint as the domestic mirror of the same problem, and end with a graded verdict rather than a prediction.

Analytical body:

- 1. Claim and named evidence:** The Cabinet Committee on Security decided on 23 April 2025 that the Indus Waters Treaty of 1960 will be held in abeyance with immediate effect until Pakistan credibly and irrevocably abjures its support for cross-border terrorism, Operation Sindoor was described officially on 7 May 2025 as measured, non-escalatory, proportionate, and responsible, and on 10 May 2025 India recorded an understanding to stop all military activities, while India separately maintains that the Court of Arbitration seized of the matter is illegally constituted and its awards null and void, a position restated on 16 May 2026; the owners fix the classification as an executive decision plus an operation plus an understanding, expressly not treaty termination and not a formal ceasefire agreement, and they draw the doctrinal point that non-reciprocal accommodation is least stable where the shared resource is finite, since it can be withdrawn when linked to a security condition.

Analysis: Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.
- 2. Claim and named evidence:** India engaged Bangladesh's interim government from 16 August 2024 and pressed for early inclusive elections on 20 August 2025, parliamentary elections were held on 12 February 2026, and the 1996 Ganga Waters Treaty expires in December 2026 with India stating on 13 February 2026 that renewal talks had not begun; the owners classify this evidence exactly as engagement plus an election fact plus a treaty-expiry fact and no renewed treaty, which makes it the cleanest available test of whether Neighbourhood First engagement attaches to a state rather than to an incumbent government. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.
- 3. Claim and named evidence:** The unresolved Teesta water-sharing issue demonstrates how Indian state-level interests can constrain a bilateral agreement with Bangladesh, and the owners draw the general lesson that neighbourhood diplomacy is shaped by domestic federal and border stakeholders rather than by the external ministry alone; the qualification carried with it is equally examinable, namely that one dispute should not be allowed to erase the wider record of connectivity and security cooperation, so the correct treatment is to name the federal constraint as a specific limiting mechanism instead of generalising it into a verdict on the whole relationship. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.
- 4. Claim and named evidence:** The Gujral Doctrine, associated with former Prime Minister I. K. Gujral, is a five-principle approach under which India does not seek reciprocity from smaller neighbours, does not interfere in their internal affairs, does not allow its territory to be used against them, respects their territorial integrity, and

settles disputes bilaterally and peacefully, and it remains the standard doctrinal reference for South Asia policy; the defining feature that examiners test is non-reciprocal accommodation, so any statement that the doctrine demands reciprocity as a precondition for cooperation inverts its meaning exactly. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.

Counter-position / limit: A doctrine label, summit declaration, signed document, project announcement, military exercise, trade change or diplomatic statement cannot alone establish binding obligation, operational delivery or strategic outcome; test legal character, implementation, partner response, alternatives and evidence status.

Qualified conclusion: Non-reciprocal accommodation is least stable where the shared resource is finite, so the assessment must separate the executive abeyance decision from treaty termination, date the Ganga Waters Treaty expiry and the state of renewal talks, add the Teesta federal constraint as the domestic mirror of the same problem, and end with a graded verdict rather than a prediction.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For 20 marks, spend one-sixth of the time decoding the directive and drawing level -> interest -> instrument -> implementation -> outcome -> alternative; state a thesis; write four to seven claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification points; reserve the final minute for source, date, membership, operative status, partner agency, causation, escalation and residual risk.

Why this earns marks: The answer obeys the directive, explains strategy and implementation rather than listing visits or groupings, uses named India-centric evidence and preserves institutional, status, level, causal and geopolitical distinctions.

How to improve this answer: For "Assess how India's neighbourhood doctrine performs when water-sharing and security conditions...", replace the weakest event-list point with one named actor, interest, instrument, implementation bottleneck, measurable outcome, alternative and source-date-status qualification.

ORIGINAL MAINS 6 - 20 MARKS

Question: Assess India's role in Sri Lanka's 2022 crisis as a test of first-responder credibility and durable partnership. Answer in about 300 words.

Model thesis: Emergency credibility and durable partnership are different claims, so the assessment must itemise the dated 2022 assistance with its time period, separate it from the pre-delivery instruments of 2025, acknowledge Sri Lankan agency and the structural constraints that emergency financing could not remove, and close with the implementation-credibility test.

Claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification:

- By 3 May 2022 India's High Commission recorded more than three billion United States dollars in assistance during 2022, comprising a one billion dollar facility for food, medicines and essentials, a five hundred million dollar petroleum credit line, about one billion dollars in Asian Clearing Union payment deferment and a four hundred million dollar Reserve Bank of India currency swap, while the petroleum line had delivered close to four hundred thousand tonnes of fuel across all twenty-five districts and the essentials facility had supplied rice and other necessities with medical consignments providing a humanitarian component; the owners require the aggregate to be time-bounded, since full-year descriptions commonly place support at around four billion dollars over 2022, and they record the limitation that emergency financing did not remove Sri Lanka's structural debt, revenue, governance and external-financing problems, whose durable resolution required domestic adjustment and an International Monetary Fund-supported programme.
- During the Prime Minister's visit of 5 April 2025 seven memoranda of understanding were exchanged with Sri Lanka, covering high-voltage direct-current power interconnection, digital transformation, the India-Sri Lanka-United Arab Emirates Trincomalee energy hub, defence cooperation, Eastern Province grant assistance, health and medicine, and pharmacopoeial cooperation, and the Ministry of External Affairs bilateral brief on India-Sri Lanka was current to July 2026; the owners fix the evidentiary level precisely, recording that signed memoranda are not proof that each project is operational and that the 120 megawatt Sampur solar project had its ground-breaking rather than its commissioning, while the same visit inaugurated five thousand rooftop solar units

and a warehouse.

- The owners state that neighbourhood policy success is not measured by the number of agreements signed but by whether connectivity and development commitments are delivered and sustained across changes of government in the partner state, and they add the outside-power variable through Sikri's period-specific critique that India's policy on Pakistan, Bangladesh, Nepal and Sri Lanka was being guided by the United States and that the government of the day seemed to have outsourced its South Asia policy, which must be cited as a dated author-specific argument about the risk of external-power involvement rather than as a description of current policy; on ownership the ledgers route one Mains demand from 2022 General Studies Paper II and four objective demands, namely 2020 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 64 on India's trade with Sri Lanka, Bangladesh and Nepal, 2023 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 10 on regional connectivity projects including the Trilateral Highway and the Bangladesh-China-India-Myanmar corridor, and 2026 Prelims General Studies Paper I questions 61 and 67 on cross-border bridges with Bangladesh, Myanmar and Nepal and on development-assistance projects matched with neighbouring partner countries and locations, with no option or answer recorded or inferred for any of them.
- This topic owns India's engagement with Bangladesh, Bhutan, Nepal, Sri Lanka, Myanmar, Pakistan and Afghanistan, together with the Neighbourhood First policy, the Gujral Doctrine, and the development, connectivity and people-to-people instruments that carry them, and its distinctive feature is that it is simultaneously doctrinal and heavily evidence-bound: one General Studies Paper II Mains demand from 2022 is routed to it in the audited ledgers alongside four objective demands from 2020, 2023 and 2026; Maldives is deliberately cross-linked to topic 04 because its salience is primarily maritime, the SAARC and BIMSTEC institutional comparison is reserved for topic 10, and the physical border and route geography belongs to the Geography owner.

Qualified conclusion: Emergency credibility and durable partnership are different claims, so the assessment must itemise the dated 2022 assistance with its time period, separate it from the pre-delivery instruments of 2025, acknowledge Sri Lankan agency and the structural constraints that emergency financing could not remove, and close with the implementation-credibility test.

Demand decoding: The directive **assess** requires a direct position on "Assess India's role in Sri Lanka's 2022 crisis as a test of first-responder credibility and...", every clause, bilateral/regional/systemic mapping, interests and constraints, objective-instrument-implementation-outcome separation, named Indian evidence, trade-offs, alternatives, implementation risks and a qualified conclusion.

Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

Introduction and thesis: Emergency credibility and durable partnership are different claims, so the assessment must itemise the dated 2022 assistance with its time period, separate it from the pre-delivery instruments of 2025, acknowledge Sri Lankan agency and the structural constraints that emergency financing could not remove, and close with the implementation-credibility test.

Analytical body:

1. **Claim and named evidence:** By 3 May 2022 India's High Commission recorded more than three billion United States dollars in assistance during 2022, comprising a one billion dollar facility for food, medicines and essentials, a five hundred million dollar petroleum credit line, about one billion dollars in Asian Clearing Union payment deferment and a four hundred million dollar Reserve Bank of India currency swap, while the petroleum line had delivered close to four hundred thousand tonnes of fuel across all twenty-five districts and the essentials facility had supplied rice and other necessities with medical consignments providing a humanitarian component; the owners require the aggregate to be time-bounded, since full-year descriptions commonly place support at around four billion dollars over 2022, and they record the limitation that emergency financing did not remove Sri Lanka's structural debt, revenue, governance and external-financing problems, whose durable resolution required domestic adjustment and an International Monetary Fund-supported programme. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.
2. **Claim and named evidence:** During the Prime Minister's visit of 5 April 2025 seven memoranda of understanding were exchanged with Sri Lanka, covering high-voltage direct-current power interconnection, digital

transformation, the India-Sri Lanka-United Arab Emirates Trincomalee energy hub, defence cooperation, Eastern Province grant assistance, health and medicine, and pharmacopoeial cooperation, and the Ministry of External Affairs bilateral brief on India-Sri Lanka was current to July 2026; the owners fix the evidentiary level precisely, recording that signed memoranda are not proof that each project is operational and that the 120 megawatt Sampur solar project had its ground-breaking rather than its commissioning, while the same visit inaugurated five thousand rooftop solar units and a warehouse. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.

3. **Claim and named evidence:** The owners state that neighbourhood policy success is not measured by the number of agreements signed but by whether connectivity and development commitments are delivered and sustained across changes of government in the partner state, and they add the outside-power variable through Sikri's period-specific critique that India's policy on Pakistan, Bangladesh, Nepal and Sri Lanka was being guided by the United States and that the government of the day seemed to have outsourced its South Asia policy, which must be cited as a dated author-specific argument about the risk of external-power involvement rather than as a description of current policy; on ownership the ledgers route one Mains demand from 2022 General Studies Paper II and four objective demands, namely 2020 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 64 on India's trade with Sri Lanka, Bangladesh and Nepal, 2023 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 10 on regional connectivity projects including the Trilateral Highway and the Bangladesh-China-India-Myanmar corridor, and 2026 Prelims General Studies Paper I questions 61 and 67 on cross-border bridges with Bangladesh, Myanmar and Nepal and on development-assistance projects matched with neighbouring partner countries and locations, with no option or answer recorded or inferred for any of them. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.

4. **Claim and named evidence:** This topic owns India's engagement with Bangladesh, Bhutan, Nepal, Sri Lanka, Myanmar, Pakistan and Afghanistan, together with the Neighbourhood First policy, the Gujral Doctrine, and the development, connectivity and people-to-people instruments that carry them, and its distinctive feature is that it is simultaneously doctrinal and heavily evidence-bound: one General Studies Paper II Mains demand from 2022 is routed to it in the audited ledgers alongside four objective demands from 2020, 2023 and 2026; Maldives is deliberately cross-linked to topic 04 because its salience is primarily maritime, the SAARC and BIMSTEC institutional comparison is reserved for topic 10, and the physical border and route geography belongs to the Geography owner. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.

Counter-position / limit: A doctrine label, summit declaration, signed document, project announcement, military exercise, trade change or diplomatic statement cannot alone establish binding obligation, operational delivery or strategic outcome; test legal character, implementation, partner response, alternatives and evidence status.

Qualified conclusion: Emergency credibility and durable partnership are different claims, so the assessment must itemise the dated 2022 assistance with its time period, separate it from the pre-delivery instruments of 2025, acknowledge Sri Lankan agency and the structural constraints that emergency financing could not remove, and close with the implementation-credibility test.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For 20 marks, spend one-sixth of the time decoding the directive and drawing level -> interest -> instrument -> implementation -> outcome -> alternative; state a thesis; write four to seven claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification points; reserve the final minute for source, date, membership, operative status, partner agency, causation, escalation and residual risk.

Why this earns marks: The answer obeys the directive, explains strategy and implementation rather than listing visits or groupings, uses named India-centric evidence and preserves institutional, status, level, causal and geopolitical distinctions.

How to improve this answer: For "Assess India's role in Sri Lanka's 2022 crisis as a test of first-responder credibility and...", replace the weakest event-list point with one named actor, interest, instrument, implementation bottleneck, measurable outcome, alternative and source-date-status qualification.